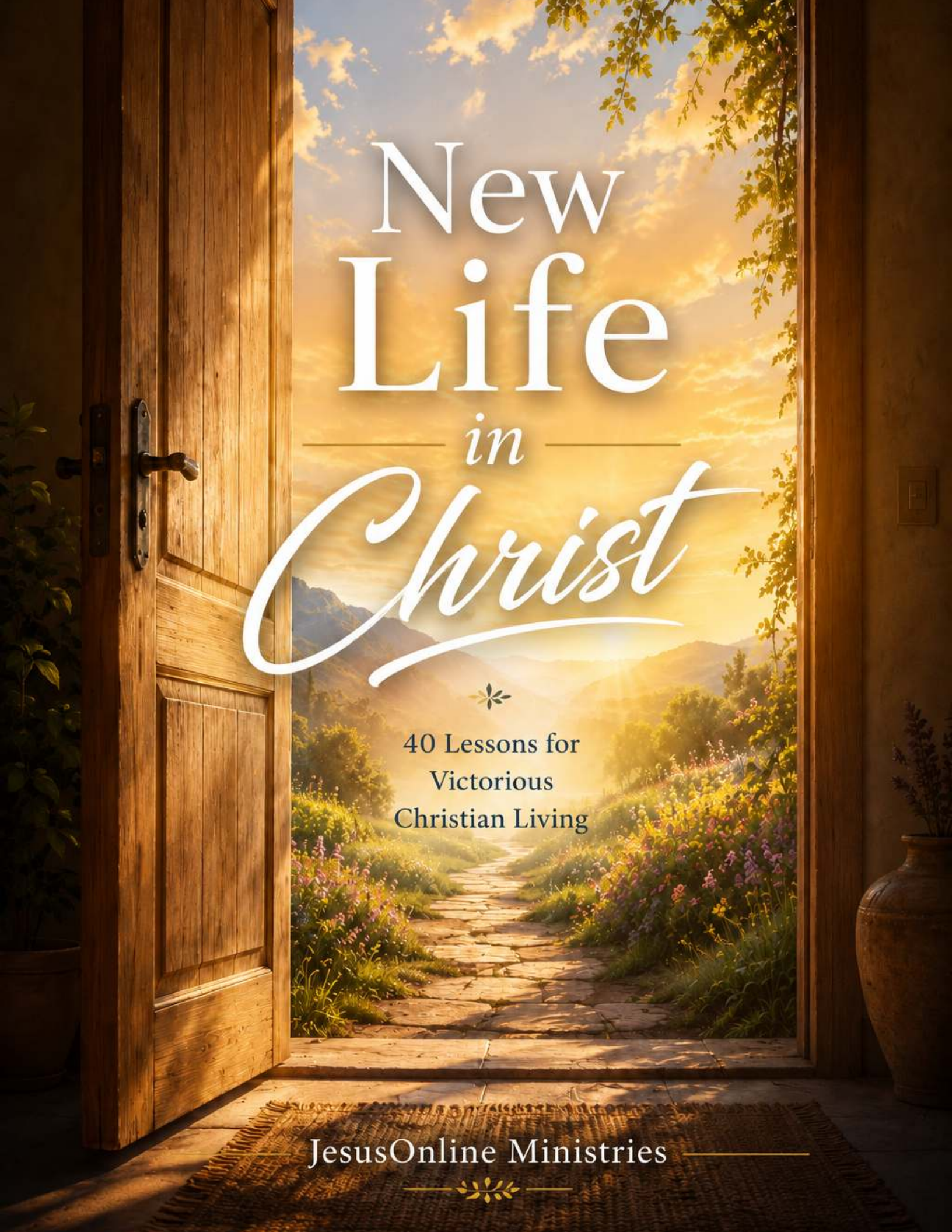




# New Life *in* Christ

40 Lessons for  
Victorious  
Christian Living

JesusOnline Ministries

# New Life in Christ

40 Lessons for Victorious Christian Living



**JesusOnline Ministries**

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## Four Immediate Benefits!

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Okay, so you've asked Jesus Christ to forgive you of your sins and be the Lord of your life! Now what? It is important that you begin to grow in your relationship with God! He is waiting for you to get to know Him better!

**Four wonderful things happen when you first become a Christian:** Your sins are forgiven. You become a child of God. You receive eternal life. And Christ lives in you.

Let's start at the beginning ...

### 1. Your sins are forgiven.

"And even though you were dead in your transgressions and in the uncircumcision of your flesh, he nevertheless made you alive with him, having forgiven all your transgressions." —Colossians 2:13

"But if we walk in the light as he himself is in the light, we have fellowship with one another and the blood of Jesus his Son cleanses us from all sin." —1 John 1:7

Q. How many of your sins are forgiven?

Q. Is there anything about this concept of forgiveness of sins that is hard for you to accept or understand?

**Our sin does not need to haunt us ... God has forgiven us.** 1 John 1:9 instructs us,

"But if we confess our sins, he is faithful and righteous, forgiving us our sins and cleansing us from all unrighteousness."

If you do sin, what should you do? Feel guilty? No, your sins have been forgiven! However, the verse in 1 John tells us that we must *confess* our sins to God. You must agree with God that you have sinned, and thank Him that because of Jesus' death on the cross, you are forgiven!

In today's world, many people do not want to talk about sin. It makes them feel uncomfortable, or sad, or angry, or guilty. But God wants us to confess it to Him, and simply let Him have it! Confess your sin and let it go!

Take a few minutes right now to confess your sin to God ... and then know that He has forgiven you!

## **2. You become a child of God.**

**God's desire is to fill us with the love of a perfect Father.** He knows us intimately and has marvelous plans for us.

"To all who have received him—those who believe in his name—he has given the right to become God's children." —John 1:12

Q. What is your part?

Q. What is God's part?

Paul encourages us with these words,

"Blessed is the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who has blessed us with every spiritual blessing in the heavenly realms in Christ. For he chose us in Christ before the foundation of the world that we should be holy and blameless before him in love. He did this by predestining us to adoption as his legal heirs through Jesus Christ, according to the pleasure of his will—to the praise of the glory of his grace that he has freely bestowed on us in his dearly loved Son. In him we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of our offenses, according to the riches of his grace." —Ephesians 1:3-7

Q. What does it mean to you to know that you are God's child?

## **3. You receive eternal life.**

**When we accept Christ's sacrifice for our sins, we will experience abundant life on earth, and then eternal life continuing in heaven.**

Eternal life ... a life with God forever after we die! Imagine, spending time with God forever! How do we know this? The Bible is very clear!

"For this is the way God loved the world: He gave his one and only Son, so that everyone who believes in him will not perish but have eternal life." —John 3:16

"And this is the testimony: God has given us eternal life, and this life is in his Son. The one who has the Son has this eternal life; the one who does not have the Son of God does not have this eternal life. I have written these things to you who

believe in the name of the Son of God so that you may know that you have eternal life.” —1 John 5:11-13

Q. What do these verses teach you about eternal life?

Q. If you have eternal life today, is it possible for you to lose it tomorrow?

“He [Jesus] has said, ‘I will never leave you and I will never abandon you.’” — Hebrews 13:5

Q. In what way does the verse from Hebrews answer the previous question?

Q. What does this mean to you personally?

#### **4. Christ lives in you!**

The Bible tells about a miraculous event that occurs when we trust Christ for our salvation. He actually comes into our lives and takes up permanent residence.

“So then, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; what is old has passed away—look, what is new has come! And all these things are from God who reconciled us to himself through Christ, and who has given us the ministry of reconciliation.” —2 Corinthians 5:17-18

Q. Is there anything in your life you can already see that is becoming new?

**Being a Christian means you have a relationship with Jesus Christ.** It is not a “religious system” or a list of rules, or an inventory of do’s and don’ts. It is a living faith in a living person, God himself.

Now that Christ is in your life forever, you will want to know Him more intimately, and to please Him by the way you think and live.

“For the love of Christ controls us, since we have concluded this, that Christ died for all; therefore all have died. And he died for all so that those who live should no longer live for themselves but for him who died for them and was raised.” —2 Corinthians 5:14-15

This a very important passage for you to think about!

Q. What are some ways that you have lived for yourself?

Q. What are some ways that you can live for God?

God created us to be His children. He desires us to spend eternity with Him in heaven; however, our sin nature would have prevented that from happening. That is why God sent his only Son Jesus Christ to die on the cross for our sins, in our place, so that we who put our trust in Him can be forgiven.

When we accept Christ's sacrifice for our sins, we will experience abundant life on earth, and then eternal life continuing in heaven. Jesus Christ is the only one who can bring us to God. Those who don't put their faith in Christ will suffer eternal separation from God.

### **Application**

Q. What excites you most about your new life in Christ?

[Next](#)

### **Related Lessons from Series Two: Empowered by Christ**

#### **God's Great Love for You!**

It's hard to imagine that the God of the universe cares about each one of us individually, but it's true! God's love extends to each and every person ... and that includes you!

[\(Go to lesson\)](#)

#### **God's Purpose for Your Life**

Your life matters! God has given you an identity in Christ and has a plan for your life!

[\(Go to lesson\)](#)



## How Can You Be Sure of Your Relationship with Christ?

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When you make the decision to receive Jesus as your personal Savior and Lord, you begin an exciting journey with Christ that will never end. But along the way, you may have some doubts.

Feelings are an unreliable source of security. We must depend on the facts of the Bible to ground our faith in God.

For many of us, the journey with Christ may be long. We have a lot of life yet to live—and some days God will *feel* very far away. How can we remember that our relationship with Christ is secure—no matter what?

Q. When you have uncertainties in your life, what do you tend to rely on to get you through?

### **Facts, Faith, and Feelings**

When it comes to our faith in Christ, three factors play into the overall picture: facts, faith, and feelings. Facts are usually the most stabilizing of the three. Faith is influenced by the facts. And feelings quite often follow. It's important to keep these three factors in the right perspective! Haven't received Christ? The most important decision you will ever make is to receive Jesus Christ as your personal Savior and Lord. We are separated from God because of our wrong choices—our sin. But Jesus Christ came to save us from our sin. ([Read More](#) or [Watch a Video](#))

First of all, the Bible contains several very important *facts* regarding our relationship with Christ.

“Who will separate us from the love of Christ? Will trouble, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness, or danger, or sword? For I am convinced that neither death, nor life, nor angels, nor heavenly rulers, nor things that are present, nor things to come, nor powers, nor height, nor depth, nor anything else in creation will be able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord.” —Romans 8:35, 38-39

“Your conduct must be free from the love of money and you must be content with what you have, for he has said, ‘I will never leave you and I will never abandon you.’” —Hebrews 13:5

“For I will be merciful toward their evil deeds, and their sins I will remember no longer.” —Hebrews 8:12

As God’s child He will always love you—even when you fail Him. He will never give up on you—even if you give up on Him.

Christianity is a relationship with Christ—based on *faith*! And your faith is to be based on the facts in the Bible ... not your feelings! Faith in Christ may result in feelings ... and often does. But feelings are changeable, and you can’t depend upon them. You can only rely on what God says in his Word!

Q. When you have uncertainties in your life, what do you tend to rely on to get you through?

Q. Think about a time when your feelings influenced a major decision in your life ... what was the outcome?

Q. Have you ever made a decision that was based on your feelings that didn’t turn out well, or has someone you know experienced this? What could/should have been done differently?

As God’s child He will always love you—even when you fail Him.

Your feelings are a reaction to specific acts or events in your life. **Relying on feelings can cause much confusion.** If you depend on your feelings and have a very bad day, what might happen to your faith? It is in those times that we can lean on the facts of God’s Word to keep us strong.

People differ in the way they perceive and respond to things. God created each one of us to be an emotional creature by nature. However, each one of us expresses our emotions in different ways! It is important to remember that different personalities respond to God in different ways.

One person may have a high emotional experience, while another individual may be calm and reserved. Because emotions vary greatly, they are not to be depended upon as a source of our security. Depending on emotions—or even seeking an

emotional experience—causes many to lack the assurance of a personal relationship with God. We think that our emotions will give us greater security ... but because they are constantly changing, they actually can make us insecure.

Christianity is a relationship with Christ—based on faith!

The Bible says:

“The righteous by faith will live.” —Romans 1:17

“Now without faith it is impossible to please him, for the one who approaches God must believe that he exists and that he rewards those who seek him.” —Hebrews 11:6

“Whatever is not from faith is sin.” —Romans 14:23

The assurance of our relationship with God is based on the authority of His Word. God loves you and you are His child. When you start to feel as if your relationship with God doesn't exist, go to the facts of the Bible to reinforce your faith in God's love for you. We live by faith in the trustworthiness of God, and His Word. Anchor your faith in the facts of the Bible, and your faith will be strong.

Q. When you have uncertainties in your life, what do you tend to rely on to get you through?

Q. What steps can you take to become more secure in your relationship with God?

## **You Have an Inheritance in Christ**

“And this is the testimony: God has given us eternal life, and this life is in his Son. The one who has the Son has this eternal life; the one who does not have the Son of God does not have this eternal life. I have written these things to you who believe in the name of the Son of God so that you may know that you have eternal life” —1 John 5:11-13

As a Christian, you are granted an inheritance. This inheritance is amazing! The Bible is very clear that when we accept Christ's sacrifice for our sins, we become God's child ... and we receive all of the benefits that go along with that relationship. Listed below are just five of the benefits we receive. As you study the Bible you will discover more of the benefits that you experience as God's child. Faith is another word for trust, and your faith must be placed in God and His Word—not in your feelings.

### **1. You become a child of God—forever.**

“But to all who have received him—those who believe in his name—he has given the right to become God’s children.” —John 1:12

### **2. Your sins are completely forgiven.**

“And even though you were dead in your transgressions and in the uncircumcision of your flesh, he nevertheless made you alive with him, having forgiven all your transgressions. He has destroyed what was against us, a certificate of indebtedness expressed in decrees opposed to us. He has taken it away by nailing it to the cross.” —Colossians 2:13-14

### **3. Christ actually comes into your life.**

“Listen! I am standing at the door and knocking! If anyone hears my voice and opens the door I will come into his home and share a meal with him, and he with me.” —Revelation 3:20

### **4. Christ gives you his nature.**

“So then, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; what is old has passed away—look, what is new has come!” —2 Corinthians 5:17

### **5. The Holy Spirit is your guarantee.**

“But it is God who establishes us together with you in Christ and who anointed us, who also sealed us and gave us the Spirit in our hearts as a down payment.” —2 Corinthians 1:21-22

Memorize one of the verses above to encourage you as you grow in your relationship with God!

### **Samantha’s Story**

Youth leader Samantha Tidball tells how, when she was a teenager, she dated a number of guys and repeatedly found herself bored after a few weeks of dating. She realized that she got an emotional high from the chase—one that wasn’t sustainable. And she says it was sort of the same thing when she first began a relationship with God. When the initial emotional rush was over, she felt empty inside and continued looking for attention elsewhere. She knew God loved her, but she didn’t always feel his love.

She wrote in a blog: “When we accept Christ’s sacrifice for our sins, we become God’s child ... And we receive all of the benefits that go along with that relationship. I have learned that I can’t force a feeling. But I can reflect on what I know, and trust that God truly does love me. I have to trust Jesus meant what He said in 1 John 4:9-10, ‘God showed how much He loved us by sending His one and only Son into the world so that we might have eternal life through Him. This is real love—not that we loved God, but that He loved us and sent His Son as a sacrifice to take away our sins.’ If Jesus died for you and me, then what does that say about our worth? Jesus says, ‘There is no greater love than to lay down one’s life for one’s friends’ (John 15:13). Apparently, God loves us enough to die for us; there is no greater act of love.”

Don’t confuse God’s love with the love you get from people. Love from people often increases with performance and decreases with mistakes. Not so with God’s love: His love comes from who He is and it never changes.

### **Application**

In what ways can you strengthen each of these areas of your life when it comes to your relationship with Christ?

Q. Facts

Q. Faith

Q. Feelings

## Faith: Knowing Who You Can Trust

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“Now without faith it is impossible to please him, for the one who approaches God must believe that he exists and that he rewards those who seek him.” —Hebrews 11:6

Faith is personal reliance on a God known to be trustworthy.

During the terrible days of the Blitz during World War II, a father, holding his small son by the hand, ran from a building that had been struck by a bomb. In the front yard was a shell hole. Seeking shelter as quickly as possible, the father jumped into the hole and held up his arms for his son to follow. Terrified, yet hearing his father’s voice telling him to jump, the boy replied, “I can’t see you!”

The father, looking up against the sky tinted red by the burning buildings, called to the silhouette of his son, “But I can see you ... jump!” The boy jumped ... because he trusted his father. The Christian faith enables us to face life or meet death, not because we can see, but with the certainty that we are seen; not that we know all the answers, but that we are known.

We are emotional creatures by nature. Different personalities respond to God in different ways. One person may have a high emotional experience, while another may be calm and reserved. Faith is another word for trust and in many ways, trust is an emotion. Your faith must be placed in God and His Word, not in your emotions. Emotions can—and will—deceive you. God’s Word never will. Your faith must be placed in God and His Word, not in your emotions. Emotions can—and will—deceive you. God’s Word never will.

The Bible says, “Without faith it is impossible to please Him” (Hebrews 11:6). The assurance of our relationship with God is based on the authority of His Word. God loves you and you are His child. When you start to feel as if your relationship with God doesn’t exist, go to the facts of the Bible to reinforce your faith in God’s love for you. We live by faith in the trustworthiness of God, and His Word. Our faith is anchored in the truth of God’s Word, and in what we know about God’s character.

When you ride in an airplane you are exercising faith in the laws of aerodynamics to overcome gravity. If you should, however somehow decide to step outside of the plane while you are in the air, you will find the law of gravity still in effect! It is not the amount or quality of your faith, but the object of your faith that matters! God



and His Word are the objects of our faith. The better we know God, the more we feel we can trust Him, and the more we trust Him, the more we experience the reality of His love and power.

“For I am convinced that neither death, nor life, nor angels, nor heavenly rulers, nor things that are present, nor things to come, nor powers, nor height, nor depth, nor anything else in creation will be able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord.” —Romans 8:38-39

Our faith is anchored in the truth of God’s Word, and in what we know about God’s character. The better we know God, the more we feel we can trust Him. . . the more we trust God, the more we experience the reality of His love and power.

Q. What do you learn about God in the verses from Romans?

“Now faith is being sure of what we hope for, being convinced of what we do not see.” —Hebrews 11:1

Q. Why is faith so important?

“Jesus said to them, ‘Have faith in God. I tell you the truth, if someone says to this mountain, “Be lifted up and thrown into the sea,” and does not doubt in his heart but believes that what he says will happen, it will be done for him.’” —Mark 11:22-23

Faith is another word for trust. Faith must have an object. We do not have faith in faith. For example, a person could have great faith that the ice on a pond is thick enough to walk on. By faith then, he could boldly walk out on paper thin ice, and his faith would result in an ice water dunking! A person who has a very weak faith may very gingerly step slowly onto a pond of six-foot-thick ice. It is more than enough to support him. The key here is the object of his faith.

Oswald Chambers once said, “Faith is deliberate confidence in the character of God whose ways you may not understand at the time.”

Faith is personal reliance on a God known to be trustworthy.

The great Bible teacher, Charles Stanley, has identified three levels of faith: Little Faith, Great Faith, and Perfect Faith.

## **Level 1—“Little Faith”**

This kind of faith is characterized by struggling to believe God. We hope He'll answer our prayer, but we're just not really sure. Sometimes doubts creep in because we're looking at the situation, not at the Lord and His Word. Or maybe our problem is that we just don't know what God has said in the Bible, so we have nothing to anchor our faith. An example of someone with little faith is found in Mark 9 where a father who had come to Jesus in hope that Jesus will heal his son says:

“Immediately the father of the boy cried out and said, ‘I believe; help my unbelief!’” —Mark 9:24

Q. When in your life have you experienced “Little Faith”?

## **Level 2—“Great Faith”**

Dr. Stanley calls this phase “reaching faith” because it involves stretching to believe the Lord more and more. Christians at this level are beginning to stand on the truth of Scripture. When we let the Word of God shape our thinking and petitions, we can know that He will grant our requests. We find an example of this kind of faith in the story of a woman who Jesus healed who had been sick for many years (Mark 5:24-34). In verse 28 she says, “If only I can just touch his clothes, I will be healed.”

Q. When in your life have you experienced “Great Faith”?

## **Level 3—“Perfect Faith”**

Perfect faith is characterized as resting in the confidence that the Lord has already accomplished what we've asked. When our requests align with God's will, it's a “done deal.” Our job is simply to thank Him and watch His promise become a reality. Jesus said:

“Ask me for whatever you want, and I'll give it to you.” —Mark 6:22

Q. Has there been a time in your life when you have experienced “Perfect Faith”?

Ask God to grow your faith!

## Yes, You Can Have a Relationship with God!

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A relationship with God? Really? Think about that for a moment! You actually have a relationship with the God of the universe! So what does that really mean? The word “relationship” implies a connection, bond, or involvement with someone. When you invited Jesus into your life, you initiated a “connection” with God. A connection that will have a daily impact on your life! This connection results in a relationship with God that is personal and intimate! When you invited Jesus into your life, you began a relationship with God that is very personal and intimate. Knowing about God is not the same as knowing Him personally and intimately. Many Christians find it hard to really trust God, because they don’t really know Him. When you know Him, you will be able to love and trust Him! Take a minute to consider your present relationship with God.

Q. What kind of connection do you have with God? Are you bonded to Him? What kind of involvement do you have with Him on a day-to-day basis? How would you describe your relationship?

### Ashley’s Story

“I always put my friends above God. In fact, my life revolved around my friends so much that I began to get involved in reckless behavior just to seem cool to others. Pretty soon I got involved in drugs, sex, and alcohol. My life was out of control, and I felt worthless, with no purpose other than to get high. Then I even lost my friends. One day someone told me that Jesus Christ not only created me, but wanted to be my best friend. I couldn’t believe it at first. Later, I decided to ask Him into my life. Since then, God has given me a new purpose in life and helped me break my addictions. I now have many new friends, but the greatest friend of all is Jesus Christ. He accepts me for who I am, and tells me that ‘He will never leave you and I will never abandon you’ (Hebrews 13:5).”

The great theologian A. W. Tozer once said, “What comes into our minds when we think about God is the most important thing about us.” And what you *think* about God will affect your relationship with Him! When you invited Jesus into your life, you initiated a “connection” with God. Consider the relationships that you have with the people in your life. Some of them are close, some on the surface, and some rather distant. It depends on how well you know someone and how much

time you spend with them that determines the quality of your relationship. And a relationship with God is much the same ... the more you get to know Him and the more time you spend with Him, the closer your relationship with Him will be.

Q. What do you presently know about God? Where has your information come from?’

*Now* is the time to develop your relationship with God by growing in your knowledge and experience of Him. Knowing about God is not the same as knowing Him personally and intimately. Many Christians find it hard to really trust God because they don’t really know Him. When you know Him, you will be able to love and trust Him!

This means it is really important that our ideas concerning God mirror what is, in reality, true about Him. Knowing God is critically important for living! If you do not truly know God, the world often becomes a strange, mad, painful place, and when life offers you disappointment—which it surely will—you will stumble and blunder with no sense of direction or meaning.

In his book, *The God You Can Know*, Dan DeHaan observes, “I have discovered a common weakness among the Christians of today, they are weak in their understanding of God and His character.” Ignorance of God and what He is like, results in a life of doubt and distrust. We need to really know God and not just have some sort of idea about who He is!

So how do we get to know God better? By reading His Word and allowing the Holy Spirit to reveal more of Him to us! We need to search God’s Word with the intent of getting to know and obey Him.

Q. What has been your experience of God up to this point in your life? What has influenced your experience?

Q. What do you want to know about God? What can you do to learn more about God?

Q. What is one step you can take to help strengthen your relationship with God?

“Stop your striving and recognize that I am God!” —Psalm 46:10

There is tremendous value in stepping aside from the rush of the day and taking time to quietly get to know God. Let Him renew your mind as you pray, read the Bible, and think.

Paul said, “My aim is to know him, to experience the power of his resurrection, to share in his sufferings, and to be like him in his death, and so, somehow, to attain to the resurrection from the dead.” —Philippians 3:10

Q. How does this verse from Philippians apply to your life right now?

“He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn over all creation, for all things in heaven and on earth were created in him—all things, whether visible or invisible, whether thrones or dominions, whether principalities or powers—all things were created through him and for him.” —Colossians 1:15-16

Q. As you consider these verses from Colossians, what impresses you most?

“The LORD says, ‘Wise people should not boast that they are wise. Powerful people should not boast that they are powerful. Rich people should not boast that they are rich. If people want to boast, they should boast about this: They should boast that they understand and know me. They should boast that they know and understand that I, the LORD, act out of faithfulness, fairness, and justice in the earth and that I desire people to do these things,’ says the LORD.” —Jeremiah 9:23-24

Q. What do the verses from Jeremiah teach us about God?

When you became a Christian, you did not sign up to become a part of some religious system. You decided to have a relationship with the God of the universe! This is a relationship that God initiated and maintains. Ignorance of God and what He is like, results in a life of doubt and distrust. Jesus died on the cross to restore the relationship that we are destined to have with God that has been broken by sin.

As Christians, we believe that we have been created specifically to have a relationship with God, but our sin separates us from Him. Jesus Christ walked this earth, fully God, and yet fully man. He died on the cross to restore the relationship that we are destined to have with God that has been broken by sin. After His death on the cross, Christ was buried; He rose again, and He now lives at the right hand of the Father God in heaven, making intercession for us forever.

The intimacy of this relationship is revealed to us in the Bible. Ephesians 1:4-5 says that we are now no longer seen as law-breakers, but we have been adopted into God’s own family as His children: “For he chose us in Christ before the

foundation of the world that we should be holy and blameless before him in love. He did this by predestining us to adoption as his legal heirs through Jesus Christ, according to the pleasure of his will.”

Q. As you think about being God’s child, what thoughts do you have? Does this kind of relationship excite you, or scare you? Ask God to help you to experience His love in a powerful way!

### **Application**

Q. Before reading this lesson, what was your idea of God? How is your perception of God changing?

### **Additional Study**

Read *The God You Can Know* by Dan DeHaan (Moody Press, 1982). Take the time to write a summary of each chapter as you go along. As a personal goal, resolve to read one chapter per day or per week!

We learn about God’s character as we read the Bible. Knowing God’s true nature not only significantly increases our reverence for Him, it greatly decreases our dependence on our own power and strength. The better we understand who He really is, the easier it is to trust and rely upon Him. Hebrews 4:16 tells us that we are always welcome in his presence: “Therefore let us confidently approach the throne of grace to receive mercy and find grace whenever we need help.”

## Becoming Like Jesus

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When you made the decision to receive Jesus into your life, you began an exciting journey with Christ that will never end. God's ultimate plan is to change you into Christ's image! In order for Him to accomplish that, you will need to commit yourself to learning how to live for Christ.

Q. At this point in time, what excites you most about your life with Christ?

"And we know that all things work together for good for those who love God, who are called according to his purpose, because those whom he foreknew he also predestined to be conformed to the image of his Son, that his Son would be the firstborn among many brothers and sisters. And those he predestined, he also called; and those he called, he also justified; and those he justified, he also glorified." —Romans 8:28-30

Think of this process life-changing process as a journey. It is somewhat like participating in a marathon. Marathon runners prepare for the long haul. The Christian life is not a sprint—it is a commitment you make for all of your life.

At the beginning of a race, competitors always feel great and have lots of energy. However, as the race wears on, they can begin to feel tired ... even exhausted. Right now you are feeling excited and ready to live for God, but the pressures of daily life are going to make you tired and possibly even discouraged.

Good marathon runners take a lot of time to train. And training time definitely pays off in helping a runner to run a better race. In order for you to run your best race for Christ, you also need to spend time in training. It takes daily discipline to put God into our days. It takes commitment to learn how to live for Christ.

Jesus' Spirit living in you has begun to bring about this change, and He will continue His work throughout your life. Philippians 1:6 tells us, "For I am sure of this very thing, that He who began a good work in you will perfect it until the day of Christ Jesus". And Philippians 2:13 encourages us with these words: "The one bringing forth in you both the desire and the effort—for the sake of his good pleasure—is God."



Once a space shuttle launches, it is too late to abort the mission without the potential of grave danger. Now that you have “launched” your life with Christ, you need to be aware of the danger of aborting your mission. The lure of life’s pleasures will tug at you. Your own desires will crave to be fulfilled. You will get tired, or bored, or disillusioned. It is important to remember in these moments that you must not abort your “mission” with Christ. When you live for Christ and trust Him, you will experience joy, peace, love, confidence, hope, and contentment as only God can give it. The Holy Spirit gives us the power to overcome trials and temptations. We must obediently surrender our lives to the Holy Spirit, and allow Him to make us Christ-like.

Q. What types of things can potentially distract or discourage you from growing in your relationship with Christ?

Paul says,

“Indeed, he who did not spare his own Son, but gave him up for us all—how will he not also, along with him, freely give us all things?” —Romans 8:32

“For we are not like so many others, hucksters who peddle the word of God for profit, but we are speaking in Christ before God as persons of sincerity, as persons sent from God.” —2 Corinthians 2:17

In other words, our heavenly Father loves us so much that He delights in helping us to be all that He created us to be. If you live for Christ and trust Him, you will experience joy, peace, love, confidence, hope, and contentment as only God can give it.

A life that is like Christ is lived in obedience to Him based upon faith in His Word. You and I are totally unable to live the Christian life in our own strength. However, by faith in God’s promises, the Holy Spirit gives us the power to overcome trials and temptations. As we surrender our lives to Jesus Christ, He conforms us into his likeness.

Q. How do you feel about being conformed into the likeness of Christ?

“But, like the Holy One who called you, become holy yourselves in all of your conduct, for it is written, “You shall be holy, because I am holy.” —1 Peter 1:15-16

Nancy DeMoss writes, “True holiness starts on the inside—with our thoughts, attitudes, values, and motives—those innermost parts of our hearts that only God can see. It also affects our outward and visible behavior.”

Q. What does it mean to you that your life must be holy?

“Or do you not know that your body is the temple of the Holy Spirit who is in you, whom you have from God, and you are not your own? For you were bought at a price. Therefore glorify God with your body.” —1 Corinthians 6:19-20

Q. What does this verse mean to you personally? How can you honor God with your body?

Since it is impossible for us to simply improve our sinful natures, we must obediently surrender our lives to the Holy Spirit, and allow Him to make us Christ-like. Many Christians are able to put on a good front, which appears Christ-like, while holding deep grudges and resentments inside. Christ’s love is totally different; it begins on the inside.

“For through the law I died to the law so that I may live to God. I have been crucified with Christ, and it is no longer I who live, but Christ lives in me. So the life I now live in the body, I live because of the faithfulness of the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me. I do not set aside God’s grace, because if righteousness could come through the law, then Christ died for nothing!” — Galatians 2:19-21

Q. Are there times when you find yourself 'faking' a true relationship with Christ? Why? How can you avoid this trap?

What does a Christ-centered life look like?

“But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. Against such things there is no law.” — Galatians 5:22-23

Q. What do these verses from Galatians say to you?

## **Application**

Q. Which areas of your life have you already surrendered to control of Christ:

Q. What areas of your life do you still need to submit to God?

## Who Is the Holy Spirit?

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Q. What do you think of when you hear the words, “Holy Spirit”?

Many people think of the Holy Spirit as a “what,” but in reality, the Holy Spirit is a “who”! The Holy Spirit is a real person. When you accepted Jesus Christ as your Savior, the Holy Spirit entered your life and He is enabling you to do God’s work! Without the Holy Spirit, living for Christ is impossible. With Him, you can do anything and everything!

The Bible teaches that God is actually “three-in-one”—God the Father, God the Son, and God the Holy Spirit. God the Father created and sustains the world. Jesus, God the Son, came to earth in bodily form and saved all of humankind from their sin. And God the Holy Spirit actually lives in each believer helping them to accomplish all that God the Father has for them to do!

Jesus said: “I tell you the solemn truth, the slave is not greater than his master, nor is the one who is sent as a messenger greater than the one who sent him. If you understand these things, you will be blessed if you do them” (John 13:16-17).

Q. What truth do you think God might be currently trying to speak into your life through the work of the Holy Spirit?

At the end of his earthly ministry, Jesus was giving His disciples final instructions before He went back to his Father. The disciples were all totally ready to follow Jesus after His resurrection ... and ready to give up everything to follow Him.

But Jesus knew they were not ready. Even after three years of Jesus training them, the disciples still didn’t have the necessary strength to live the life Jesus had called them to live. He knew they would fail miserably if they tried to live for Him in their own strength! Jesus knew they needed His power. He told them:

“But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you” —Acts 1:8.

Jesus told his disciples to wait for the “promise” He would send them from his Father. In Luke 24:49, He said, “And look I am sending you what my Father promised. But stay in the city until you have been clothed with power from on high.”

The Holy Spirit is called many things in the Bible, but his main role in your life is to be your “Encourager” and “Comforter” as you embark on your new journey with Christ.

Q. What in your life are you currently trying to accomplish for God?

Q. How might allowing the Holy Spirit to work in you make a difference?

When you invited Jesus Christ to be your personal Savior and Lord, the Holy Spirit actually entered your life—and He will be with you forever. Imagine that—the Spirit living inside you!

You will never be alone! Ephesians 3:16-17 tells us, “I pray that according to the wealth of his glory he will grant you to be strengthened with power through his Spirit in the inner person, that Christ will dwell in your hearts through faith, so that, because you have been rooted and grounded in love. ”

The Holy Spirit is invisible, but He is a real person. In John 14:16-17, Jesus said, “I will ask the Father, and he will give you another Advocate to be with you forever—the Spirit of truth, whom the world cannot accept because it does not see him or know him. But you know him because he resides with you and will be in you.”

In *My Heart, Christ's Home*, Robert Munger wrote about having Christ control each “room” of a person’s life. Envisioning what it would be like to have Jesus come to the home of our hearts, Munger goes from room to room considering what Christ desires for us. In the living room, we prepare to meet Christ daily. In the dining room, we examine what appetites should and should not control us. Munger even helps us explore the closets in our lives that Christ can help us cleanout. Think about what it would mean to give Christ control over all of your life! As your invited guest and Lord, Jesus desires to “settle down” in each “room” of your “house.” Christ lives in you through the person of the Holy Spirit and He will take each area of your life which you commit to Him and help you to live for God.

Q. As you consider this concept of your life being like a home, which room comes first to your mind as needing to be under the Holy Spirit’s control?

Read the following verses to learn more about the Holy Spirit:

“Do you not know that your body is the temple of the Holy Spirit who is in you, whom you have from God, and you are not your own? For you were bought at a price. Therefore glorify God with your body.” —1 Corinthians 6:19-20

Q. What does 1 Corinthians 6:19-20 teach you?

“But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the farthest parts of the earth.” —Acts 1:8

Q. What does Acts 1:8 teach you?

“But I say, live by the Spirit and you will not carry out the desires of the flesh.” —Galatians 5:16

Q. What does Galatians 5:16 teach you?

The Holy Spirit is the one who directs and controls us. Each one of us is like a basketball player who voluntarily puts himself under the control of his coach. The basketball player listens to the coach so he can perform to the best of his ability. The player is not a robot, but he freely chooses to let his coach direct him because he wants to play well.

### **Application**

Q. In what ways is having the Holy Spirit working in your life making a difference?

Q. What can you do to allow the Holy Spirit to have more control over your life?

### **Additional Study**

Read the booklet, My Heart, Christ's Home by Robert B. Munger. You can access this publication at <http://navigatorsdetroit.com/MHCH.pdf>.

God's plan for you is to mold you into the image of Christ. This life-long process is the work of the Holy Spirit ... as you allow Him to control your life. The Holy Spirit will gradually conform us into the image of Christ as we submit ourselves to Him. Second Corinthians 3:18 encourages us with these words, “And we all, with unveiled faces reflecting the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another, which is from the Lord, who is the Spirit.”

## **Related Lessons from Series Two: Empowered by Christ**

### **Living “by the Spirit”**

When you sincerely ask Jesus to come into your life, the Holy Spirit makes a home in your heart. The moment you surrender your life to Jesus, the Spirit comes in ... even if you don't feel anything. He is there, waiting for you to yield to His power. It is through the Holy Spirit that we receive the ability and power to live the way God wants us to.

[\(Go to lesson\)](#)

### **Spirit-Controlled vs. Self-Controlled**

The Bible describes two types of Christians—those who are Spirit-controlled and those who are self-controlled. Being Spirit-controlled requires allowing the Holy Spirit to control your life. It is a decision, a free choice for you to make. It is done by simply putting your life into the hands of a trustworthy God. Just as you came to Christ by faith for the forgiveness of your sins, you must by faith ask the Holy Spirit to control your life.

[\(Go to lesson\)](#)

### **Spiritual Breathing**

One of the ways you can experience God's transformation is through a spiritual discipline called “Spiritual Breathing.” In “Spiritual Breathing”, you “exhale”—by confession—sin, and “inhale” —by faith—the Holy Spirit's control.

[\(Go to lesson\)](#)

### **The Holy Spirit's Power to Resist Temptation**

It is only through the Holy Spirit's power that we can resist temptation and live victorious for Christ! Trust God ...temptation is normal! Trust God ... the Holy Spirit will give you the ability to withstand temptation! Trust God ... He will give you a “way out”!

[\(Go to lesson\)](#)

## **The Holy Spirit's Power to Overcome Evil**

God has given us a way to not only resist temptation but to also overcome evil! Ephesians 6 reveals that we have spiritual weaponry for fighting our spiritual battles! We need to be prepared! Faith, salvation, truth, the Spirit ... we seldom think of these as protection—but that is exactly what they are! Make sure you are wearing all the protection God gives for spiritual safety!

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## Put the Truth of God's Word into Your Life!

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Have you ever thought about why you do the things you do? Where does your behavior come from? These questions may seem somewhat unimportant to you, but ... the answers to these questions really are important! What you put into your mind influences your behavior! Everything a person puts into their mind, sticks—every word, every image, every idea.

Q. So, why do you think you do the things you do?

The Bible tells us that what we believe (what is in our minds) determines what we do.

Proverbs 23:7 says, “For he is like someone who has calculated the cost in his mind. ‘Eat and drink,’ he says to you, but his heart is not with you.”

So, think about it—what is in your mind comes out in your behavior! Consider the enormous growing pool of information in your mind, much of which is subconscious. You have information coming to you from all kinds of sources. That subconscious information is influencing your behavior.

In the field of computer science, they use the phrase, “garbage in, garbage out.” This phrase is used primarily to call attention to the fact that computers will unquestioningly process the most nonsensical of input data (“garbage in”) and produce nonsensical output (“garbage out”). It was most popular in the early days of computing, but applies, even more, today, when powerful computers can spew out mountains of erroneous information in a short time. In other words, what you put in is what you are going to get out! What is in your mind comes out in your behavior!

Q. What types of things go into your mind on a regular basis?

Q. In what ways is the information going into your mind currently affecting you? Are you making wise decisions? Does your behavior reflect your relationship with God?

Picture your mind as a huge “vat” with two big faucets pouring everything you hear, see, smell, read, and experience into that “vat.” One pipe is pumping in the world’s point of view, and the other pipe is pumping in God’s truths. You determine how much of each kind of information is coming into your vat!

Your thoughts, values, decisions, beliefs, fears, joys, emotions, and attitudes are all by-products of what is in your vat! The great theologian A. W. Tozer once said, “What comes into our minds when we think about God is the most important thing about us.” Consider that truth for a moment: The most important thing about you is what you think when you think about God! What do you think about God? Is your information accurate? Is it based on the Bible ... or on what you’ve simply “heard” about God? It’s important that you have correct information about God coming into your vat—and the most reliable source for that information is the Bible. Your thoughts, values, decisions, fears, joys, emotions, and attitudes are all by-products of what is in your mind!

Q. What do you currently know about God?

Q. Where do you get your information about God? Where can you go to get accurate information about God?

Unfortunately, all of us “contaminate” our vat, which is similar to putting dirt in a glass of water! If you let the glass of water stand, the dirt might sink to the bottom ... but it is still there! And it can still be stirred up to make the glass of water cloudy (and gross!). When it comes to your vat—and the information that is in your mind—you may have lots of good information in your mind about God and truth, and then someone tells you a dirty joke or you see something on the internet that is immoral. Now you have both kinds of information in your mind. You can let the ungodly “stuff” sink to the bottom, or you can “stir” it up and let it cloud your thinking. In any case, the “dirt” is still there.

Q. What kinds of things are currently contaminating your vat?

If we fill our minds with God’s Word and instruction, our decisions and behavior will reflect that. God’s Word is the place to go to get the right information about God. What does God reveal about himself in the Bible? He is eternal; He had no beginning, and He has no end. Nothing existed before Him. No one created Him. Nothing is hard for Him. God created all of the universe with all its electrons, elements, and the laws that control it. He is everywhere all at once. He does not change, grow, develop, or learn; He is the same yesterday, today, and forever—not because He is arrogant or small-minded, but because He already knows all that can be known.

He hates sin and loves righteousness. He is never surprised, never asks questions, never discovers anything, does not seek information—because He already knows all there is to know ... about the world and about each one of us. He has total knowledge, and infinite wisdom to apply it. He is absolutely holy. And in addition to all that, He is infinitely loving, kind, patient, and gracious! How's that for some good stuff for your vat!

Consider someone who is becoming a doctor. It is critical that this person have accurate data in their vat. How do they accomplish this? Primarily by reading books about medicine and listening to experienced doctors. The practice of medicine is a matter of making many decisions, many of which are critical. These decisions are made on the basis of what one knows, what is in the vat. A doctor facing a medical decision cannot use what is not there! The more accurate information the medical student puts into the vat, the more resources they will have at their disposal when critical decisions needed to be made.

Q. How do you think this idea of filling your mind with the truth of God's Word might make a difference in your life?

A distorted, inaccurate view of God will result in a distorted, inaccurate response to Him! When we are faced with important decisions—personal, moral, ethical, spiritual, relational—we can only draw on the information that is currently in the vat. If we fill our vat with God's Word and instruction, our decisions and behavior will reflect that. As you study God's Word, your vat will influence you to live in a way that not only glorifies God but also points others to Him.

Here are some principles from the Bible to get you started on having your vat filled with God:

"Finally, brothers and sisters, whatever is true, whatever is worthy of respect, whatever is just, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is commendable, if something is excellent or praiseworthy, think about these things." —Philippians 4:8

"Jesus answered them, 'You are deceived, because you don't know the scriptures or the power of God.'" —Matthew 22:29

"Every scripture is inspired by God and useful for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the person dedicated to God may be capable and equipped for every good work." —2 Timothy 3:16-17

“So then, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; what is old has passed away—look, what is new has come!” —2 Corinthians 5:17

“For the love of Christ controls us, since we have concluded this, that Christ died for all; therefore all have died. And he died for all so that those who live should no longer live for themselves but for him who died for them and was raised.” —2 Corinthians 5:14-15

Being a Christian is all about having a relationship with Jesus Christ. It is a living faith in a living person, God himself. A distorted, inaccurate view of God will result in a distorted, inaccurate response to Him! What you think about God really does make a difference in how you act! Every day you will be faced with choices on what to allow into your vat ... and what you are going to allow to influence your behavior. Choose wisely! Fill your mind with the things of God so that your life will reflect Him!

### **Application**

Q. What is one step you can take to increase the input of God's truths into your vat?

## God Is Communicating with You!

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This next series of lessons is about the Bible and the importance of using it to grow in your relationship with God.

Many Christians say they love God and want to know Him better, but they don't do anything to actually learn more about Him. They say they want to serve God, but they don't take the time to read His Word to find out just how to do that. Take time to read the Bible—it will encourage you every day and strengthen your relationship with God!

Q. At this point in your life, how much of the Bible have you read?

Q. What thoughts do you have of trying to spend more time reading and studying the Bible?

By taking the time to read God's Word on a regular basis, you will grow spiritually and be able to stand firm when difficulties and deceptions come into your life. Every moment of every day your mind is flooded with information ... most of it from the world's viewpoint. The Bible is the primary way that God communicates his desires for His people to His people! The Bible is nothing less than the words God himself chose for us to hear! The Bible is God's "Road Map" for your life. The Bible is your guide to righteousness peace and stability.

Your life and the decisions you make are greatly influenced by what goes into your mind and heart. In order for God's viewpoint to prevail in your life, you must really study God's Word ... and not just for a few minutes each day.

The Bible is not just one big book, but actually a collection of 66 smaller books written over a period of at least 1600 years by about 40 different authors. Everything the authors wrote was inspired by God.

God will not love you more because you read the Bible, but the Bible is His way of helping you to grow in your relationship with Him. Your relationship with God has been sealed by the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ ... now it's time to learn more about God! By taking the time to read God's Word on a regular basis, you will grow spiritually and be able to stand firm when difficulties and deceptions come into your life.

If you received a special letter or email from God ... telling you how much He loves you ... giving you guidance and direction for your daily issues ... would you read it? Would you keep it, treasure it, memorize it, and continually think about it ... like a letter you receive from one of your cherished friends? That's exactly what the Bible is ... God's letter to you!

"Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly, teaching and exhorting one another with all wisdom, singing psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs, all with grace in your hearts to God." —Colossians 3:16

Q. As you look at this verse, what is it saying to you today?

Q. What do the following verses reveal about God's Word?

"Above all, you do well if you recognize this: No prophecy of scripture ever comes about by the prophet's own imagination, for no prophecy was ever borne of human impulse; rather, men carried along by the Holy Spirit spoke from God." —2 Peter 1:20-21

"For the word of God is living and active and sharper than any double-edged sword, piercing even to the point of dividing soul from spirit, and joints from marrow; it is able to judge the desires and thoughts of the heart." —Hebrews 4:12

In the early 1700s (!) author Matthew Henry said: "If you want to get close to God, you must study his Word." The Bible is the primary means that you have to know God and what He wants for your life.

The whole Bible can be summed up in five words: **Preparation, Presentation, Propagation, Explanation, and Consummation**. As we look at all of scripture, we find that the whole Bible is about the Lord Jesus Christ.

Preparation—The entire Old Testament

Presentation to the world—The Gospels

Propagation to the world—Acts

Explanation of how to live for Him—The Epistles

Consummation of everything in Him—Revelation

Q. From what you know about the Bible right now, what one word would you use to describe it?

## **The Bible is God's "Road Map" for Your Life**

If you were trying to drive to a distant small town you had never been to before ... would you drive by your emotions and instincts ... or would you look at a road map? While the road map won't tell you what's just around the curve, or how bumpy the road is ... it will keep you from heading in the wrong direction, giving you guidance for your trip.

The Bible provides the "road map" for your journey with God. It gives you God's wonderful promises for each step of the way.

"The road of life can be a baffling route indeed: smooth at times, but sometimes full of potholes...one day a well-marked expressway, the next a maze of detours. But your heavenly Father has provided a road map—the Bible—to keep you moving in the right direction." —*Closer Walk New Testament*

Every day you do things out of habit. You get up, eat breakfast, shower, get dressed, go to school, go to work, etc. In order to make God's Word part of your life—you need to make it one of your daily habits. Pick a time, then pick a quiet spot and spend time reading the Bible and thinking about how it applies to your life. Once you have done it for thirty days, you will have established a habit that will change your life!

Q. As you think about the routine of your day, when would be a time that you could spend some time with God by reading and studying His Word?

## **God's Viewpoint**

The Bible gives you God's answers to all of life's most important questions regarding:

God's Nature

Your Purpose

How to Grow in Christ

Moral Decisions

Relationships / Sex

Emotions / Comfort

Trials / Death



Henry Brandt and Kerry Skinner once wrote, “Your love for God is demonstrated by the place that His commandments occupy in your life. You must study His Word to learn what His commandments are.”

To follow God’s Word as life’s guidebook requires a familiarity with the commandments and a keen sense of the place that they have in God’s order. A serious study of the Bible will give you an understanding of what God requires of you and what you can expect from God ... for it is the Bible that is the guide to righteousness, peace, and stability.

### **Application**

Q. On a scale of 1 to 10, how important is it to you to take time to learn from God’s Word?

Q. What one step can you take to make reading and studying God’s Word more of a priority in your life?

### **Additional Study**

You may find it helpful to obtain a copy of *What the Bible Is All About* by Henrietta Mears. Dr. Mears was one of the great Bible teachers of the 20th Century. As Christian Education Director at First Presbyterian Church of Hollywood, she built one of the largest Sunday Schools in the world and wrote a curriculum that was in such high demand that to publish it she founded her own publishing company! Such notable Christian leaders as Richard C. Halverson, Luis Evans Jr., and Bill Bright were among her students. Dr. Billy Graham once said of her, “She is certainly one of the greatest Christians I have ever known.”

## Talk to God!

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Prayer is one of the most incredible privileges we have. We actually are invited to come directly into God's presence and talk with Him about whatever is on our hearts and minds. And He promises to listen and respond! Prayer is the means God uses to give you what He wants for you. God does not just respond to your prayers; He responds to you as a person.

People "pray" all the time these days! But who are they praying to and what are they praying about? When you are praying, God is listening ... and He will answer. Is it important to you? The dictionary actually defines prayer as, "An act of communion with God, or another object of worship, such as in devotion, confession, praise, or thanksgiving." Hmm ... does it seem to you that the people you know are "communing" with God? Are they praying with "devotion"? Prayer is when we take the time to talk with God! The God of the universe! The God who created you! The God who has all of the answers to all of life's questions!

Suppose you were having lunch with a friend one day and your cell phone rang.

You answer and an unfamiliar voice calls out your name.

You ask, "Who is this?"

The response? "I'm your heavenly Father. I'm calling to talk with you because you're my child ... and I haven't heard from you for a while!"

Q. What would your reaction would be? Would you feel special ... scared ... excited ... nervous ... convicted? What thoughts would you have?

Prayer for the Christian is really a conversation with God!

But the "conversation" can be a little tricky, because sometimes it feels like a one-way deal: Us talking and God listening. It takes a measure of sensitivity to hear God's responses back to us!

Q. What has been your experience of prayer at this point in your life?

God wants you to know Him so well that you will always feel like talking to Him ... even when you sin. Prayer is one of the most incredible privileges we have. We actually are invited to come directly into God's presence and talk with Him about whatever is on our hearts. And He promises to listen!

Prayer is when we take the time to talk with God ... the God who has all of the answers to all of life's questions.

When you invited Jesus into your life, you began a relationship with God that is very personal and intimate. All relationships need good communication to be healthy. Jesus' death for you on the cross made it possible for you to talk directly with your Father in heaven. Your Father wants you to seek His guidance, comfort, peace, and intimate companionship at all times ... not just when you want things. He actually desires your companionship!

Dan DeHaan, in his book *The God You Can Know*, was hard at work in his office one day when his son opened the closed door, came in and sat down quietly. Dan asked, "What do you want?" The boy said "I didn't want anything, I just wanted to be with you." He didn't want money, he didn't want to go out that night, he didn't want help with his homework. No, he said, "I just wanted to be with you." Have you ever felt that way about God? We so often just barge into His presence, reel off our selfish list of wants and take off! God wants you to know Him so well that you will always feel like talking to Him ... even when you sin.

Q. What thoughts do you have about just being with God?

Prayer is a dialogue between two persons who love each other. It is a means God uses to give you what He wants for you. God does not just respond to your prayers; He responds to you as a person. W. B. Hunter, in his book, *The God Who Hears*, said, "Prayer is not a blank check which can be cashed for anything we have enough faith for... we must learn to want what we get!"

All relationships need good communication to be healthy. Your Father wants you to seek His guidance, comfort, peace, and intimate companionship at all times ... not just when you want things.

Why pray? The Bible is filled with reasons and promises regarding our conversation with God:

- **God wants us to pray.** "Be devoted to prayer." —Colossians 4:2
- **God is listening.** "Come to me in prayer." —Jeremiah 29:12
- **God answers our prayers.** "I will respond, I will hear." —Isaiah 65:24
- **God wants an intimate relationship with us.** "Draw near to God." —James 4:8
- **God wants to bless us.** "Your Father ... gives good gifts." —Matthew 7:11

- **God wants to meet our needs.** “Receive mercy and find grace.” —Hebrews 4:16
- **God wants us to be protected.** “Stay awake and pray.” —Matthew 26:41
- **God wants to conform our perspectives, desires, and will to be like Jesus Christ.** “Clothe yourself with a heart of mercy, kindness, humility, gentleness, and patience.” —Colossians 3:12
- **God’s kingdom is built through prayer.** “Above all, pursue his kingdom and righteousness.” —Matthew 6:33

Q. As you look at this list, which reason for prayer is most important to you today?

Prayer is sharing your heart with your heavenly Father, who desires a relationship with you.

Our relationship to God is as a child to a parent! The act of prayer is to have fellowship with our heavenly Father! Relating to God as your loving Father prevents legalism, fear, a critical spirit, or jealousy. An incorrect concept of God will bring forth an incorrect response to Him. It is important to see Him as He is! When you pray you have the incredible privilege of talking with the King of the Universe! You can actually know Him and have His guidance and protection made real to you. Our lack of influence and fruitfulness is primarily because we don’t really believe that God can and will act on our behalf!

Q. What motivates you to pray?

Q. What images of God do you have that keep you from praying?

Prayer is the natural result of meaningful time in the Scriptures where God reveals himself to us. It is there we learn that God wants us to think of Him as our Father. The term “Father” is applied to God 189 times in the Gospels (the books of Matthew, Mark, Luke and John) alone! Prayer is one way God reveals His will to us, and where personal battles and battles for others are won.

“I, the LORD, do these things. I, the LORD, form the plan to bring them about. I am known as the LORD. I say to you, ‘Call on me in prayer and I will answer you. I will show you great and mysterious things which you still do not know about.’” —Jeremiah 33:2-3

Q. What do these verses tell you about your part in talking with God?

Q. What kinds of things do you think God wants you to ask Him for?

James 4:2 tells us, “You do not have because you do not ask.”

Almighty God is our heavenly Father and He wants us to talk to Him. Prayer is not the end in itself, but the means used to know and develop intimate fellowship with God! The Holy Spirit helps us pray. Faith makes our prayers effective. God’s Word teaches us who God is and how to pray. Prayer is the means whereby God moves in the accomplishment of His mighty operations on the earth. We can’t fully understand this enormously important concept, but we can believe it.

The Bible records many specific, detailed examples of prayer making a difference in the real world. It is the major means of becoming a fruitful witness for Christ. Someone once said, “The divine order is first to talk to God about men, and then to talk to men about God.” When you are praying, God is listening ... and He will answer.

Take time to listen for God’s response—through His Word, through other people, through an idea or thought brought to mind by the Holy Spirit. Pay attention to God’s answers!

### **Application**

Q. How can you begin to incorporate a conversation with God into your life every day?

### **Additional Study**

Author and speaker Evelyn Christenson was known for her passion for prayer and the gospel of Jesus Christ. She wrote many books; two great books to add to your collection of spiritual helps would be *What Happens When Women Pray* and *What Happens When God Answers Prayer*.

### **Related Lessons from Series Two: Empowered by Christ**

#### **Pray with Confidence**

We serve a great God! And that great God loves us unconditionally and wants what is best for us! God is your perfect heavenly Father and you can pray with confidence knowing that He is listening and will answer your prayers!

[\(Go to lesson\)](#)

## **Different Ways to Pray**

We can pray in many ways! The important thing is to take time to be still with God. Enjoy His presence. Allow Him to speak quietly to you. Let the Holy Spirit fill you. Take time to be with Him every day.

[\(Go to lesson\)](#)

## Get Connected

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When you invited Jesus into your life, you became a part of God's family! When we are joined together with other believers who are growing in Christ, we encourage one another and help one another stay focused on our mutual faith. It doesn't matter what color your skin is; how smart you are; what kind of job you have; if you are a man, woman, teenager, or child; or how much money or stuff you have ...you are part of the family of God. And you need to get to know the other members of your family!

"So then you are no longer foreigners and noncitizens, but you are fellow citizens with the saints and members of God's household, because you have been built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets, with Christ Jesus himself as the cornerstone. In him the whole building, being joined together, grows into a holy temple in the Lord, in whom you also are being built together into a dwelling place of God in the Spirit." —Ephesians 2:19-22

You, along with all other Christians of all time, make up what is known as the body of Christ, the Church. Jesus made a promise to you and me. When we come together, with Him as our focus ... He is there:

"For where two or three are assembled in my name, I am there among them." —Matthew 18:20

Q. Are there people in your circle of family, friends, or acquaintances that you know are believers in Jesus Christ?

Q. Where can you go or what can you do to connect with other believers?

Every part of the body of Christ is important. And every part is interrelated. A body isn't just a single part blown up into something huge. It's all the different-but-similar parts arranged and functioning together. One of the main reasons many Christians live defeated lives is that they have isolated themselves from other believers. They think they can go it alone. That they can stay connected to Christ without being connected to His body, which is made up of other believers. It is important that you find a church or some type of group of Christians to connect with in order to grow in your relationship with God.

Throughout the New Testament of the Bible, Paul tells the early Christians that they are each vital “parts” of the “body of Christ.” The need to stay committed to God and to each other. The commitment of the early church was so strong, and their love for one another so great, that within three hundred years, Christianity spread throughout the entire Roman Empire. Those Christians truly changed their world for Christ!

Q. As you think about the commitment of the early Christians, how committed are you to other believers?

Q. What are you currently doing to develop relationships with other believers?

Every part of the body of Christ is important. And every part is interrelated.

Think about your personal, physical body for a moment ... every part has an important function and every part is interconnected.

Likewise, the body of Christ is also interconnected. There is a very important passage in the Bible that talks about this interconnectedness of the body of Christ. Read this passage and then write down what the Holy Spirit puts on your heart.

“For in fact the body is not a single member, but many. If the foot says, ‘Since I am not a hand, I am not part of the body,’ it does not lose its membership in the body because of that. And if the ear says, ‘Since I am not an eye, I am not part of the body,’ it does not lose its membership in the body because of that. If the whole body were an eye, what part would do the hearing? If the whole were an ear, what part would exercise the sense of smell? But as a matter of fact, God has placed each of the members in the body just as he decided. If they were all the same member, where would the body be? So now there are many members, but one body. The eye cannot say to the hand, ‘I do not need you,’ nor in turn can the head say to the foot, ‘I do not need you.’ On the contrary, those members that seem to be weaker are essential, and those members we consider less honorable we clothe with greater honor, and our unpresentable members are clothed with dignity, but our presentable members do not need this. Instead, God has blended together the body, giving greater honor to the lesser member, so that there may be no division in the body, but the members may have mutual concern for one another. If one member suffers, everyone suffers from it. If a member is honored, all rejoice with it. Now you are Christ’s body, and each of you is a member of it.” —1 Corinthians 12:14-27

Q. As you read this passage, What has the Holy Spirit impressed upon you?



Think about how this perspective keeps your significance from getting blown up into self-importance. No matter how significant you are, it is only because of what you are a part of. An enormous eye or a gigantic hand wouldn't be a body, but a monster. What we have is one body with many parts, each its proper size and in its proper place. No part is important on its own. Can you imagine Eye telling Hand, "Get lost; I don't need you"? Or, Head telling Foot, "You're fired; your job has been phased out"? As a matter of fact, in practice it works the other way—the "lower" the part, the more basic, and therefore necessary. You can live without an eye, for instance, but not without a stomach. When it's a part of your own body you are concerned with, it makes no difference whether the part is visible or clothed, higher or lower. You give it dignity and honor just as it is, without comparisons. If anything, you have more concern for the lower parts than the higher. If you had to choose, wouldn't you prefer good digestion to full-bodied hair?

The way God designed our bodies is a model for understanding our lives together as a church: every part dependent on every other part, the parts we mention and the parts we don't, the parts we see and the parts we don't. If one part hurts, every other part is involved in the hurt, and in the healing. If one part flourishes, every other part enters into the exuberance. Our heavenly Father has given each one of us distinctive gifts that are needed in the body of Christ.

You are a part of Christ's body—that's who you are! You must never forget this! Only as you accept your part of that body does your "part" mean anything. Some of the "parts" that God has formed in his Church, which is his "body" are: apostles, prophets, teachers, miracle workers, healers, helpers, organizers, those who pray in tongues. But it's obvious by now, isn't it, that Christ's church is a complete body and not a gigantic, unidimensional part? It's not all Apostle, not all prophet, not all miracle workers, not all healers, not all prayer in tongues, not all interpreters of tongues. And yet some sometimes we want to compete for so-called "important" parts.

Coming together with other believers in Christ's name is similar to hot coals, which keep each other hot when lumped together. However, a coal that is separated from the others will soon grow cold. Like logs burning in the fireplace when you separate them, the fire goes out. You need to be connected to other believers in order to be encouraged to continue your relationship with God and for you to encourage others! Each person is a unique creation of God. Our heavenly Father has given each one of us distinctive gifts that are needed in the body of Christ.

Refer back to the 1 Corinthians passage above:

Q. Who gave you your gifts?

Q. Which gift is most important?

Q. What are we warned against?

Q. What are we to do for others?

Satan is very clever in convincing many Christians that they are not important to Christ's work on earth. Many leave the job of doing God's work to those with gifts that are more obvious or appreciated. God's Word is clear that each gift is vital to his kingdom!

### **Application**

Q. How can you become more connected to other believers?

Q. What special gifts do you have to share with the body of Christ?

Q. How can you learn more about the gifts God has given you?

### **Additional Study**

*You Were Made for More* by Jim Cymbala. This book will help you come to a deeper understanding of the nature and character of God and how He works in the lives of His children. Some relate to God as a stern judge instead of as a loving Father. Some struggle with the idea that growing in faith entails doing more—more studying, more serving, more Bible reading. All you really need is a closer relationship with God—He'll do the rest!

In one way, your role in the church is similar to a player on a basketball, football, or soccer team. Unless each player uses his skill and talent to play, the game could be lost. To win, each player must do their own job well. As an important part of God's team, you need to play the position He has gifted you to play!

## Obedience

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Blessing comes through obedience. There's no other way to put it. It is only when we obey God and live life His way that we truly experience Him and all that He has to offer us.

Obedience is a key concept in how we relate to Almighty God. Our obedience comes out of our relationship with Him; we obey Him because we love Him!

"I pray that according to the wealth of his glory he will grant you to be strengthened with power through his Spirit in the inner person, that Christ will dwell in your hearts through faith, so that, because you have been rooted and grounded in love, you will be able to comprehend with all the saints what is the breadth and length and height and depth, and thus to know the love of Christ that surpasses knowledge, so that you will be filled up to all the fullness of God." — Ephesians 3:16-19

That's what we all want ... to experience God's power, and His love, and His grace. But all of that blessing comes through obedience.

Q. What comes to your mind when you think about obeying God?

Q. At this point in your life, are you willing to obey God ... in what areas of your life?

The entire Bible is full of evidence that God is serious about obedience. He wants us to obey Him. If you type "obey" into the keyword search on the online Bible reference Bible Gateway ([www.biblegateway.com](http://www.biblegateway.com)), you will come up with more than 200 references ... here are just a few:

"Then Samuel said, 'Does the Lord take pleasure in burnt offerings and sacrifices as much as he does in obedience? Certainly, obedience is better than sacrifice; paying attention is better than the fat of rams.'" —1 Samuel 15:22

"You must obey him and keep his commandments and statutes that I am giving you today." —Deuteronomy 27:10

"Give me understanding so that I might observe your law, and keep it with all my heart." —Psalm 119:34

"Blessed rather are those who hear the word of God and obey it!" —Luke 11:28

Q. What do you learn from the preceding four verses about obedience to God?

Q. How do you feel about the word “obedience,” especially as it relates to your relationship with God?

Q. In what ways is the concept of obedience difficult or easy for you?

Q. Who are some of the people you obey? Why?

Q. What are some of the reasons you choose to disobey people and rules that are in your life?

If we’re really honest, the main problem for us when it comes to our obedience of God is not ignorance, it is defiance ...we don’t obey God because we don’t want to. That’s a tough admission. The Bible records a consistent recurring scenario: God’s people do not listen to Him, they do not take Him seriously, and they repeatedly disobey His commands. After a period of time God punishes them. And as a result, they experience terrible, serious, and painful consequences. This happens over and over and over. “They would not listen” is a tragic, common phrase in the Old Testament!

Are you serious about trusting and obeying our loving heavenly Father?

Unfortunately, many Christians look, dress, act, talk, lie, cheat, and participate in the same godless activities as non-Christians, and therefore our ability to impact our hurting world is seriously compromised. The question is not “What does God want me to do?” but, “Am I willing to do what God wants me to do?”

Q. In what areas of your life do you think God wants you to obey Him?

Never think that your relationship with God is a matter of Him saving you and then handing you a bunch of rules to obey! That is simply dead religion. A relationship with God brings about a changed life, a desire to do what He wants you to do that stems from your relationship with your heavenly Father!

We cannot obey God in our own strength. It is because of our relationship with Jesus Christ that the Holy Spirit motivates and empowers us to obey Him! Our act of obedience is to surrender our lives to the Holy Spirit, and allow Him to make us Christ-like.

As an example, let’s consider love for a moment. On our own, it can be almost impossible sometimes to love others. But because of Jesus Christ, the Holy Spirit is actively at work in giving us His supernatural love for others. God’s love is

forgiving rather than judgmental, patient rather than irritable, and compassionate rather than easily angered and embittered towards others. We obey God's command to love others through the Holy Spirit working in us.

Many Christians are able to put on a good front, which appears loving, while holding deep grudges and resentments inside. Christ's love is totally different; it begins on the inside. When we confess our sin of resentment, God's love takes over.

Galatians 2:20 explains it this way:

"I have been crucified with Christ, and it is no longer I who live, but Christ lives in me. So the life I now live in the body, I live because of the faithfulness of the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me."

Q. What part of this verse do you need to claim for your own life?

Biblical obedience is enabled when we surrender to the control of the Holy Spirit. It cannot be accomplished in any other way!

### **Application**

Q. Make a list of all of the areas in your life that require obedience to God in some way

Q. Evaluate which areas you are actually obeying and in which ones you are not obeying—even a little.

Choose one area where you are disobeying your heavenly Father and find a verse of scripture to memorize and apply to that area of your life. Thank God for the Holy Spirit's power to help you become more obedient.

### **Additional Study**

*Soul Prescription: Experience True Healing and Freedom* by Bill Bright & Henry Brandt. God longs to see you living in the joy and freedom that He promises in his Word, but sometimes we choose poorly and end up with destructive habits. This book presents a unique, methodical, and biblically based approach to eliminating sin habits so that you can live a victorious Christian life.

*Grace Rules* by Steve McVey. There's a big difference between living by the rules and letting God's grace rule you. If you're living by the rules, you'll always be exhausted. You'll feel that you're not doing enough for God and that if you don't

quite measure up, He will be displeased with you. But God never meant for the Christian life to be that way! His love for us isn't based on how we perform for Him. He sent Christ to set us free from rules. He didn't call us to serve Him in our own feeble power, but to let His power flow through us—a power that is without limit! What's more, this power is already available to us right now. God has provided everything we need for a truly meaningful, joy-filled life here on earth—all because of His marvelous grace. Rest in God's grace, and let Him live through you—because grace rules!

## Spend Time with God Every Day!

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In order to have a great relationship with God, you need to spend time with Him every day! Just like with your human relationships, the purpose of spending time with God is to get to know and understand Him better.

“I just want to make a difference!” How many times have you heard that ... from others and also from yourself? Most people want to know that their lives are significant, that they matter, that they are important. Each one of our contributions to the world around us is different, but each one matters! For the Christian, a life of true significance begins with a close, personal relationship with God.

Everything we are and everything we do is grounded in the relationship that we have with our heavenly Father. The more time that we spend with God, the more we will know and understand His plan for our life. Consistency is critical. Just as plants grow well with daily sunlight and water, we too will grow well when we spend time daily in God’s Word. Plants don’t do well with gallons of water one day and then no water for an entire week. That is how it works for us in our relationship with God as well.

We can gain a lot by spending a lot of time in God’s Word ... but then if we don’t spend any time with God for a week, we may find ourselves “wilting.” The bottom line is that in order to have a great relationship with God, we need to spend time with Him every day! Just like with our human relationships, the purpose of spending time with God is to get to know and understand Him better.

Q. When are you currently spending time with God? And how often?

“Just as the Father has loved me, I have also loved you; remain in my love. If you obey my commandments, you will remain in my love, just as I have obeyed my Father’s commandments and remain in his love.” —John 15:9-10

Q. What does it mean to you to remain in Jesus’ love?

We’ve already spent a lot of time talking about the importance of hearing, reading, studying, meditating on, and memorizing God’s Word. We also discussed how taking time to pray makes a huge difference in our lives. So by now, you should be spending at least some time with God. Hopefully this is enjoyable for you! It may

not always be easy, but as you develop a daily discipline of spending time with God, you will find yourself not only growing closer to Him, but also experiencing His power in new ways.

Q. When you do spend time with God, what difference does it make in your life?

When you spend time with God every day you will be more in tune with what He wants for your life. You will be able to get your mind off the world and worries around you and focus on His faithfulness to you. You will find it easier to worship Him and to experience His great love and power.

Set reasonable goals for your time with God so that you can maintain spending time with Him every day. Maybe it's only 15 minutes in the morning, or 20 minutes at lunch time. If you don't have more time than that, don't set a goal for 30 or 40 minutes ... you will become discouraged and frustrated. Ask God to give you the desire and discipline to take that time with Him every day. Keep it simple. The goal of your time with God is to try to grow closer to Him. It's not to check off your list. Don't add extra burdens to this focus. "I have to make at least 15 observations." "I have to write at least 5 pages in my journal." "I have to pray for at least 45 minutes." The goal is to spend time with God and to grow closer to Him.

Q. What do you most enjoy about your time spent with God?

Q. What are the things that get in the way of you spending time with God every day?

Q. What can you do to make time for God?

Don't be disappointed when progress in your Christian life doesn't happen as quickly as you would like it to. Growing as a Christian is a lifelong process! God is patient, and He will never take His love away from you. Remember, the Holy Spirit will empower you when you choose to obey Him.

Your daily time with God is time to look to Him and listen to Him as He speaks to you through His Word. Plan a specific time and place the night before. Have your journal that you are using for Bible study and prayer ready. You don't necessarily have to write something every day. There are no rules or pressure. Simply enjoy His presence and wait for His direction.



When we spend time with God every day, we are able to experience His power. We are able to find His strength. When you take time out of your day to specifically spend time with God, you are intentionally acknowledging His presence in your life.

Ephesians 3:20 promises: “Now to him who by the power that is working within us is able to do far beyond all that we ask or think.”

Isaiah 40:31 says: “But those who wait for the Lord’s help find renewed strength; they rise up as if they had eagles’ wings, they run without growing weary, they walk without getting tired.”

God gives you this great promise that you can make yours every single day: “For God did not give us a Spirit of fear, but of power and love, and self-control” (2 Timothy 1:7)

When we spend time with God every day, we are reminded of who He is and His great love for us. God is with you every moment of every day and night! When you finish your specific time with Him, ask the Lord to come with you wherever you are going next. Make it a definite invitation. “Lord, I’m going to go to work now. Would you please come with me?” Of course, He is going to be with you, but this will remind you of His very real presence.

## **Application**

Pick a time that will work for you to spend time with God, and stick to it for the next week. Record the ways God directs and leads you during this time.

## God's Great Love for You!

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God loves you. Did you know that? Plain and simple. Right to the point. God loves you! And He wants to have a relationship with you!

Q. What is your initial reaction to the statement: God loves you!

It's hard to imagine that the God of the universe cares about each one of us individually, but it's true! God's love extends to each and every person ... and that includes you! There may be times when you don't feel like God loves you, or when the circumstances of your life are overwhelming and it seems as if God doesn't care, but the fact remains that God's love extends beyond all of our circumstances.

God made you in his image—you are His highest creative work! Genesis 1:27 tells us, "God created humankind in his own image, in the image of God he created them; male and female he created them." You are precious to Him. Luke 12:7 says, "Even the hairs of your head are all numbered. Do not be afraid; you are more valuable than many sparrows." And God is going to love you forever! Psalm 13:5 declares, "I trust in your faithfulness. May I rejoice because of your deliverance!"

Q. As you consider the three verses above, which one speaks to you most at this time in your life?

Q. Which verse is most difficult for you to embrace?

Q. Why is it difficult for you to embrace it?

God's love for you isn't dependent upon your performance for Him. God's love for you flows out of His very nature. Psalm 119:76 says, "May your loyal love console me, as you promised your servant." Jeremiah 31:3 reminds us, "In a far-off land the Lord will manifest himself to them. He will say to them, 'I have loved you with an everlasting love.'"

Q. What do the verses in Psalm 119 and Jeremiah 3 say about God's love?

Q. What does it mean to you that God's love is loyal and everlasting?

Q. Has there ever been a time in your life when you felt as though you were beyond God's love or you doubted His love for you? Do you know someone who feels they are beyond God's love?

Q. Are there times in your own life, or do you see it in someone you know, when you try to earn God's love? What kinds of things do you do? How does it make you feel? Does it work?

God is love. God's love is so great that He gave his only Son to bring us into a relationship with Him. God's love not only encompasses the world, but embraces each of us personally and intimately.

First John 4:9-10 explains: "By this the love of God is revealed in us: that God has sent his one and only Son into the world so that we may live through him. In this is love: not that we have loved God, but that he loved us and sent his Son to be the atoning sacrifice for our sins."

In *The Nature of God's Great Love*, Robert Wells writes, "The sad truth is that even though many people today have heard that God loves them, they simply don't believe it. They just cannot understand or comprehend the reality of God's love in their lives. They can't grasp something they cannot see. They haven't learned how to recognize it and experience it and therefore they don't know how to embrace it, nurture it, grow in it, or truly enjoy it. And without knowing and realizing that God loves us we cannot possibly have hope in our lives. We will not be aware of the purpose or the meaning that God wants us to have concerning our lives. God wants us to know a lot about him, but the most important thing that he wants us to know about him is the tremendous and awesome love that he has for each and every one of us. That is why the apostle John could write in 1 John 4:8, 'The person who does not love does not know God, because God is love'"

(<http://robertwells.tripod.com/godislove.html>).

God's love is not based upon attraction or performance. It is totally sacrificial and unselfish.

Q. Has there ever been a time in your life when you have truly felt God's love? When? Or if not, what do you think it might feel like to be totally wrapped up in God's love?

Are you measuring God's love for you by your present circumstances—either good or bad? The truth is your circumstances are always changing because of daily experiences, relationships, and choices. Maybe you feel as though God is not

answering your prayers. God is answering your prayers, but in His way and in His time. His great love for you sees the big picture of your life. You can't do anything to get God to stop loving you!

Q. On a scale of 1 to 10, how much do you feel God's love? In reality, how much love does God have for you?

Not one of us knows why God loves us. We just can see that God's love is radically different from ours. It is not based upon attraction or performance. It is totally sacrificial and unselfish. Jesus compared God's love with the love of a perfect father. A good father wants the best for his children, sacrifices for them, and provides for them. And, in their best interests, he also disciplines them. John 1:12 tells us, "But to all who have received him—those who believe in his name—he has given the right to become God's children." God created you to have life that is flooded with meaning and purpose.

You may be thinking, "Yes, I know that God is love, and that I am his creation, but my sin is too great, I've failed God too many times. I've broken too promises. I've made too many poor choices. I've walked away from God more times than I can count." But the good news is that God never says, "That's it, no more love! I've had it with you!" God's everlasting love means that you can't do anything to get God to stop loving you!

Robert Wells puts it this way, "God hates our sin, but even as we are sinning he still loves us with that perfect unconditional love. It is a love that is simply beyond the comprehension of the human mind."

Man's inability to understand God's great love is probably best described by Paul in Ephesians 3:19, "a love which surpasses all knowledge."

In Romans 8:38-39, Paul tells us, "For I am convinced that neither death nor life, nor angels nor heavenly rulers, nor things that are present, nor things to come, nor powers, nor height, nor depth, nor anything else in creation will be able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord."

Q. What are some of the things that might keep people from experiencing God's love?

Experiencing God's love requires that you place your life in God's hands. You need to ask forgiveness of your sins and then ask God to come into your life. If you truly ask God to come into your life and give you guidance, He will! Ask Him to show

you the path that He wants you to take and ask Him to help you get started.

Tell Him that you want to trust Him completely with your life and that you want Him to take the lead as you live your life.

Are there times when your life just feels empty? Nothing you have tried satisfies the inner void you feel? God can fill that void and change you in a moment. He created you to have life that is flooded with meaning and purpose.

Jesus said: “The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy; I have come so that they may have life, and may have it abundantly.” —John 10:10.

Perhaps things are going well for you in life, but you are restless or lack peace. You realize that you are separated from God’s love and forgiveness and you fear His judgment.

Jesus also said: “Peace I leave with you; my peace I give to you; I do not give it to you as the world does. Do not let your hearts be distressed or lacking in courage.” —John 14:27.

So whether you are simply tired of a life of empty pursuits or are troubled by a lack of peace, the answer still comes down to having a relationship with God through Jesus Christ.

When you put your trust in Jesus Christ, God will forgive you of all your sins—past, present, and future. You will become His child. He will give you purpose and meaning in life on earth. All of God’s children have the promise of eternal life with Him. God’s love is not based on how good you are or how you feel, it is grounded in His nature of love. His love is part of who He is.

Q. Have you put your life in God’s hands? When? Or why not? What will it take for you to let God into your life?

## **Application**

Q. What key idea about God’s love do you want to remember from this lesson?

Take some time right now to sit in God’s presence. Ask Him to fill the empty places in your life with Himself. Ask Him to allow you to experience His love.

## God's Purpose for Your Life

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Have you ever thought about what life is really all about? What you have been created for? Why you are where you are? Does it seem possible to you that God loves you and has a purpose for your life?

Your life matters!

Q. At this point in your life, what do you think your purpose in life is?

Your life is not an accident!

Psalm 139:13-18 says: "Certainly you made my mind and heart; you wove me together in my mother's womb. I will give you thanks because your deeds are awesome and amazing. You knew me thoroughly; my bones were not hidden from you, when I was made in secret and sewed together in the depths of the earth. Your eyes saw me when I was inside the womb. All the days ordained for me were recorded in your scroll before one of them came into existence. How difficult it is for me to fathom your thoughts about me, O God! How vast is their sum total! If I tried to count them, they would outnumber the grains of sand. Even if I finished counting them, I would still have to contend with you."

Imagine, God's thoughts toward you outnumber the grains of sand on earth! He cares deeply about you! He planned for you to be here!

However ... it's not all about you! What?

The Bible teaches that God has a specific plan for you ... but that plan is specifically tied to how you fit into His eternal master plan. God has given you the freedom to choose His plan or your own plan. To choose wisely, you must understand how life fits into the big picture of God's eternal master plan, and you must learn from the choices others have made. It's important to remember that you have the freedom to choose, but not freedom from the consequences of your choices.

All of creation and history exist for the glory of God. Ultimately, we have been created to know God, to appreciate his divine qualities, and to give ourselves to God in worship and service. The value of our existence is derived from our knowing God and pleasing Him with our lives.

Q. In what way(s) are you presently living for God?

Q. In what way(s) are you presently living for yourself?

God is your loving Father and He planned and designed you to be His child for all eternity. Ephesians 1:3-6 tells us: “Blessed is the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who has blessed us with every spiritual blessing in the heavenly realms in Christ. For he chose us in Christ before the foundation of the world that we should be holy and blameless before him in love. He did this by predestining us to adoption as his legal heirs through Jesus Christ, according to the pleasure of his will—to the praise of the glory of his grace that he has freely bestowed on us in his dearly loved Son.”

You are free to choose God’s plan or your own plan.

The Bible is filled with promises from God about His plans for us. God’s purpose for your life is for you to live as His child! John 1:12 says, “But to all who have received him, to those who believe in his name, he gave the right to become children of God.”

As God’s child, He will always love you!

We often do not realize that the Bible is filled with promises from God about His plans for us. Here are just two scriptures that tell us about God’s design for our lives.

Ephesians 2:10 encourages us with these words, “For we are his creative work, having been created in Christ Jesus for good works that God prepared beforehand so we can do them.”

Ephesians 4:11-16 teaches: “And he himself gave some as apostles, some as prophets, some as evangelists, and some as pastors and teachers, to equip the saints for the work of ministry, that is, to build up the body of Christ, until we all attain to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God—a mature person, attaining to the measure of Christ’s full stature. So we are no longer to be children, tossed back and forth by waves and carried about by every wind of teaching by the trickery of people who craftily carry out their deceitful schemes. But practicing the truth in love, we will in all things grow up into Christ, who is the head. From him the whole body grows, fitted and held together through every supporting ligament. As each one does its part, the body builds itself up in love.”

God wants you to live in such a way that you will experience His best, which He has planned for all eternity.

Q. As you think about these two passages from Ephesians, what are some abilities and talents you have that God might be wanting you to use for Him?

God has a specific job for you to do. He wants your life to fit in with His master plan. He wants you to advance His purposes. God wants you to live in such a way that you will experience His best, which He has planned for all eternity. Whatever your situation, your choice matters. God wants you to submit to His plan for your life.

Q. Is there something in your life (such as a relationship, a possession, a job, a commitment, or something else very important to you) that is standing in the way of what God wants you to do?

Second Corinthians 5:17 reminds us, “So then, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; what is old has passed away—look, what is new has come!”

In Jeremiah 29:11 we are told, “For I know what I have planned for you,” says the Lord. “I have plans to prosper you, not to harm you. I have plans to give you a future filled with hope.”

## **Application**

Q. As you think about all that has been presented here, what have you have been created for?

Q. In what ways do you see God working in your life—big and small?

Q. In what ways are you embracing God’s purpose for your life? In what ways are you fighting it?



## Living by the Spirit

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The moment you surrender your life to Jesus, the Holy Spirit comes in ... even if you don't feel anything. He is there, waiting for you to yield to His power. The Holy Spirit gives us the ability and power to live life the way God wants us to.

However, many believers have mistaken the Holy Spirit's power for an emotional feeling or euphoria. Sadly, when the emotions and feelings depart ... or even fail to materialize in some grand way, they think they have lost the Holy Spirit's power. They don't believe God's promise of Hebrews 13:5: "Never will I leave you; never will I abandon you."

Q. Can you think of a time when you experienced the emotion of the Holy Spirit?

Q. What was the result?

Q. Why is it a bad idea to depend on our feelings or emotions?

The power the Holy Spirit brings to you is much more than emotions or feelings ... although they may be part of how you experience Him. It is through the Holy Spirit that we receive the ability and power to live life the way God wants us to. When you become a Christian, Jesus does not give you a list of rules to follow. Rather, He empowers you by the Holy Spirit to live an intimate life with Him. Every moment of your life, the Holy Spirit is waiting to guide you into a life of significance for God. He will empower you to abide in Christ, love others, overcome trials and temptation and sin, and live for Him. Every moment of your life, the Holy Spirit is waiting to guide you into a life of significance for God.

### **The Holy Spirit's empowers you to:**

- abide in Christ
- love others
- overcome trials and sin
- live for Jesus

But ... He always allows you free choice. How you act and behave is motivated by what you think. Many people fill their lives by chasing after money, sex, or toys and possessions, thinking it will bring them happiness. And, as a result, they

waste their lives. Other people leave God out of their lives because they believe life will be boring. They believe God is against fun ... and that He doesn't care about their dreams. They don't want to trust Him with their future.

What will you choose?

The Bible tells us that God loves us so much that He desires and plans the very best for our future. In Psalm 37:4 we read, "Then you will take delight in the Lord, and he will answer your prayers."

If you accept God's Word as truth, you will give all your plans and dreams to God. Then, as He transforms your heart, your purified desires will become compatible with God's desires for you.

Q. How do you feel about letting the Holy Spirit have complete control of your life?

Romans 8:32 says, "Indeed, he who did not spare his own Son, but gave him up for us all—how will he not also, along with him, freely give us all things?"

Q. What kinds of things do you think God desires to graciously give you?

God desires and plans the very best for your future.

## **Joni's Story**

Joni Eareckson was an attractive, athletic teenager who had everything going her way in life—until she dove head first into a shallow lake and broke her neck. Joni had trusted Christ for salvation in Young Life, but at the time of her accident, she was living for self-fulfillment. Suddenly her world fell apart. She would never walk or be able to use her hands again! Joni's faith was shaken. Joni says, "In those first few months after my injury, the promises of God seemed anything but true ... How could I be expected to believe in God when everything inside and outside of me screamed just the opposite?" Joni struggled greatly until a friend from Young Life named Steve Estes encouraged her to trust God. Through time, and as she listened to God's Word, Joni began to believe God's promises. She overcame her despair ... by faith ... and today runs an international ministry, Joni and Friends, which shares Christ's love with disabled people all over the world. "Today as I look back, I am convinced that the whole ordeal of my paralysis was inspired by

God's love. I wasn't the brunt of some cruel divine joke. God had reasons behind my suffering, and learning some of them has made all the difference in the world."  
—Joni, A Step Further

The Bible tells us that it *is* possible to live a life of incredible influence. What might that look like? Hebrews chapter 11 gives us examples of men and women who trusted God in spite of great adversity and opposition. Living a life of faith pleases God and results in a life of power and victory over our circumstances. Living a life of faith comes from the Holy Spirit's power.

In the Old Testament of the Bible, when God rescued the Israelites from slavery in Egypt, He performed many miracles, including drying up the Red Sea so they could escape the armies of Pharaoh. The people of Israel saw God's mighty hand at work, but soon forgot and began to doubt his promise to provide for their basic needs. As God transforms your heart, your purified desires will become compatible with God's desires for you. Living a life of faith pleases God. It results in a life of power and victory over our circumstances.

God told the people through Moses that He had a place of rest for them to dwell in, called the Promised Land, "a land flowing with milk and honey." But all they did was complain and doubt God's promise. (This story is found in the Bible in Exodus chapters 3 through 20.)

The Israelites sent twelve spies to scout out the land and discovered it to be a paradise "flowing with milk and honey." But there were also giants there. When the spies came back and reported their findings, only Joshua and Caleb were willing to trust God and face the giants. The other ten scouts were afraid and convinced the doubting Israelites they were unable to overcome the giants. For the next 40 years, they wandered in the wilderness because of their unwillingness to trust God. (Read chapters 13 and 14 in the book of Numbers.)

Q. What are the giants in your life?

Read Hebrews chapter 11 in the New Testament of the Bible and write down your thoughts about these men and women who had faith and what you can learn from them.

Q. How can the Holy Spirit encourage you today to face those giants?

## **Application**

Q. Is there something in your life keeping that is keeping you from trusting God?

Take a moment to confess your fear and your lack of trust in God. Ask God to fill you with the Holy Spirit and empower you to face your giants!

## Spirit-Controlled vs. Self-Controlled

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Do you ever find yourself making a choice that you know in your heart is not God-honoring, but that you decide to pursue anyway? Even when you've committed your life to Christ, you may not always be living the way God wants you to live. The Bible describes two types of Christians: self-controlled and Spirit-controlled.

### Self-controlled

You've given your heart to Jesus, but you still make decisions that reflect what *you* want, not necessarily what *God* wants? This is a time when you are acting in a *self-controlled* way, rather than in a *Spirit-controlled* way.

Q. Describe one of these times in your life: What happened, how did you feel, what was the result?

### Spirit-controlled

Being Spirit-controlled requires *allowing* the Holy Spirit to control your life. It is a decision, a free choice for you to make. Self-controlled behavior is caused by a lack of *surrender* to Jesus. When we act in a self-controlled way, we are trusting in our own efforts to live the Christian life. It is only through the *Holy Spirit* that we can truly experience God's best for us and can accomplish His work.

The two thrones below illustrate these two types of individuals.

The throne on the left illustrates a Christian who has given his/her life to Christ but has chosen to continue to rule his/her own life.

The illustration below depicts a Christian who has put Jesus on the throne of his or her life and is allowing the Holy Spirit to control their choices and behaviors.

When you are SELF-CONTROLLED, all your activities, interests, desires, and choices are dictated by self, leading to a life of frustration and defeat (represented by the arrows going every which way).

Galatians 5:19-21 describes the Christian who has self at the center of his life: "Now the works of the flesh are obvious: sexual immorality, impurity, depravity, idolatry, sorcery, hostilities, strife, jealousy, outbursts of anger, selfish rivalries,

dissensions, factions, envying, murder, drunkenness, carousing, and similar things. I am warning you, as I had warned you before: Those who practice such things will not inherit the kingdom of God!”

Q. When are the times in your life when you are most likely to act in a self-controlled way?

When you are SPIRIT-CONTROLLED, all your activities, interests, desires, and choices are directed by Jesus resulting in harmony with God’s plan, (represented by the uniformity of the arrows). This is the abiding life, a life controlled by the Holy Spirit, which results from being obedient to the Word of God.

Galatians 5:22-23 describes a person who is Spirit-controlled: “But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. Against such things there is no law.”

Q. When do you most often act in a Spirit-controlled way?

### **Todd’s Story**

“For three years I had been consumed with the desire to join the elite drinking club for ‘cool’ guys in my high school ... the ‘Mavericks.’ Before coming to Christ, I would have ‘sold my soul’ to have been asked to join. Even though I was now a Christian, I thought it would still be okay to join ...I could still follow Christ and belong to this exclusive club. I began to seriously consider going all out for Christ and what it might mean to put aside all the things in my life that were self-destructive. As I was trying to make this decision, I got asked to join the Mavericks! I immediately knew that the stakes were high and that Satan was trying to derail my decision for Christ. I didn’t give him the pleasure: I turned my life completely over to God ... and God gave me true freedom ... and an awesome life!”

Q. Have you ever experienced this type of “decision” time in your life? What was the result? How did you get through it? What could have helped you or hindered you into a different decision?

As Romans 12:1 says, “Therefore I exhort you, brothers and sisters, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies as a sacrifice—alive, holy, and pleasing to God—which is your reasonable service.”

Take some time to watch the four-part video series "[Be Filled With the Holy Spirit](#)" and read "[How to Be Filled with the Holy Spirit](#)". Giving your life to the Holy Spirit is a decision ... a free choice for you to make. It is done by simply putting your life into the hands of a trustworthy God. Just as you came to Christ by faith for the forgiveness of your sins, you must by faith ask the Holy Spirit to control your life. If you desire for the Holy Spirit to be in control of your life, simply pray the following:

*"Heavenly Father, I want You to change my life from being self-controlled into one that is Spirit-controlled. I confess my selfish thoughts and actions, and give You, Holy Spirit, control of my life right now."*

Q. What does this commitment mean to you?

### **Application**

Take some time right now to sit in God's presence. Ask Him to fill the empty places in your life with Himself. Ask Him to allow you to experience His love and for the Holy Spirit to control you completely.

## Spiritual Breathing

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Experience God's transformation is through "Spiritual Breathing".

**"Exhale"**—by confession—sin

**"Inhale"**—by faith—the Holy Spirit's control

Being controlled by the Holy Spirit is a moment-by-moment decision. There are going to be times when you are totally Spirit-controlled and then there will also be times when you are self-controlled. Every believer sins and breaks fellowship with the Holy Spirit at times. Broken fellowship does not mean your sins aren't forgiven. Jesus paid for all your sins on the cross, once and for all—past, present, and future. Broken fellowship means that you are not abiding in Christ, and therefore are not experiencing God's supernatural power for a life of purpose and joy. When we are in step with the Holy Spirit, our life results in purpose, power, peace, and hope. These are times when we are walking in the Spirit.

Q. When are you most often in step with the Holy Spirit?

Being controlled by the Holy Spirit is a moment-by-moment decision.

Unfortunately, the sinful part of you will always want your own way ... the self-controlled way. A self-controlled life usually achieves short-term pleasures, but more often than not the end result is quite often fear, emptiness, loneliness, and eventually despair.

Q. When are the times in your life when you are most often self-controlled rather than Spirit-controlled?

Romans 12:2 encourages us with these words: "Do not be conformed to this present world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind, so that you may test and approve what is the will of God—what is good and well-pleasing and perfect."

Walking in step with the Spirit results in purpose, power, peace, and hope.

One of the ways you can experience God's transformation is through a spiritual discipline called "Spiritual Breathing." A spiritual discipline is a habit or regular pattern in your life that brings you back to God and opens you up to what the Holy Spirit is saying to you.



Years ago, the founder of Campus Crusade for Christ, Bill Bright, compared walking in the Spirit on a moment-by-moment basis to breathing. When you breathe, you exhale impurities, and inhale pure air and oxygen. In “spiritual breathing,” you “exhale”—by confession—sin, and “inhale”—by faith—the Holy Spirit’s control.

Exhale: confess your sin—agree with God concerning your sin and thank Him for His forgiveness of it. Confession involves repentance—a change in attitude and behavior.

Inhale: by faith, surrender the control of your life to the Holy Spirit. Trust that He now directs and empowers you.

### **Jennifer’s Story**

It was Labor Day 1972. I had had it! This time I left Jeff for good. I was miserable and in tears as I drove down Roscoe Boulevard on a sunny day in southern California. I needed to talk with someone—anyone who would understand and give me sympathy. Jeff just didn’t understand me. He was oblivious to my needs. So many times I had tried to communicate with him—but he was too busy watching football, or thinking about his career, or just spending time with other people, especially his family.

The tears were streaming down my face as I pulled into the parking lot at Grace Community Church. We had been attending this church for over a year, and had heard the Bible taught by John MacArthur. I had accepted Christ years earlier and had even been door-to-door witnessing—but the reality of Christ in my life was missing. Jeff had actually prayed with me, and talked about Christian things, but I didn’t understand them, nor could I understand him. If Christ was real in his life, why didn’t he pay more attention to my needs and show more love to me?

The fall leaves were blowing around as I pulled my green Volkswagen into a parking space. The church was large and always had a lot of people and staff around. But on that day, as I looked around for someone, I saw no one; not a car, not a person. It was Labor Day and everyone had taken the day off. My tears flowed openly now. Who was I going to get help from? I thought about leaving—and reached for my keys. But then I decided to read a little booklet someone had given me that was sitting on the floor of my car! This little booklet, entitled *How to be Filled by the Holy Spirit* by Bill Bright, explained how Christ gives us a new nature which is like Him, loving, humble, non-judgmental, patient, and kind. I read

the verse that said, “The Lord will fight your battles.” I had always fought my own battles, and I had been battling Jeff. In the midst of my tears, I cried out to God to forgive me for my sins and fill me with his Holy Spirit. In the middle of that prayer an amazing peace overcame me. My tears of sadness and self-pity were replaced with tears of joy and gratitude.

It was in that parking lot on a hot sunny day in southern California that I met my Savior and Lord. I then read in that little pamphlet how I could not just be controlled by the Holy Spirit, but that I could stay controlled on a moment-by-moment basis. The little section in the booklet called “Spiritual Breathing” taught me to “exhale” (or confess) any known sin in my life when I became aware of it, and “inhale” (renew the Spirit’s control) in my life simply by asking. I was a new person! I no longer looked to Jeff as my source of strength and contentment. In fact, he became incidental to my own walk and wonderful new relationship with Christ. Nearly 29 years later, our marriage has blossomed. Jeff saw the change in me and God dealt with him about his need to surrender his life to Christ and yield his life to the Holy Spirit. Now we are actively teaching others how Christ can give them victory in their lives and marriages. Confession involves repentance—a change in attitude and behavior. By faith, surrender the control of your life to the Holy Spirit.

### **Another Story ... from Matt**

Although I was a worship leader in my church, I led a double life. I became addicted to pornography at eleven years of age. As my addiction grew, my cravings became more vile and ugly. Soon I was having all-night pornography sessions on the Internet, and even fantasizing about rape. I was out of control. When a godly man told me about the Holy Spirit’s power to break my addiction, I began looking into God’s Word and memorizing its promises. I discovered God’s awesome power to overcome my addiction. My breakthrough came when I began believing and claiming God’s promises.

Now, whenever I am tempted, I think about a promise in God’s Word that applies to that particular temptation. I then simply focus on His Word, and pray for the Holy Spirit to give me strength to overcome. There are really four keys to my victory over the bondage of sin. First, I needed to take the time to memorize and meditate on God’s promises. Second, I confess my sins whenever my thoughts are wrong which is the “Exhale” part of Spiritual Breathing. Third, I surrender my thoughts and actions to the Holy Spirit by telling Him I want to please Him which

is the “Inhale” of Spiritual Breathing. Finally, I spend time with my mentor and other Christians who hold me accountable and encourage me in my walk with Christ.

As I’ve applied God’s Word to all areas of my life, I have been free from bondage to sin and addiction. God has blessed me with a wonderful Christian wife and family. My wife and I are now teaching others how memorizing God’s promises can help overcome sin and addiction. I feel so free and joyful now that I have turned my life completely over to the Holy Spirit’s control.

First John 1:9 says, “But if we confess our sins, he is faithful and righteous, forgiving us our sins and cleansing us from all unrighteousness.”

Take some time to watch the four-part video series, “[Walk in the Spirit](#)” and read “[How to Walk in the Spirit](#)” both available on this App.

## **Application**

Q. How can you begin to practice the spiritual discipline of Spiritual Breathing?

## The Holy Spirit's Power to Resist Temptation

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There are days when it seems that the enticement of sin is everywhere! Advanced by the media, promoted on the Internet, endorsed by friends and/or acquaintances, sometimes simply presented at an unexpected moment, the temptation to do something that dishonors God is all places! As Christians, what are we to do with this onslaught of temptation? It is only through the Holy Spirit's power that we can resist temptation and live victorious for Christ!

The truth is that we all face numerous temptations daily. And it is important to remember that being tempted is not a sin; it is normal! However, when we are tempted, there is a choice to be made: give in or to trust God. Giving in to temptation is what results in sin, and when we sin, we break our fellowship with God.

"No trial has overtaken you that is not faced by others. And God is faithful: He will not let you be tried beyond what you are able to bear, but with the trial will also provide a way out so that you may be able to endure it." —1 Corinthians 10:13

In this verse, God tells us how to overcome temptation! First of all, trust God ... temptation is normal! Secondly, trust God ... the Holy Spirit will give us the ability to withstand temptation! Finally, trust God ... He will give us a "way out."

Q. When do you most experience temptation? Is there something in your life right now that is regularly tempting you to sin or to not hold on to your relationship with God?

Q. What can you do to help yourself remember that God is going to provide a way out for you when you are tempted?

One of the ways that the Holy Spirit empowers us to resist temptation is by helping us to be aware of it ahead of time! Believers face three main "attackers" when it comes to temptation: Satan, the "world", and what we call "fleshly desires." These three attackers can present themselves to us individually or they can interact with one another.

## **Satan**

Satan is a vicious enemy whose primary goal is to destroy you and your relationship with Christ. In 1 Peter 5:8 the Bible calls him a “roaring lion” who is always looking to destroy believers. His biggest desire is to keep you away from God’s Word ... and your dependency on Christ. He uses his weapons of doubt and discouragement to accomplish that goal. You don’t need to fear him! He can only defeat you if you let him. Ask the Holy Spirit to give you His wisdom to know when Satan is attacking you and seeking to distract you from your goal of loving God! Satan wants to destroy you and your relationship with Christ.

Q. Are there times in your life when you feel as though Satan is tempting you? What can you do to resist him?

## **The “World”**

In the Bible, the “world” is a term that refers to the ordered, arranged system of physical reality. Although there is nothing wrong with money or material success, it is very easy to get so focused on possessions and success, that God becomes secondary to personal goals, dreams, and ambitions. God wants to be your first and highest focus in life ... and you will only be truly satisfied when you give Him his rightful place.

Matthew 6:33 is a great verse to memorize and to hold on to when faced with temptation from the “world”: “But above all pursue his kingdom and righteousness, and all these things will be given to you as well.”

Q. What in the world is most likely to tempt you? What active step can you take to resist temptation in this area of your life?

## **“Fleshly Desires”**

The “flesh” is the earthly part of man with its lusts and desires. We all are assaulted daily by images and desires that are outside the will of God. This includes temptations such as sex outside of marriage, gossip, anger, addictions, and other destructive behavior. When we ignore the guidance of the Holy Spirit, we are certain to live in the flesh and will make ourselves miserable.

Q. How can you guard against temptations in the area of fleshly desires?

Here are some ways that temptation can subtly present itself to you. Remember, Satan will try to control your perspective, manipulate your thinking, and exploit your foundational desires. God wants to be your first and highest focus in life.

### **Deception**

Deception is hard to discern because it is often cleverly disguised. It can be total lies that have been dressed up to look like the truth, lies that have been mixed in with the truth, or misrepresentations of truth taken out of context.

### **Worldly Gratification**

There is nothing wrong with enjoying God's gifts to you! However, when those gifts become consuming or become distorted they can present a major temptation in life! This can come in the form (but is not limited to) sensual pleasure, money and possessions, and/or fame and power.

### **Accusation**

This is one of Satan's favorite tricks! If he can get you to believe that you are not worthy of God's love, or that you don't truly have a relationship with Him, he has gained a foothold in drawing you away from God. Satan's tactics in this arena include condemning you of past sins that have already been confessed to God and forgiven, or creating false guilt about things for which God does not hold you responsible.

### **Distraction**

Temptation also can come in the form of distraction! If you can be sidetracked from staying focused on your purpose of living for God, Satan can keep you from growing in your relationship with Him. Distraction presents itself to different people in different ways! For some, distraction can come in the form of entertaining diversions, or relationships, or work. For others, distraction may come from a crisis of some kind—either professionally, relationally, or spiritually. Satan will try to control your perspective, manipulate your thinking, and exploit your foundational desires.

### **Affliction**

Suffering, hardship, and pain can present temptation to us! Satan can use any kind of mental or emotional torment or physical illness or disease to tempt us to question God's great love for us. It is during these times that we must hold on to

what we *know* about God's greatness to sustain us and hold us close to Him!

## **Discouragement**

Think about how discouragement can be a temptation. When we are discouraged, we often feel hopelessness, or loneliness, or despair. It is during these times when we are especially vulnerable to temptation. We often will do anything to feel better!

## **Doubt**

Here again, doubt is not sin! Doubting, when dealt with appropriately can lead us to a deeper understanding and experience of God! However, doubt can also lead us away from God when we question His motives and character and search for the answers in places other than His Word.

## **Division**

Oh, what an ugly word for God's people! When we are tempted to be divided with God's children, we focus on differences in others, or we are suspicious of the motivations of others.

## **Intimidation**

A key component of intimidation is fear. And we are often afraid—and when we are afraid, we can be tempted to do all kinds of things! We are afraid of failure, rejection, the unknown, persecution.

Q. As you look at this list, how does temptation most often come in your life?

Q. The next time you are tempted, what is one thing you can do to resist it?

As you mature in Christ and learn to depend on the Holy Spirit's guidance, you will become more and more sensitive to the times temptation is before you. When you are tempted, don't say, "The temptation is too strong," and give in to it. If you are abiding in God, the Holy Spirit has promised to give you the power to withstand temptation. Ask for His help!

## **Darrel's Story**

I had been dating Tori for two years and we were involved sexually. I attended a Christian youth camp and gave me life to Jesus. When I got home, I wanted to please my Savior, but when it came to my sexual relationship with Tori, I

rationalized my behavior—wanting God to approve. I thought He would understand my “needs” as a guy. But, because I wanted to please Christ, I kept reading the Bible and I realized that it said I needed to have sexual purity. I realized that this was actually an act of obedience to Christ, and that sex outside of marriage was wrong. I knew though, that I didn’t have the strength to break off my relationship with Tori.

So, by faith, I asked for the Holy Spirit to empower me to obey Him and help me to do what I knew I needed to do. The temptation to have sex with Tori was so strong that I realized we needed to quit seeing each other.

When I chose to obey God and broke off my relationship with Tori, the Holy Spirit gave me tremendous peace and joy. Since that decision, my life has been truly awesome! Darrel took God seriously, and “ran” from the temptation that could have entrapped him and hindered his walk with Christ. By faith, Darrel chose to obey God.

If you are involved in a battle over temptation, sin, or addiction to a substance or lifestyle, the power of the Holy Spirit is able to lift you out and give you total victory. Choose to trust Him! Focus on your relationship with God, who He is, what He is doing in your life!

2 Thessalonians 3:3 assures us, “But the Lord is faithful, and he will strengthen and protect you from the evil one.”

James 4:7 promises, “So submit to God. But resist the devil and he will flee from you.”

Memorize scripture, ask God to fill you with the Holy Spirit’s wisdom, hold on to God’s faithfulness ... the Holy Spirit will help you resist the temptation!

## **Application**

Q. As you consider all that has been discussed in this lesson, what is one thing you can begin to put into your life today that will help you the next time you are tempted?

Choose one of the verses presented in this lesson to memorize and focus on it the next time you are tempted.



## The Holy Spirit's Power to Overcome Evil

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Have you ever thought about the very real presence of “evil” in our world? Sometimes it’s hard to imagine ... and other times it is not! The truth is that evil *is* in our world and does surround us. There are places in the world where it may be more or less pervasive, but Satan is working throughout the world and in the lives of all believers. His ultimate goal is to persuade people to leave behind the relationship with God that defines them! A distorted, inaccurate view of God will result in a distorted, inaccurate response to Him.

Be assured that Satan will choose a precise weakness for his attack. If your marriage is not strong, that is the place where he will surely try to break through your lines of defense. If you struggle with honesty, he will throw a temptation at you that will compromise your ability to be truthful. If you struggle with your self-image, Satan will find a way for you to question God’s great love for you. A distorted, inaccurate view of God will result in a distorted, inaccurate response to Him!

God has given us a way to not only resist temptation but to also overcome evil! Ephesians 6 reveals that we have spiritual weaponry for fighting our spiritual battles! We need to be prepared!

“Finally, be strengthened in the Lord and in the strength of his power. Clothe yourselves with the full armor of God, so that you will be able to stand against the schemes of the devil. For our struggle is not against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the powers, against the world rulers of this darkness, against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavens. For this reason, take up the full armor of God so that you may be able to stand your ground on the evil day, and having done everything, to stand. Stand firm therefore, by fastening the belt of truth around your waist, by putting on the breastplate of righteousness, by fitting your feet with the preparation that comes from the good news of peace, and in all of this, by taking up the shield of faith with which you can extinguish all the flaming arrows of the evil one. And take the helmet of salvation and the sword of the Spirit (which is the word of God).” —Ephesians 6:10-17

Faith, salvation, truth, the Spirit ... we seldom think of these as protection—but that is exactly what they are!

## **The Belt of Truth**

Satan likes to interfere in our perceptions of reality through deception. The bottom line is that he doesn't want us to know the truth. God's truth shows us the way things really are—and His truth is the real truth! Each one of us must ground our lives on the truth of God's Word so that misguided ideas will not get in the way of our living for God.

Your thoughts, values, decisions, beliefs, fears, joys, emotions, and attitudes are all by-products of what is in your mind!

If we fill our minds with God's Word and instruction, our decisions and behavior will reflect that.

A distorted, inaccurate view of God will result in a distorted, inaccurate response to Him.

Q. In what ways are you putting God's truth into your life?

## **The Breastplate of Righteousness:**

We have been made righteous through Jesus Christ's death on the cross ... and nothing can change that! Satan wants us to believe that God sees us as failures and he will try to degrade our sense of worth through false guilt and accusations. God's righteousness, given to us through faith in Christ, protects our spiritual self-image!

Q. How can you focus your attention on God's righteousness?

## **The Shoes of Peace**

Peace protects the well-being and effectiveness of the body of Christ—it protects our unity and the shoes of peace help us to spread God's peace to others.

Q. In what ways are you currently experiencing God's peace?

## **The Shield of Faith**

A shield is a protective piece of armor! The shield of faith protects us from Satan's flaming arrows of temptation and doubt. We hold on to our trust in God and His ability to not only protect us but also empower us!

Q. How are you making your shield of faith stronger?

## **The Helmet of Salvation**

The helmet of salvation protects us against Satan's efforts to fill our minds with whatever will draw us away from God. He wants us to be self-centered. The helmet of salvation keeps our minds on Christ!

Q. What are you doing to train yourself to wear the helmet of salvation at all times?

## **The Sword of the Spirit**

The sword is the only offensive weapon on the list of spiritual armor. The Holy Spirit will give us wisdom for each tempting situation that confronts us. The Spirit is our source of power!

Q. What are you doing to prepare yourself to immediately pick up the sword of the Spirit when you are faced with temptation or evil of any kind?

Make sure you are wearing all the protection God gives for spiritual safety!

What you put into your mind influences your behavior! Fill your mind with God's Word! Everything a person puts into their mind, sticks—every word, every image, every idea.

What is in your mind comes out in your behavior! Satan will try to attack you through a "chink" in your "armor."

Make sure you are wearing all the protection God gives for spiritual safety!

Q. Which piece of armor are you most comfortable using?

Q. Which piece of spiritual armor do you need to proactively take up?

Sometimes the whole idea of aggressively fighting against Satan can be overwhelming, but it's important to remember that God is infinitely greater than anything Satan can throw at us. First John 4:4 says, "You are from God, little children, and have conquered them, because the one who is in you is greater than the one who is in the world."

Q. What in this lesson has challenged and/or inspired you?

Q. What can you do to make sure that you are ready with your spiritual armor the next time you need it?

## **Application**

Memorize Ephesians 6:10-17, really! This is quite a long passage, but by memorizing it, you will be reminded at critical times of God's ability and availability to help you when you need it most!

## Pray with Confidence

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We serve a great God! And that great God loves us unconditionally and wants what is best for us! As you learn more about the faithfulness of God and His Word, the more you will trust Him; and the more you trust Him, the more you will enjoy talking with Him. God is your perfect Heavenly Father and you can pray with confidence knowing that He is listening and will answer your prayers!

Why can you pray with confidence? God's Word gives many reasons, here are a few:

**Because you belong to Christ.** Many people pray instinctively, even if they do not have a relationship with God. However, it is because you have a relationship with God through Christ that God your heavenly Father hears your prayers! It is important that you remember that you pray to the only true God, our Creator, and heavenly Father.

In John 14:6, Jesus said, "I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me."

Praying in His name means far more than just adding those words as a sort of good-luck charm to the end of your prayer. It means you speak to your Father with all the authority of Christ! It is like placing a draft on the bank of heaven with the check signed by Jesus Christ! Asking in His name means on the basis of who He is. Many people today think that Jesus Christ doesn't really matter ... God will hear whoever calls out to him.

But the Bible is clear that it is through Jesus Christ alone that we come to God! It means you speak to your Father with all the authority of Christ!

**When you have a clean heart.** Psalm 66:18-20 says, "If I had harbored sin in my heart, the Lord would not have listened. However, God heard; he listened to my prayer. God deserves praise, for he did not reject my prayer or abandon his love for me!"

Jesus paid for your sin on the cross, but you need to confess that sin to God!

**When you have a forgiving spirit.** An unforgiving spirit is a terrible roadblock to your fellowship with God. If you hold anything against anyone, take care of it at once!

Mark 11:25-26 tells us, “Whenever you stand praying, if you have anything against anyone, forgive him, so that your Father in heaven will also forgive you your sins.”

You can be confident that God will answer any prayer that is according to His perfect will.

**When you come in faith.** You must have a believing heart if you are to communicate with your Father.

James 1:6 says, “But he must ask in faith without doubting, for the one who doubts is like a wave of the sea, blown and tossed around by the wind.”

Q. Which one of these reasons is the most encouraging to you today?

Q. Why is it encouraging to you?

Q. Do any of the above statements seem difficult for you?

Ask God today to help you to embrace his design for having a right relationship with Him.

“Dear friends, if our conscience does not condemn us, we have confidence in the presence of God, and whatever we ask we receive from him, because we keep his commandments and do the things that are pleasing to him. Now this is his commandment: that we believe in the name of his Son Jesus Christ and love one another, just as he gave us the commandment. And the person who keeps his commandments resides in God, and God in him. Now by this we know that God resides in us: by the Spirit he has given us.” —1 John 3:21-24

Q. What are the keywords in these verses from 1 John that really stand out to you?

Q. What do these verses teach you about talking to God?

God’s Word tells us that as his children we are always welcome in his presence!

Hebrews 4:16 explains, “Therefore let us confidently approach the throne of grace to receive mercy and find grace whenever we need help.”

Q. What do you think of when you see the words “confidently” and “mercy”?

Q. How are your ideas about talking with God changing as you read and think about the verses and passages contained in this lesson?

God answers the prayers of his children! John 15:7 says, “If you remain in me and my words remain in you, ask whatever you want, and it will be done for you.”

Q. What are some ways that you can remain in God?

“And this is the confidence that we have before him: that whenever we ask anything according to his will, he hears us.” —1 John 5:14

Q. Sometimes people like to focus on the word “anything” in this verse, rather than on the phrase “according to his will.” What are some things that you know are God’s will?

Q. What are some things that you know for sure are not God’s will?

You can be confident that God will answer any prayer that is according to His perfect will. Don’t give up on prayers that don’t get answered right away. Countless Christians will tell you stories of God’s faithfulness in answering prayers after many years of continual prayer. It is important to focus on God rather than on your requests when you pray. He already knows what you are praying about and His answer to your situation.

Trust His heart, His answers, and His timing.

### **Application**

Q. What is one way you can grow your confidence in prayer: memorize a scripture verse, take a step of faith, pray in a different way, another idea?

Commit yourself to whatever it is you have chosen to do ... and ask God for the strength and discipline to do it!

## Different Ways to Pray

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Prayer is talking with God: asking Him for guidance, praising Him for His goodness, sharing with Him the needs of ourselves and others, and knowing by faith that He hears and will grant our requests.” The important thing is to take time to be still with God. The big question is ... how?

Bill Bright once wrote, “Prayer is the most intimate communication ever devised. It is heart to heart, spirit to Spirit communication between creation and Creator. Enjoy His presence.”

We can pray in many ways! In this lesson, we will discuss a couple of different ideas and approaches that will help you to actually *pray*!

### **Be Still**

Allow God to speak quietly to you. First of all, take time to *be still*! The great theologian, A.W. Tozer, once said, “More spiritual progress can be made in one short moment of speechless silence in the awesome presence of God than in years of mere study.” This can be a frightening concept in a world of constant activity! But take the time *each day* to stop and be still with God. Let the Holy Spirit fill you.

Psalm 46:10 says, “Stop your striving and recognize that I am God! I will be exalted over the nations! I will be exalted over the earth!”

Q. How do you feel about being still with God?

### **Choose a Specific Time to Meet with God Every Day**

If you want your relationship with Christ to grow, plan to meet with Him every day! Many Christians find that morning works best before the busyness of the day sets in. But everyone is different! Choose a time that really works for you!

### **Prayer Notebook or Journal**

Many people find it helpful to keep a prayer notebook or journal. You can actually combine this with a study journal or notebook where you record all of your thoughts and anything that you are learning about your walk with God. Simply record your requests and how and when God answers them. A prayer notebook



can be especially helpful when you feel that God is far away. As you review the times and places when you have experienced his specific answers to your prayers you will be encouraged by His faithfulness to you!

Q. Have you ever done any kind of journaling? In what ways might this approach be helpful for you?

## **Claim God's Promises**

Apply the truth of God's Word to each day and claim His promises by praying verses of scripture. Here's a great verse to get you started:

"Trust in the Lord with all your heart, and do not rely on your own understanding. Acknowledge him in all your ways, and he will make your paths straight." — Proverbs 3:5-6

Pray: "Lord, today, I am going to trust You with all my heart. Help me not to depend on my own understanding, but to seek Your will for my life in each situation. Help me to trust that You will show me throughout the day which path to take."

## **The ACTS Approach to Prayer**

Rather than simply rambling all over the place when you pray, you can try to be more focused by using the acrostic ACTS. ACTS stands for four points: **A**doration, **C**onfession, **T**hanksgiving, and **S**upplication. It's a great way to center your thoughts on what you are talking to God about.

### **Adoration**

Adoration of God involves acknowledging His character and reflecting on His power, majesty, and holiness with humble praise and worship. Worship is a part of adoration. Confession is only possible for a person who is willing to submit to God.

Worship is not a fuzzy feeling brought on by soft lighting and music, nor is it limited to a *place* such as a church building. It does not consist simply of religious duty, listening to a great sermon, or hearing the choir. Singing hymns may not be worship if our hearts are not in the right place, and even prayer can be from purely selfish motives and therefore not worship. True worship is "*in Spirit and in truth*" (John 4:24).

One of the ways to worship and adore God is to use scripture. Pray a passage or use keywords to help you express your love and admiration for God.

As you read Psalm 145:1-6, look for keywords and phrases of worship ...

“I will extol you, my God, O king! I will praise your name continually! Every day I will praise you! I will praise your name continually! The LORD is great and certainly worthy of praise! No one can fathom his greatness! One generation will praise your deeds to another, and tell about your mighty acts! I will focus on your honor and majestic splendor, and your amazing deeds! They will proclaim the power of your awesome acts!”

#### Q. Keywords and phrases of worship

Worship is our *response* to God. It is what happens in our hearts when we know God well, and love Him deeply. This response comes from an intimate relationship with Him and is *enabled* by the Holy Spirit. Our worship includes praise, thankfulness, wonder, joy, delight, trust, obedience, awe, and reverence.

Worship is *recognizing* God’s majesty, glory, honor, power, wisdom, love, and justice. It is finding God to be of infinite worth! Worship is when we are overwhelmed by God’s sovereignty, person, and works. Express gratitude for all your blessings and privileges, as well as your trials and troubles!

Q. What are some adoration words you can use during your prayer time to worship God?

### **Confession**

When you sin and feel like no one cares about you, run to your Heavenly Father’s waiting arms. He will gladly welcome you! To restore fellowship with God, simply tell Him that you have sinned (name it), ask for His forgiveness, and then choose to let the Holy Spirit control your life. First John 1:9 promises, “But if we confess our sins, he is faithful and righteous, forgiving us our sins and cleansing us from all unrighteousness.”

Confession is only possible for a person who is willing to submit to God. You cannot spend your day being angry, deceitful, selfish, lustful, or proud, and then decide to “worship” God. Confess your sin to God and restore your relationship with Him!

## Thanksgiving

This part of your prayer involves expressing gratitude for all your blessings and privileges, as well as your trials and troubles! A thankful spirit is very pleasing to God.

“Always giving thanks to God the Father for each other in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ.” —Ephesians 5:20

Take time to thank God for all He is and does for you! Think about his love and grace. If you are having a hard time thanking Him, read the Psalms, and as you read the many praises, stop and make them your own. Think about God’s greatness and his great love for you!

## Supplication (Request)

God wants you to bring your requests to Him! By approaching Him through adoration, confession, and thanksgiving, you will often find that you are more in tune with Him as you present your requests to Him. Know that God delights in your requests! Never stop asking Him for things that are Biblical and within His will. He promises to answer those prayers ... in His time! Ask God to supply your needs, making special requests and desires known to Him. Don’t hesitate to pray for the needs and desires of others. As you read God’s Word and allow the Holy Spirit to control your life, you will find yourself naturally talking with God more.

The important thing here is to take the time to pray! Don’t get stuck on one type of approach. Keep your conversations with God alive! Pray with others, pray alone, pray any time!

Here is a helpful and concise resource in PDF: The Navigators “[How to Have a Daily Quiet Time](#)” [external link]

## Application

For the next 30 days start a prayer list. Add to it each day. Record how and when God responds:

- Ways you are growing in your relationship with God
- Specific issues regarding your family and friends
- Non-Christians you desire to know Christ
- Other Christians you can help in some way: physically, emotionally, or spiritually

- Other requests

## Share the Good News

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What is the most important thing that has ever happened to you? If you are a Christian, it was when you decided to receive Christ into your life as your personal Savior! And this is good news to share with others! As followers of Jesus, we have the privilege and responsibility of sharing the good news of Jesus Christ with those around us! When you “witness” about Jesus, you are telling about who He is and what He has done for you.

Think for a moment about the people you know and interact with on a regular basis who don’t have a personal relationship with Jesus Christ.

Q. Who are these people?

Q. Have you ever tried to have a conversation with them about Jesus?

Q. If so, what kind of response did you get? If you haven’t had a conversation, why not?

In Acts 1:8 Jesus said: “But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the farthest parts of the earth.”

This verse is for all believers! You are a unique person with a unique sphere of influence no one else has.

Q. What does this verse tell you about sharing the news of Jesus with others?

A witness is someone who tells what he or she knows about a given situation. When you “witness” about Jesus, you are telling about who He is and what He has done for you.

You are a unique person with a sphere of influence no one else has. As you ask the Holy Spirit to direct you, you will find opportunities to “witness” everywhere!

Q. What excites you most about talking with others about Jesus?

Q. What concerns you most about talking with others about Jesus?

Peter wrote these words in the New Testament:

“But set Christ apart as Lord in your hearts and always be ready to give an answer to anyone who asks about the hope you possess.” —1 Peter 3:15

Q. What keywords do you see in this verse?

Q. Why do you think Peter added the instruction here about gentleness and respect?

You don't have to make a complete presentation of the Gospel to make an impact for Jesus Christ. The key to sharing your relationship with Jesus is to be available. Ask the Holy Spirit to lead you to someone who is open to hearing more about Christ. If you sense that person is open to hearing about Jesus, but may not be ready for a real conversation about Him, you can:

- Invite them to attend church with you or to visit a study group you are part of.
- Ask them to join you at a Christian event.
- Introduce them to other Christians.
- Give them a Christian book or tract along with an invitation to discuss it with you after they finish reading it. Start out with an easy question to get you into a spiritual conversation.

If the Holy Spirit is directing you to have a conversation with someone, you can start out with an easy question to get you into a spiritual conversation. Here are a few ideas:

“Do you think about God very often?”

“Have you ever read the Bible?”

“What is your purpose in life? Why are you here?”

Q. Write down a couple of conversation starters of your own that would probably work in your situation and circumstances.

One of the greatest problems we all face is the problem of getting started. This is a great barrier to communication of the good news of Jesus Christ. The great evangelist Bill Bright once said, “Successful witnessing is simply taking the initiative to share Christ in the power of the Holy Spirit—and leaving the results to God.”

Do not wait for people to come to you. Go to them with the good news! Be friendly. Focus the conversation on Jesus Christ. Ask God for wisdom as you talk. God loves this person. You don't need to be pushy or preachy or combative. Expect results. When you are under the Holy Spirit's control and you talk about Jesus, you can expect results ... not on the basis of positive thinking but because of your confidence in God and His love for people! Expect people to respond because Jesus himself has commissioned us to go into all the world and spread the good news!

Most people reject Christianity because they really don't understand what it is all about, or they misunderstand and think it is just "religion." They don't realize being a Christian means having a relationship with God through Jesus Christ!

The best way to witness ... so that people really understand what the Bible says ... is to stick to the facts of who Jesus is. For this reason, it can be very helpful to use a good Gospel tract, such as [\*Would You Like to Know God Personally\*](#) by [Cru](#) or [\*The Bridge to Life\*](#) by [The Navigators](#).

This JO App also has several articles ("Evangelistic Articles") and videos ("Evangelistic Videos") you can share with others. Explore "Share Jesus" from the main menu.

If you are really ambitious, you can memorize this information during your daily time with God and then you'll have it available to you whenever you want to share it! Many times it can be helpful to share your personal testimony. Your "testimony" is when you "testify" as to what God is doing in your life. Your testimony should be short—less than 5 minutes—and should focus on how Christ has changed your life ... and how much He means to you. Be enthusiastic ... but not phony. Be transparent. As you think about your testimony consider these three questions:

"What was my life like before I had a relationship with Jesus Christ?"

"When did I begin my relationship with Jesus Christ?"

"What has God been doing in my life since I began my relationship with Jesus Christ?"

Take time to write out your testimony. Share it with a trusted friend and get some feedback. Keep your sharing short and to the point. Stay Focused! You fight a spiritual battle when you share Christ with an unbeliever.

There may be unusual interruptions ...or the person might try to evade the real issues and get you off track. Focus on Christ's love and his death on the cross. Emphasize how important that person is to God. At some point in the conversation, as the Holy Spirit leads, ask for a decision. Expect God to be working in their heart. Ask one of the following questions:

"Does this make sense to you?"

"Would you like to have a relationship with God through Jesus Christ?"

"Would you like to ask Jesus to be a part of your life?"

Finally, if they are ready to receive Christ, pray with them, using the prayer in your tract (or go back to lesson 3 at the beginning of all of this study!). Encourage them to find a church or another Christian to help them grown in their relationship with God.

When you wake up each morning, thank the Lord Jesus that He lives within you, tell Him that you are available, and stay alert so He can use you to speak of His love and forgiveness at every opportunity throughout the whole day.

### **Application**

Ask God to bring someone into your life whom you can introduce to Jesus!



## Knowing Our Great God

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God is totally amazing ... and His greatness is far beyond our human understanding.

*However*, even though we can't *totally* understand God's greatness, the Bible does give us a picture of who He is! There are actually ten fundamental character qualities of God: God is sovereign, eternal, all-knowing, all-powerful, present everywhere, unchanging, holy, just, love, and truth.

Sometimes those words can seem intimidating or even irrelevant. But they are important words that ground us in really knowing and trusting God! Knowing God's character will help us to really know and trust Him!

In this lesson, you will learn about the first five of those attributes. One or two scripture passages are included for each one, but the Bible is filled with many more descriptions of God's character. You can easily use an online Bible reference such as [Bible Gateway](#) to learn more about each attribute of God and deepen your understanding of who God is. As you consider each character quality, take time to think about each one and how that specific attribute shapes your view of God ... and your relationship with Him.

### God is Sovereign

The word "sovereign" refers to a supreme power having freedom from external control. When we refer to God as sovereign, we are saying that He alone has control of the universe. He is in charge of all things. He has complete authority to do whatever pleases Him. Nothing is out of His control. God is sovereign . . . He alone has control of the universe.

Consider these two verses from the Bible:

"The LORD has established his throne in heaven, and his kingdom extends over everything." —Psalm 103:19

"And we know that all things work together for good for those who love God, who are called according to his purpose." —Romans 8:28

Q. What do these verses mean to you personally?

Q. What can we learn about trusting God's sovereignty from these two passages?

Q. If I trust in God's sovereignty, I will ...

### **God is Eternal**

We live in a time dimension. God does not. God has always existed ... and He always will. When we join God in heaven, we will live forever with Him. He gives us eternal life! Being eternal, God is not bound by time. He lives in an everlasting "now," without past or future. Having always existed, He sees the past and future as clearly as the present and simultaneously. With this perspective, He has infinite understanding as to what is best for us.

"The grass dries up, the flowers wither, but the decree of our God is forever reliable." —Isaiah 40:8

"Your throne, O God, is permanent. The scepter of your kingdom is a scepter of justice." —Psalm 45:6

Q. What do the two verses above tell us about God?

Q. If I believe that God is eternal, I will ...

### **God is All-Knowing**

God knows everything! He knows everything in the past. He knows everything that is going on in the universe now. And He knows everything that is going to happen in the future. God is never surprised!

Psalm 139 tells us a lot about God and how much he knows about each one of us! Read this passage and write down all of the phrases that are meaningful to you.

1. O Lord, you examine me and know.
2. You know when I sit down and when I get up; even from far away you understand my motives.
3. You carefully observe me when I travel or when I lie down to rest; you are aware of everything I do.
4. Certainly my tongue does not frame a word without you, O Lord, being thoroughly aware of it.
5. You squeeze me in from behind and in front; you place your hand on me.
6. Your knowledge is beyond my comprehension; it is so far beyond me, I am unable to fathom it.

7. Where can I go to escape your Spirit? Where can I flee to escape your presence?
  8. If I were to ascend to heaven, you would be there. If I were to sprawl out in Sheol, there you would be.
  9. If I were to fly away on the wings of the dawn, and settle down on the other side of the sea.
  0. Even there your hand would guide me, your right hand would grab hold of me.
  1. If I were to say, "Certainly the darkness will cover me, and the light will turn to night all around me.
  2. Even the darkness is not too dark for you to see, and the night is as bright as day; darkness and light are the same to you."
  3. Certainly you made my mind and heart; you wove me together in my mother's womb.
  4. I will give you thanks because your deeds are awesome and amazing. You knew me thoroughly;
  5. my bones were not hidden from you, when I was made in secret and sewed together in the depths of the earth.
  6. Your eyes saw me when I was inside the womb. All the days ordained for me were recorded in your scroll before one of them came into existence.
  7. How difficult it is for me to fathom your thoughts about me, O God! How vast is their sum total!
  8. If I tried to count them, they would outnumber the grains of sand. Even if I finished counting them, I would still have to contend with you.
  9. If only you would kill the wicked, O God! Get away from me, you violent men!
  0. They rebel against you and act deceitfully; your enemies lie.
  1. O Lord, do I not hate those who hate you, and despise those who oppose you?
  2. I absolutely hate them, they have become my enemies!"
  3. Examine me, O God, and probe my thoughts! Test me, and know my concerns!
  4. See if there is any idolatrous way in me, and lead me in the everlasting way!"
- Q. Because I know that God is All-Knowing, I ...

## God is Present Everywhere

This universe is about thirty billion light years across ... and contains at least ten trillion stars (more than all the grains of sand on earth!). Yet God is present on every star, and in every inch of space. It really is more than we can imagine! We cannot hide from Him or act without His knowledge. God is always with us!

“Where can I go to escape your Spirit? Where can I flee to escape your presence? If I were to ascend to heaven, you would be there. If I were to sprawl out in Sheol, there you would be.” —Psalm 139:7-8

Q. What does this tell you about God’s presence?

Q. When I know that God is Present Everywhere, I ...

Several great resources for learning more about God’s character include: *God: Discover His Character* by Dr. Bill Bright and *The Knowledge of the Holy* by A. W. Tozer.

## Application

Q. Of the five attributes listed in this study, which one is most real to you?

Q. Which one gives you the most comfort?

Q. Which one is most confusing?

Q. Which one do you want to learn more about?

Read and pray David’s prayer in 1 Chronicles 29:11-13: “O Lord, you are great, mighty, majestic, magnificent, glorious, and sovereign over all the sky and earth! You, Lord, have dominion and exalt yourself as the ruler of all. You are the source of wealth and honor; you rule over all. You possess strength and might to magnify and give strength to all. Now, our God, we give thanks to you and praise your majestic name!”

## Knowing Our Perfect God

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We have a relationship with a big God and it is important to learn about all of His character. If we only focus on one or two of his attributes, we will have a distorted image of who He *really* is.

In the lesson previous to this one, we considered how God is sovereign, eternal, all-knowing, all-powerful, and present everywhere. This lesson will cover another five of God's character attributes: the fact that He is unchanging, holy, just, love, and truth.

One or two scripture passages are included for each attribute, but the Bible is filled with many more descriptions of God's character. You can easily use an on-line Bible reference such as Bible Gateway ([www.biblegateway.com](http://www.biblegateway.com)) to learn more about each attribute of God and deepen your understanding of who God is. As you consider each character quality, take time to think about each one and how that specific attribute shapes your view of God ... and your relationship with Him.

### God is Unchanging

Since we are always changing our minds or moods, it is hard to imagine anyone or anything that is always the same. In all of our human relationships, change is inevitable. But with God, no change is possible. His character is unchanging. He never changes his mood, never "cools off," and never stops loving us, which means that He is completely trustworthy, dependable, and stable. It's important to learn about all of His character.

God never changes ... his love for you also never changes. It doesn't fluctuate with your emotions or deeds.

Q. What do the following verses tell you about God's unchanging character?

"Since, I, the Lord, do not go back on my promises, you, sons of Jacob, have not perished." —Malachi 3:6

"Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever!" —Hebrews 13:8

God is completely trustworthy, dependable, and stable.

Q. If I believe that God is unchanging, I will ...

## **God is Holy**

God is righteous and set apart from us. His holiness means He is perfect in every way. God cannot lie. He is totally trustworthy.

God has never thought an unrighteous thought ... and never will! He is absolutely pure and perfect in every way! Holiness is a part of God's very essence. It is unique to God and alone, and it is beyond our comprehension.

Psalm 145:17-20 teaches:

"The Lord is just in all his actions, and exhibits love in all he does. The Lord is near all who cry out to him, all who cry out to him sincerely. He satisfies the desire of his loyal followers; he hears their cry for help and delivers them. The Lord protects all those who love him, but he destroys all the wicked."

Q. What do you learn about God's holiness from the verses in Psalm 145?

"And I saw the dead, the great and the small, standing before the throne. Then books were opened, and another book was opened—the book of life. So the dead were judged by what was written in the books, according to their deeds. The sea gave up the dead that were in it, and Death and Hades gave up the dead that were in them, and each one was judged according to his deeds. Then Death and Hades were thrown into the lake of fire. This is the second death—the lake of fire. If anyone's name was not found written in the book of life, that person was thrown into the lake of fire." —Revelation 20:12-15

Q. What do you learn about God's holiness from the verses in Revelation?

Sin is the exact opposite of God's nature ... and without Christ's death for you on the cross, you would be totally rejected from his presence. Christ's death and resurrection give you access to our Holy God. This holiness is truly beyond explanation.

Q. Knowing that God is holy means ...

## **God is Just**

When we say that God is just, we are saying that He is perfectly and completely fair. God is the supreme judge of the universe. He cannot make a mistake ... and He is always totally fair in His judgments.

Jeremiah 9:24 tells us “I the LORD, act out of faithfulness, fairness, and justice in the earth and that I desire people to do these things.”

God will always be fair by his perfect standard.

Q. What do you learn about God’s character when you read the following passage?

“There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus. For the law of the life-giving Spirit in Christ Jesus has set you free from the law of sin and death. For God achieved what the law could not do because it was weakened through the flesh. By sending his own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh and concerning sin, he condemned sin in the flesh, so that the righteous requirement of the law may be fulfilled in us, who do not walk according to the flesh but according to the Spirit.” —Romans 8:1-4

Q. Because God is just, I can be confident that ...

## **God is Love**

God will never love you less ... and He cannot love you more! The Bible tells us that God doesn’t just have love, “God *is* love!” (1 John 4:16). The fact that your heavenly Father sent Jesus to suffer and die for you on the cross demonstrates the depth of his love for you. “God is love!”

Q. What do you learn about God’s love when you read the following verses?

“Dear friends, let us love one another, because love is from God, and everyone who loves has been fathered by God and knows God. The person who does not love does not know God, because God is love.” —1 John 4:7-8

“That Christ will dwell in your hearts through faith, so that, because you have been rooted and grounded in love, you will be able to comprehend with all the saints what is the breadth and length and height and depth, and thus to know the love of Christ that surpasses knowledge, so that you will be filled up to all the fullness of God.” —Ephesians 3:17-19

Q. Because God is love, I can ...

## **God is Truth**

The world is saying, “There are no absolutes. Truth is what you believe or what you say it is. What may be truth for you is not truth for me.”

Q. How would you define 'truth'?

In John 14:6, Jesus said: "I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me."

He also said in John 17:17, "Your word is truth."

God cannot lie. He is totally trustworthy. Everything He says is true. And His truth is clearly revealed in the Bible, His Word. Since God is truth, you can always count on Him ...and you can always trust His promises to you!

It is possible to *read* God's words of truth and not understand them or be changed by them. It is important to remember that we need God himself to reveal His truth to us. Since God is Truth, you can always count on Him ... and you can always trust his promises to you! Someone once said, "When you know God, really know God, what you don't know is irrelevant."

Q. Because God is truth, I can ...

Several great resources for learning more about God's character include *God: Discover His Character* by Dr. Bill Bright and *The Knowledge of the Holy* by A. W. Tozer.

### **Application**

Q. Of the five attributes listed in this study, which one is most real to you?

Q. Which one gives you most comfort?

Q. Which one is most confusing?

Q. Which one do you want to learn more about?



## Hear God's Word

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As we grow in our relationship with God, it is very important to take time to read and study the Bible. There are actually five basic ways for you to experience God's Word:

1. **Hear it**
2. **Read it**
3. **Study it**
4. **Memorize it**
5. **Meditate on it**

All of these ways to make God's Word a bigger part of your life are important. And it is important to use a combination of all five to really grow in your relationship with God. For the next couple of lessons, we will look at each one of these separately ... specifically in this lesson: "Hear it."

Hearing God's Word is the simplest way to get God's Word into your life ... and it involves listening.

Q. What are the ways you currently hear God's Word?

Whenever you hear God's Word, attempt to learn what the Holy Spirit is trying to teach you personally writing down your thoughts when possible. There are many ways you can hear God's Word: At your Church, in a Bible Study, from a teacher in a Bible school, on Bible tapes and CDs and DVDs, by attending Christian Seminars, through a friend, listening to Christian radio, reading Christian books ... non-fiction as well as fiction, and by searching online Bible-based web pages. It is important that when you are listening to anything that is not scripture, such as a Christian speaker, that you make sure that person is a reliable source of God's truth.

In the book of Acts we read that the New Testament Christians "eagerly received the message, examining the scriptures carefully every day to see if these things were so." —Acts 17:11

Q. Why do you suppose it is important to examine the Scriptures to see if what you are hearing is true?

Whenever you hear God's Word, attempt to discern what the Holy Spirit is trying to teach you personally, writing down your thoughts when possible.

"Consequently faith comes from what is heard, and what is heard comes through the preached word of Christ." —Romans 10:17

Q. In what ways can your faith be strengthened when you hear the Word of God?

As Christians, we are disciples of Christ who are committed to learning His truth and following His directions.

"So I say this, and insist in the Lord, that you no longer live as the Gentiles do, in the futility of their thinking. They are darkened in their understanding, being alienated from the life of God because of the ignorance that is in them due to the hardness of their hearts." —Ephesians 4:17-18

Romans 12:2 challenges us with a more positive approach with these words: "Do not be conformed to this present world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind, so that you may test and approve what is the will of God—what is good and well-pleasing and perfect."

Listening is the easiest way to get God's Word into your mind, but it isn't a totally passive endeavor! Listening is the easiest way to get God's Word into your mind, but it isn't a totally passive endeavor! As you listen to God's Word, you can use the following steps and questions to apply God's truth in your life.

### **Receptivity—Check Your Attitude**

God will not push His way into your life. He is waiting to transform you, but He also is waiting for you to open yourself up to Him. If God sees that you are not really willing to obey Him, then there is no point in revealing more truth to you. Because He is your loving Father, He will wait, but He desires a humble and submissive attitude.

The question to ask here is: Am I *willing* to let God's truth change me and my life?

Q. What is the most recent thing you have heard from God's Word?

Q. On a scale of 1 to 10, how receptive were you to that specific truth?

Q. Is there anything you can or should do to increase your receptivity to hearing God's truth?

## **Comprehension—Check Your Understanding**

There are several questions to ask when you are reflecting upon your comprehension:

What new truth have I become aware of through reading my Bible, going to church and/or listening to other Christians?

What does this truth mean in relation to what I think, say, and do?

What are the consequences of not applying this truth to my life?

What benefits will I experience from acting on this truth?

Q. What is the most recent truth you have become aware of through hearing God's Word?

Q. What does this truth mean to you?

Q. As you consider this truth, what consequences or benefits will you experience if you act or don't act on this truth?

## **Conviction—Check Your Level of Belief**

The question to ask yourself regarding your conviction is:

Why am I convinced that it is important to apply this revealed truth to my life?

Q. What do you think influences your conviction about God's truth?

Q. How is conviction measured?

Q. Is there anything you can do to boost your conviction concerning God's truth in your life?

## **Transformation—Check Your Commitment to Application**

There are several questions here that will help you evaluate your commitment:

What steps must I take to apply this truth to my life?

Am I allowing Satan to use fear or difficulties to prevent me from following through with these steps of application?

Am I allowing other concerns or my desire for wealth or pleasure to distract me from following through with these steps of application?

Q. As you consider this final step, are you often committed to the application of God's truth to your life? Why or why not?

Q. What is the greatest hindrance to the application of God's truth to your life?

Q. How can you overcome this hindrance?

Q. What positive things have you experienced when you have applied God's truth to your life?

### **Application**

James 1:22 encourages us with these words: "But be sure you live out the message and do not merely listen to it and so deceive yourselves."

Q. How can you listen to more of God's Word on a regular basis?

Q. What are you currently doing with the Word of God that you hearing?

## Read God's Word

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Reading God's Word can make a big impact on your life. As was presented in the previous lesson, there are five basic ways for you to benefit from God's Word: hear it, read it, study it, memorize it, and meditate on it. In this lesson, we will consider how *reading* God's Word can make a big impact on your life.

The purpose of reading God's Word is to change your life! The great preacher D. L. Moody said it well: "The Scriptures were not given to increase our knowledge, but to change our lives." With that in mind, it is important to remember that when you are reading the Bible, it's best to read it slowly and thoughtfully.

You should find some way to record your thoughts and be able to record key verses. Reading is more than just "reading" ... you need to think as well! "Reading" is not as intense as "studying," but you still have an intention of gaining something from the text!

"Every scripture is inspired by God and useful for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the person dedicated to God may be capable and equipped for every good work." —2 Timothy 3:16-17

Q. What do you learn about God's Word from these verses?

As you read your Bible, ask yourself questions, and then answer them! Make your reading enjoyable! Go on a "hunt" to find promises God has for you.

This is especially easy if you are using an online resource. You can simply type in a keyword and off you go! Record the references so you can refer back to them later.

Many people find it helpful to keep a journal. You can record what you are reading and learning from the Bible as well as any other insights God gives you about your relationship with Him, how He is working in your life, and what He is doing in and through you. A journal can be a great reminder of God's blessings and strength!

If this is your first adventure in reading the Bible, it can be easier to start in the New Testament, reading at least one of the four Gospels (Matthew, Mark, Luke, or John). Many teachers recommend starting with John. The book of Acts tells about the actions of the early Christians. Acts is a "must-read" at some point for all Christians. After Acts, you'll find the letters to the first Christian churches, which

give instruction and guidance for daily living. And finally, in the book of Revelation, you will see how Christ is going to end all things in this world and begin ruling as “King of kings and Lord of lords.”

Q. What in the Bible are you currently reading? What are you learning?

One way to read the Bible is to simply open it and read whatever is in front of you. You can definitely gain from this approach, but being a little more systematic will be more beneficial to you in the long run. If you can actually write down some of what you are reading and thinking, that can also be valuable.

Start your reading time with two sheets of paper. On one, write down the things God is teaching you as you read, and on the second, jot down the things that come to mind that you need to take care of in your life. That will allow you to stay focused. There is no pressure. Simply read until God shows you something, then stop and think. As you read, ask yourself some of the following questions, and answer them!

What does this mean?

What caused this situation?

Why did God include this?

Why is this important?

Is this really true?

What difference does knowing this make?

What action should I take?

What am I missing?

What can I claim for myself?

In what ways am I really trusting God?

Talk to the Lord about what you read and make some notes. When you start to read God’s Word on a regular basis, you will find yourself growing in your relationship with your heavenly Father! As you read, talk to God about everything you are thinking. Cultivate the sense of His presence and His love. Worship Him. Thank Him for what you are reading and learning and thinking and experiencing. Give Him your intense attention and concentration Praise Him.

Many people find it helpful to have a daily reading program helps them read steadily through the entire Bible in a systematic way. There are many plans available. Whatever method you choose to use, get started! Each day jot down the chapters that you read and then you will know where to start the next time. Modify the plan to suit your needs.

### **Application**

Q. What goal can you set for reading God's Word?

Q. How do you plan to achieve your goal?

## Study God's Word

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Studying God's Word will make a difference in your life! When you study God's Word you will gain insight into who God is and what He wants to do in your life. This topic is a continuation of our study on the five basic ways for you to experience God's Word: hear it, read it, study it, memorize it, and meditate on it. In this lesson, we will consider how *studying* God's Word will make a difference in your life.

Proverbs 2:1-5 instructs us: "My child, if you receive my words, and store up my commands inside yourself, by making your ear attentive to wisdom, and by turning your heart to understanding, indeed, if you call out for discernment—shout loudly for understanding—if you seek it like silver, and search for it like hidden treasure, then you will understand how to fear the Lord, and you will discover knowledge about God."

Q. What are some of the key action words in the above passage?

Q. What are some of the keywords used to describe God's Word?

Each time you approach God's Word in study, you need to pray for God's direction and then, observe, interpret, and apply what you are reading.

Q. What insight do you get from the following verse in 2 Timothy about the importance of studying God's Word?

"Make every effort to present yourself before God as a proven worker who does not need to be ashamed, teaching the message of truth accurately." —2 Timothy 2:15

Remember how in a previous lesson we talked about the importance of receptivity? Psalm 119:18 models for us our *asking* God to open us up to His Word: "Open my eyes so I can truly see the marvelous things in your law!"

Q. When are the times in your life when you are most open to God's Word?

Q. When are you not open to the truth of God's Word?

Q. Is there anything you can do to stay more open to what the Bible has to say to your life?



The reason you need to study God's Word is to gain insight into who God is and what He wants to do in your life! One way that you can achieve good results from your study time is to write down what you discover. Reading is faster than study and gives you the overall picture, but study requires that you *think* and *remember*. Yes, this is more time-consuming ... but it will be worth the effort!

Q. What are you presently learning from your study of God's Word?

"Jesus said to the people who believed in him: 'If you continue to follow my teaching, you are really my disciples and you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free.'" —John 8.31-32

Q. What do you learn from these verses?

There are actually several ways you can study the Bible:

- A word (such as grace, faith, love, sin)
- A single verse (such as Hebrews 12:1; 1 John 1.5)
- A passage or chapter (such as Ephesians 1, or Ephesians 1:15-23, Proverbs 3)
- A book (any!)

## **A 4-Step Process**

Before you begin your study, consider this 4-step process to help you gain the most from your time in God's Word. Study is more than just reading. Reading is faster than study and gives you the overall picture, but study requires that you think and remember.

### **Step 1—Pray**

Ask the Holy Spirit for insight and understanding! Open yourself up to what God wants you to see in His Word today.

### **Step 2—Observe**

As you study the word, or verse, or passage, or book you've chosen, you are looking for answers to the following questions?

- What does it say?
- What does it reveal about God?
- What does it reveal about having a more intimate relationship with God?

- What does this teach me about faith, hope, and love?
- What new insights can I obtain about my new identity in Christ and how God has designed me?
- How does God want me to depend on Him for wisdom, strength, special abilities, and resources?
- What does this reveal about how God will meet my needs and accomplish His purposes?
- How can I resist Satan's schemes and seek refuge in God from evil?
- How does God direct our steps toward the fulfillment of His specific plan for our life?

Not all of the studies that you do will answer every one of these questions, but they provide a good framework for your thought and reflection. As you study the word, or verse, or passage, or book you've chosen, you are looking for answers to at least one of these questions.

### **Step 3—Interpret**

As you read and think and reflect, consider "What does this *mean*?" Here are a few other questions to help you identify the meaning of what you are studying:

- Is this passage to be interpreted literally or does it contain figurative words, phrases, or expressions?
- How does the *context* for this passage help in understanding its *meaning*?
- What other scriptures help to clarify or amplify the interpretation of this passage?
- What point is this trying to make?

### **Step 4—Apply**

This is the most important step! Ask yourself: What am I going to do with this new insight and understanding?

### **Specific Suggestions for Studying a Single Word**

It is actually much easier to study a *verse* when you are first starting to study the Bible. If you choose to study a single word, you can use on-line searching or you will need a good Bible concordance that contains single words and a list of the verse where that word is used. What you are looking for is the different ways that word is used and what is being communicated.

## Specific Suggestions for Studying a Single Verse

### Approach #1

Begin by reading the context of the verse ... what comes before it and after it.

Next, ask yourself, “Who is speaking, to whom, and what is the situation?”

Visualize yourself in the situation and customs of that time and place. If possible, read several different translations of the Bible (this is easy to accomplish with online resources such as [Bible Gateway](#)). Look up keywords in the dictionary and write down their definitions. Ask questions from the “Observe” step (Step 2) described earlier in this lesson. Take notes! Continue your study through the Step 3 and Step 4 processes!

### Approach #2

Another way to approach a verse study is to look at each *word* individually *within* the verse.

Here is an example using the first phrase of Psalm 118: 6: “The Lord is for me ...”

With this approach, you write the verse down the left side of your paper one word at a time. In some ways, we are crossing over into the “Meditate on It” process of experiencing God’s Word (to be discussed in a later lesson), but it is important to remember that all of these approaches interact with one another ... not one truly stands alone! As you look at the first word, write down as much as you can about that word. Then take the second word of the verse, and spend time thinking and writing about that word, and so on until you finish the verse or phrase. Then write a reflection statement summarizing your insights.

The Lord—the mighty, almighty, creator, sovereign, loving, glorious God

is—right now, presently, an absolute certainty

for—purpose, goal, God has my best interests at heart, He is on my side, He knows what is best for me

me—personally, not in general, but specifically, by name

Reflection: It is awesome and exciting to contemplate me personally having such intimacy...with God himself!!

### **Approach #3**

Read the passage in at least two different versions of the Bible and then write what it means to you personally.

### **Specific Suggestions for Studying a Passage or Chapter**

First, read the entire passage or chapter. Next, make an overall outline of what you have just read. Then, give it a title. Now determine which verse is most meaningful to you at this time in your life. Finally, consider what challenges you see in the passage.

### **Specific Suggestions for Studying a Book**

In many ways, the study of a book is similar to studying a passage or chapter, there's just more of it at one time, but the process remains the same.

Another great way to study a book of the Bible is to go through a study that has already been put together! These are available at various online sites or through a Christian bookstore.

As you continue to study God's Word, assemble books and Bible resources that will help you continue to grow in your relationship with God. Bible concordances contain Biblical words listed alphabetically, with indications to enable you to find the passages of the Bible where the words occur. If you purchase a concordance it should match the translation of the Bible that you are using. A Bible commentary will have explanations of various verses.

### **Application**

Choose one way to study the Bible and work at it diligently for the next week or two (depending on what you have chosen to study).

Q. My approach

Q. What I plan to study

Q. When I plan to study

## Memorize God's Word

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As we have been discussing, there are five basic ways for you to grow in your knowledge and experience with God's Word: hear it, read it, study it, memorize it, and meditate on it. In this lesson we will consider how *memorizing* God's Word will help you tremendously.

One of the most important reasons for memorizing Scripture is because our memories are short. Research has shown that after 24 hours you accurately remember:

5% of what you hear

15% of what you read

35% of what you study

57% of what you see and hear

100% of what you memorize

Noted author and counselor, Henry Brandt, once wrote: "I still consider Bible memorization the single most important aid in my Christian life and in my counseling."

Dawson Trotman, past president of the Navigators said, "I know of no form of intake of the Word which pays greater dividends for the time invested than Scripture memory."

In Matthew 4:1-10, we see Jesus overcoming Satan's temptations by using scripture. He probably didn't have the scriptures in written form ... he was using them because he had learned them as a child and could recite them! Here's the story:

"Then Jesus was led by the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil. After he fasted forty days and forty nights he was famished. The tempter came and said to him, 'If you are the Son of God, command these stones to become bread.' But he answered, 'It is written, "Man does not live by bread alone, but by every word that comes from the mouth of God."'"

“Then the devil took him to the holy city, had him stand on the highest point of the temple, and said to him, ‘If you are the Son of God, throw yourself down. For it is written, “He will command his angels concerning you” and “with their hands, they will lift you up so that you will not strike your foot against a stone.” Jesus said to him, ‘Once again it is written: “You are not to put the Lord your God to the test.’

“Again, the devil took him to a very high mountain, and showed him all the kingdoms of the world and their grandeur. And he said to him, ‘I will give you all these things if you throw yourself to the ground and worship me.’ Then Jesus said to him, ‘Go away, Satan! For it is written: “You are to worship the Lord your God and serve only him.” Then the devil left him, and angels came and began ministering to his needs.”

Q. What do you learn from this passage that you can apply to your own life?

People often say “I just can’t memorize things.” But that simply is not true! We memorize information all the time for business, sales presentations, stock market quotes, sports, and daily commitments. Athletes memorize whole playbooks, team standings, player stats, etc. It’s not a memory that is lacking, it’s motivation.

It’s actually easy to memorize verses:

Start with one verse. Write it down if possible.

Repeat it several times.

Say it in your own words. Identify why it is important.

Repeat it to a friend or family member.

Think about how you might apply it to your life.

Once you have it memorized, review it every day for 30 days.

It will be yours to take with you wherever you go!

Here are a few verses for you to memorize to get started!

“How can a young person maintain a pure life? By guarding it according to your instructions! ... In my heart I store up your words, so I might not sin against you.”  
—Psalm 119:9, 11

Q. What do these verses teach you about God’s Word?

“Fix these words of mine into your mind and being, and tie them as a reminder on your hands and let them be symbols on your forehead. Teach them to your children and speak of them as you sit in your house, as you walk along the road,

as you lie down, and as you get up.” —Deuteronomy 11:18-19

Q. Why is this a good verse to commit to memory?

“Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly, teaching and exhorting one another with all wisdom, singing psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs, all with grace in your hearts to God.” —Colossians 3:16

Q. In what ways is this verse an encouragement to you?

“For I am convinced that neither death, nor life, nor angels, nor heavenly rulers, nor things that are present, nor things to come, nor powers, nor height, nor depth, nor anything else in creation will be able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord.” —Romans 8:38-39

Q. Why do you think this is a good verse to commit to memory?

One way to improve your knowledge of the Bible, deepen your walk with God, and memorize verses that will carry you through the hard times of life is by using *The Navigator’s Topical Memory System*. You can online search for a way to obtain it or it is available in most Christian book stores.

## **Application**

Q. What can you do to keep yourself motivated to memorize scripture?

Choose a verse or passage today to start memorizing!

Q. This is what I am going to memorize:

## Meditate on God's Word

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As we've considered the different ways for you to grow in your relationship with God by hearing, reading, studying, and memorizing His Word, we've actually also been *meditating* on His truth, which is the focus of this lesson. Meditating involves taking a prayerful, serious approach to reflecting on a specific verse or passage.

As you've learned how to listen and read and study and memorize, you've also been meditating. But in this lesson, we're going to specifically focus on meditation as its own discipline.

There really is no better way to grow in your relationship with Christ than to meditate on God's promises throughout the day. Whenever something stressful happens (and it will), you can think about a verse that applies to your situation.

Meditating means you are giving extended, careful thought to God's Word with the intent of conforming your life to His will. Meditating on God's Word will result in knowing Him intimately and being obedient to Him in everything. Meditating means you are giving extended, careful thought to God's Word with the intent of conforming your life to His will.

Two questions to consider whenever you are meditating on a passage of scripture:

1. What is the meaning of this verse or passage based on its context?
2. How can/should this verse or passage affect my life?

Use these two questions right now as you consider Philippians 4:6-7:

"Do not be anxious about anything. Instead, in every situation, through prayer and petition with thanksgiving, tell your requests to God. And the peace of God that surpasses all understanding will guard your hearts and minds in Christ Jesus."

Q. What is the meaning of this passage based on its context (look it up!)

Q. How can/should this passage affect my life?



## Power Over Bondage

In 1977, New York City was in turmoil because a troubled twenty-four-year-old man, David Berkowitz, who the media labeled “Son of Sam,” went on a killing spree. His target was young women, and before he was finally caught, five young women and one man were dead.

During his time in prison, David was approached by a young prisoner named Ricky Lopez. Ricky told David that regardless of what he had done, Jesus loved him and died for him.

Ricky gave David a Bible. As David Berkowitz read the Bible, God’s power began breaking him of his bondage to sin. In time, the Word of God brought him to a point of complete repentance—and the “Son of Sam” surrendered his life completely to Christ. Today, as he continues to serve his life sentence, David Berkowitz is the chaplain’s assistant at Sullivan Correctional Facility. (Read this, and other stories of God’s transforming power, in *Fresh Power*, by Jim Cymbala.)

David Berkowitz was transformed because he replaced his human viewpoint of life with God’s viewpoint. He meditated on God’s truth! There really is no better way to grow in your relationship with God than to meditate on His promises throughout the day.

Psalm 1:1-3 says, “How blessed is the one who does not follow the advice of the wicked, or stand in the pathway with sinners, or sit in the assembly of scoffers! Instead, he finds pleasure in obeying the LORD’s commands; he meditates on his commands day and night. He is like a tree planted by flowing streams; it yields its fruit at the proper time, and its leaves never fall off. He succeeds in everything he attempts.”

Make sure your roots are deeply planted in God’s Word ... just like a tree that survives and grows and bears fruit because its roots tap deep into the soil below.

Q. What are you presently doing to help your roots grow deep into God’s Word?

In Psalm 119:97-105, what promises are made to the person who continually meditates?

“O how I love your law! All day long I meditate on it.

Your commandments make me wiser than my enemies, for I am always aware of them.

I have more insight than all my teachers, for I meditate on your rules.

I am more discerning than those older than I, for I observe your precepts.  
I stay away from every evil path, so that I might keep your instructions.  
I do not turn aside from your regulations, for you teach me.  
Your words are sweeter in my mouth than honey!  
Your precepts give me discernment. Therefore I hate all deceitful actions.  
Your word is a lamp to walk by, and a light to illumine my path.”

Q. Promises \_\_\_\_\_

Luke 6:45 says,

“The good person out of the good treasury of his heart produces good, and the evil person out of his evil treasury produces evil, for his mouth speaks from what fills his heart.”

Q. What important lesson does this verse communicate about our meditation on God’s Word?

Meditating means thinking deeply about something. To meditate is to focus your thinking on something specific. It means to focus, contemplate, reflect, or think deeply about. You do it long enough that something changes (attitude, purpose, conviction), and then you have the perspective and wisdom to get up and make changes. In other words, meditation causes life change!

Q. What do you most often meditate on?

Q. What do you need to do in order to make God’s Word the focus of your meditation?

It is important to think rightly and to have God’s perspective and discernment about everything, including money, Jesus, sin, marriage, sex, divorce, obedience, kids, work, honesty, trouble, yourself, the future, and a host of other things. Think like Jesus thinks, have His mindset. Meditation on God’s Word will help you to do that. But .... it will take planning and time. If you don’t plan it, it won’t happen.

J. I. Packer wrote: “Meditation is the activity of calling to mind, thinking over, dwelling on, and applying to oneself the various things that one knows about the works, ways, purposes, and the promises of God. Its effect is to humble us as we contemplate God’s greatness and our own littleness—to encourage and reassure us as we contemplate the unsearchable riches of God as displayed in the Lord Jesus Christ” (*Knowing God*).

So meditate, but don't meditate on your problems, your irritations, your hurts, and/or your enemies. Rather, meditate on the truth of God's Word! The purpose of meditation is a life change. You want to experience God! Meditate until you not only understand a passage of God's Word but until can't wait to apply it!

### **Application**

Q. What in this lesson on meditation is most meaningful to you?

Choose a verse or passage of scripture to meditate on ... and then do it!

## Anger

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As we think about being connected to other people in the body of Christ, it's good to stop and consider the topic of anger. What? Anger? Why? Because angry people are hard to get along with ... and they disrupt life in the body of Christ! Christian psychologist Henry Brandt spent nearly his entire professional career talking to Christians about letting God take care of their anger!

When was the last time you saw or experienced the result of someone's anger ... on the road, at the store, in your family, with a friend? Believe it or not, the one emotion that plagues everyone is ... anger. People seldom admit to actually being angry. Instead, they say, "I lost my temper," or "I was out of control" or "That person really annoyed me." Curious expressions, aren't they? Rarely does anyone say, "I was really ticked off and I sinned"? *Sin*? Really? Yes, really. The truth is that rarely is our anger in and of itself a sin ... but how we handle it often leads to sinful behavior. The one emotion that plagues everyone is ... anger. No matter how you express it, anger is still anger ... and it is a problem if you don't deal with it in an appropriate way.

Q. Think about it for a minute, what is it that causes you to be angry?

Q. What does your anger usually look like?

Q. In what ways has (or does) your anger result in hurting other people?

In his book entitled *Heart of the Problem*, Dr. Henry Brandt wrote, "I have never found anger to be a positive factor in problem-solving. I have never found anger to be righteous. It is always a hindrance to intelligent straight thinking and rational behavior. In an instant, anger can change a person from being satisfied, cheerful, and relaxed to being dissatisfied, unhappy, and tense. There is universal agreement that unrestrained anger can destroy us."

The things that make you angry are situations and people that are outside of you that cause something inside of you to react.

You can only correct what is wrong with your spirit by accessing God's power. Anger is defined as "an emotional reaction of extreme displeasure and/or antagonism." Other words we might use to describe anger are: annoyance, irritation, antagonism, resentment, and indignation. Anger is expressed in many

ways. It can be murderous rage or mild inner annoyance and irritation. You may not lose your temper and throw things, but you get terribly “irritated” about a lot of things. Many of us nurture our anger into something else: either a physical action or verbal assault that is hurtful, bitter, or a plan for revenge ... you name it!

Q. When is the last time you were angry about something or with someone?

Q. What are you angry about today?

What does a mean, angry, hostile Christian look like? Well, let’s take a look at the guy who walks into the office on Friday morning. His face is smiling and calm. However, as is the case with most people, he can usually control the way his face looks, but he can’t control his spirit. This guy is saying to himself, “My boss makes me mad, my wife drives me crazy, my kids annoy me, and my coworkers are idiots.” Where is this person supposed to go to find peace when he has all these people aggravating him all the time? He is angry and his anger is causing him to focus on many negative things. Throughout the morning he begins to interact in negative ways with all of these people. He sighs, he shouts, he rolls his eyes, he is sarcastic.

Your joy, happiness, and contentment do not depend on the behavior of other people. When you insist on life being the way you want it, all sorts of things will disturb you.

Q. How do you typically handle your anger?

Q. Does your behavior honor God?

If you really look at your anger, you will find that when you are angry, irritated, and frustrated it is because something has not gone your way. But, and here’s the problem, the things that make you angry are situations and people that are *outside* of you; and they are causing something *inside* of you to react. The problem is not really what is making you angry, but how you are responding to it. The problem is your spirit. And you can only correct what is wrong with your spirit by accessing God’s power.

Henry Brandt says that many people try to *cope* with their anger... but what they need is a *cure*! Angry reactions are triggered by anything that causes us to be annoyed, disgruntled, upset, uncomfortable, bitter, or envious. Contention, disagreement, discord, hostility, temper tantrums, rage, screaming, arguing, and anger are all words describing a fundamental response we exhibit when we don’t

get our own way! Strife, wrangling, arguing, and shouting are often the result. Nearly everyone thinks that their anger is a justifiable response to the way they were treated. God's Word teaches us to get rid of our anger.

Q. What are the triggers for your anger?

Q. When is the last time you blamed someone else for your reaction?

In Colossians 3:8, the Bible tells us to "put off all such things as anger, rage, malice, slander, abusive language from your mouth."

When you insist on life being the way *you* want it, all sorts of things will disturb you. The fact remains that each one of us needs to learn how to deal with our personal anger. Society's solutions include "ignoring it," "sharing" (or more accurately blasting) people with it so that we will feel better, hiding it, or finding a way to "control it." All of these solutions are actually asking us to simply "live with" the anger.

But as Henry Brandt points out in nearly all of his books, the Bible has another approach altogether. God's Word teaches us to get rid of our anger. Carefully study these verses:

"For human anger does not accomplish God's righteousness." —James 1:20

"A person who has a quick temper will do foolish things, and a person with crafty schemes will be hated." —Proverbs 14:17

"Scornful people inflame a city, but those who are wise turn away wrath." —Proverbs 29:8

"A fool lets fly with all his temper, but a wise person keeps it back." —Proverbs 29:11

"An angry person stirs up dissension, and a wrathful person is abounding in transgression." —Proverbs 29:22

"Do not be angry and frustrated! Do not fret! That only leads to trouble!" —Psalm 37:8

"Be angry and do not sin; do not let the sun go down on the cause of your anger. Do not give the devil an opportunity." —Ephesians 4:26-27

So how do we get rid of our anger? You cannot have a peaceful heart when you are allowing a number of things to “trigger” your emotions. Can you be “filled with the Spirit” when you are angry? Are you going to settle for being an angry person and justify it by saying, “That’s just the way I am?” You need to allow the Holy Spirit to rid you of your anger.

The idea here is not to learn to control, stuff or channel your anger into meaningful activity. Acknowledge your anger and let God deal with it. Now is the time to talk to God and acknowledge the anger you have become aware of and want to release. Forgive anyone you are holding a grudge against. Thank God for forgiving your sin of anger. Ask Him to bless the ones you are angry with and to love them through you. You will have a huge load lifted from your shoulders!

### **Application**

Take a notepad and pencil with you and for twenty-four hours list everything that “triggers” your anger ... in any form. Then take some time to evaluate what you have been angry about. You will be surprised! Talk to God about it. Ask the Holy Spirit to change you *from the inside*. Let God direct your emotional responses to your circumstances. Keep a record of how God is working in your life in this area.

## Forgiveness

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Forgiveness ... at times a very difficult word. A word that is critical to our relationship with God: We experience forgiveness because of what Christ did for us on the cross.

When someone hurts us, we are often willing to forgive them based on the severity of their offense. If the offense doesn't seem too severe, we will probably forgive them. But, if in our minds, or even in the minds of others, the offense is serious, we may hold our forgiveness back.

However, forgiveness is necessary for our relationships with others: We extend forgiveness because we have experienced it.

Jesus tells us: "For if you forgive others their sins, your heavenly Father will also forgive you. But if you do not forgive others, your Father will not forgive you your sins." —Matthew 6:14-15

What does this mean?

Forgiveness frees us from the non-productive and destructive emotions which chain and enslaved us to the object of our anger and pain. Sometimes a story can help us understand a concept better than an explanation ... Henry Brandt shares this story in his book, *Heart of the Problem*.

"At a conference in Zimbabwe, I told the audience the story of a Ugandan businessman I had met who had lost everything when Idi Amin's soldiers had seized his possession and his family had to flee to the forests. This businessman had peace in his heart only after he had forgiven the soldiers.

"After my morning address, I received a note requesting a private meeting. To my surprise, I found myself sitting across from a couple from Uganda who had been urged by some friends to attend this conference. Deeply disturbed by a tragedy in their own lives, the couple had listened intently to the story of my Ugandan friend.

"As they sat before me, they told me how they had struggled to keep their business going in spite of the turbulence of Uganda's last twenty years.



“Then one day during the bloody reign of Idi Amin, they receive a note stating their twenty-six-year-old son had been kidnapped and was being held for ransom. The parents did nothing for a few days, and then received a note threatening that their son would be killed if they did not pay the ransom.

“The couple sought legal advice and consulted with the proper government authorities. They were advised to resist payment. Then came another note. This was the final warning. If payment was not made immediately, their son would be tortured and killed. As they agonized over what to do, they receive a note stating that their son was dead. Grief-stricken; the father tried to locate the body.

“Finally he found someone who, for a price, would lead him to his son’s body. When he arrived at the appointed place, he was seized by a group of soldiers and taken to a prison. In the same cell that had held his son, they stripped him to the waist, made him face a wall, and with a whip made of leather strips, they cut his back to ribbons. They loaded him into the back of a pickup truck and dropped him off on a street corner. They shouted at him that if he ever tried to locate his son again, he would be killed.

“Two years had passed. The couple had suffered bitter, deep hatred toward unknown soldiers who had murdered their son and beaten the father. They could no longer enjoy success in business, a spacious home in the country, and a happy family life. Now each day was filled with sorrow, hatred, and thoughts of revenge. The story of the Ugandan businessman had disturbed them; they wanted to know if I believed they were wrong to treasure their misery and keep their hatred alive. It seemed to them that resentment was normal and proper. To forgive the soldiers seemed to them to be inappropriate and disloyal to the memory of their son.

“What could I say? Theirs was a tragic story. Surely they had the option to choose their own approach to the cruel, heartless event that had clouded their lives. The problem was so far removed from my own life experiences that it seemed almost from another world. I required more wisdom than I possessed. ‘God, help me,’ I quietly prayed.

“We sat in silence in a dimly lit room. I couldn’t think of anything to say to this couple. The woman’s eyes were filled with tears. The gentleman sat with his elbows on his knees and both hands covering his face. The wife whispered, ‘It would be a relief to put this behind us and get on with the future.’ ‘Yes, it would,’ he replied. ‘Can you help us?’

“How could I help? I leaned back in my chair and thought to myself, ‘What would the Ugandan businessman who had lost everything say to them right now?’ I believe he would have said: ‘You must put away all bitterness, anger, wrath, quarreling, and slanderous talk—indeed all malice. Instead, be kind to one another, compassionate, forgiving one another, just as God in Christ also forgave you’ (Ephesians 4:31-32).

“Murder and merciless beatings are heinous deeds. Many friends and associates had assured them that revenge, anger, and hatred were natural responses. To think of being kind and tenderhearted and forgiving was beyond consideration.

“As the three of us struggled in that dark room in Zimbabwe, it seemed to me that there was another presence in the room. God was there telling me to gently urge this dear couple to let go of their hostile spirit and let Him cleanse their hearts. He would give them a forgiving spirit. Jesus would say: ‘But I say to you, love your enemy and pray for those who persecute you’ (Matthew 5:44).

“I suggested that they needed to pray for such a change of heart. After a long silence, the man said in a trembling voice, ‘I am ready.’ His wife said, ‘So am I.’

“The three of us knelt by the bed in that quiet room. I have never heard such moving prayers. We stood up and embraced each other with tears of supernatural joy streaming down our cheeks. The next day the man and his wife stood before the entire gathering. He told the group that he and his wife were leaving a heavy burden behind and looking forward to a new life in the future.”

Dr. Brandt goes on to say:

“We want to know when it is acceptable not to forgive. We are confronted on all sides with physical abuse, sexual abuse, rape, unfaithfulness, suffering. The list is long. Is no one entitled to nurse resentment, bitterness, and to withhold forgiveness? Why should we forgive?

“The answer is clear. The Ugandan couple experienced miraculous healing when they released their anger and bitterness. Forgiveness freed them from the non-productive and destructive emotion which chained them and enslaved them to the object of their anger and pain. They found that forgiveness was the beginning of a free life.”

God's children have full access to the limitless supply of the fruit of the Holy Spirit: love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. Isn't it odd, therefore, that we should ever choose hatred, resentment, or anger, not over the great tragedies of life, but more often, over the small grievances of daily living?

Forgiveness is a tough concept! And one in which we grow and stretch and learn and process. It will be a life-long journey as God teaches about forgiveness and helps you to forgive.

### **Application**

Q. Are there people in your life you can't or won't forgive?

Take some time alone with God to confess your inability to forgive, and ask the Holy Spirit to forgive them through you. As you rely on Him, He will give you the power!

## Know What God Wants You to Do Every Day

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God reveals His will to us through: His Word, the Holy Spirit, other people, and providential circumstances.

There is an old story about a man trapped on the top of his house during a flood or hurricane or tsunami (insert your own natural disaster). The water is swiftly rising. As this man sits on his roof, fearful of being swept away by the current, he cries out to God, “God please help me.”

A few moments later, a friend arrives with his boat. “Hey, friend, need a ride to safety?” he asks.

“No,” replies the man on top of his house. “God is going to help me.”

An hour later, the water is up to the gutters. A voluntary rescue person comes by on his yellow raft. “Hey, let’s get you off of there and on to safety,” he yells.

But the man on top of his house refuses to go. “God is going to help me.”

Another hour passes and now the water is halfway up the roof. The man is now on top of his chimney, nervously looking down at certain death.

Fortunately, a Red Cross volunteer swings by in a canoe and offers to take him to safety. But the man refuses. “No, God is going to help me.”

A couple of hours pass by and the water sweeps over the top of the house. The man is carried away by the current and drowns. When he gets to Heaven, he says to God, “I thought you were going to help me.”

God and says to the man, “I sent a boat, an inflatable raft, and a canoe—but you refused each one.”

And you laughed, right? But quite often this is a perfect analogy of our attempts to know God’s plan for our lives. We act as if God’s will is some sort of vague, mysterious amazing thing. It’s as if we want God to show us what He wants us to do, but we don’t really think He will make it clear to us. Ask God what He wants you to do ... and then wait expectantly for Him to give you answer!

Q. How do you most often figure out what you should do?

Q. Do you usually consider what God might want for you to do? How do you determine this?

Many times, what God wants us to do is very clear. When we talk about knowing what God wants us to do this is sometimes referred to as “knowing God’s will.” We can know God’s will in two different ways: through His *general* will and His *specific* will.

God’s *general* will is always clear. We find His general will clearly revealed in Scripture. When we are considering whether or not God is directing us to do something, some decisions are objective enough to be eliminated on the basis of whether or not they conform to God’s Word. God will never lead us in a direction that will violate the principles He has given in the Bible. For example, He would not lead lie or cheat or steal, because this is clearly taught in the Bible as something that is wrong. Or He would not want you to pursue a relationship with a person who is married, because you would be committing adultery, which is in direct violation of what is taught throughout the Bible.

In Psalm 32:8 we read,

“I will instruct and teach you about how you should live. I will advise you as I look you in the eye.”

As we immerse ourselves in prayer and in the study of God’s Word, He will give us His wisdom to make decisions that are compatible with His principles.

Proverbs 3:5-6 reminds us, “Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not rely on your own understanding.”

Here are some principles that can guide us as we seek to determine God’s general will:

**God has a plan for your life.** Jeremiah 29:11 says, “For I know what I have planned for you,” says the Lord. “I have plans to prosper you, not to harm you. I have plans to give you a future filled with hope.”

**God desires that each and every person have a relationship with Him through His Son, Jesus Christ.** 1 Timothy 2:4-5 tells us, “He [God] wants all people to be saved and to come to a knowledge of the truth. For there is one God and one intermediary between God and humanity, Christ Jesus, himself human.”

**God promises to give us wisdom if we ask Him and believe that He will give it.** James 1:5 tells us, “But if anyone is deficient in wisdom, he should ask

God, who gives to all generously and without reprimand, and in these words, “I am able to do all things through the one who strengthens me.” And Isaiah 41:10 says, “Don’t be afraid, for I am with you! Don’t be frightened, for I am your God! I strengthen you—yes, I help you—yes, I uphold you with my saving right hand!”

Q. What new thought or idea has been presented to you so far in this lesson?

God’s *specific* will at times is difficult to see clearly. Does he want me to take a job in a different city ... or stay with the one that I have? Does he want me to marry this person that I am currently dating ... or should I wait for someone else? Should I buy a new car ... or a used one? Should I go to the university ... or stay home with my family?

You can be sure of one thing: No one has perfect insight into God’s specific will. The soundest, most mature believers can and do make mistakes about God’s specific will. However, in determining God’s specific will there are some absolutes that never change. God reveals His specific will through His Word, the Bible (Psalm 119:105), through the Holy Spirit (John 14:26), through other people (Proverbs 15:22), and through providential circumstances (Proverbs 16:9).

As you study God’s Word and talk with Him about the specific things in your life that you need direction and discernment for, here are some questions that can help you make a decision. Each one of these questions is based on principles that run throughout the Bible. A specific Bible verse or passage is given for each principle as a reference, but you can find many other verses related to each question!

- Does it comply with the directions given in God’s written Word? (Psalm 119:133)
- Does it demonstrate love for God? (John 14:15)
- Does it demonstrate love for others? (Romans 13:9-10)
- Does it promote personal holiness? (1 Thessalonians 4:7)
- Does it reflect the fruit of the Spirit? (Galatians 5:22)
- Does it require faith and trust in God? (Hebrews 11:6)
- Does it make sense when you use reasoning that is based on God’s truth? (Romans 12:2)

- Does it generate a supernatural inner peace and calmness that cannot be attributed to your circumstances? (Philippians 4:6-7)

Q. Is there any situation or relationship in your life right now for you to apply some of these questions to?

You do not have to be able to answer “yes” to each and every question in order to determine that the direction you are heading is the one God wants for you. There may be several questions that you simply cannot answer, but there should be a clear consensus among those that you can. If the answer is “no” to any of these questions, take time to wait on God to give you more confirmation before taking action. Many times, people believe God is leading them into an area, and He may be, but they plunge forward without getting His confirmation. Be patient and willing to wait on God.

Take time to recognize God’s direction through insights, impressions, conversations, circumstances, and counsel that may be God’s specific guidance. God promises to give us strength and courage for whatever life brings.

### **Application**

Q. In what ways can you apply the principles contained in this lesson to your life right now?

## Jesus Said, “I Am...”

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Jesus made several “I am” statements that tell us who He is!

- “I am the bread of life.”
- “I am the light of the world”
- “I am the good shepherd.”
- “I am the door.”
- “I am the resurrection and the life.”
- “I am the way ... truth ... and the life.”
- “I am the vine.”

There’s a lot of crazy information out there today about Jesus. Get it from the internet, or from a media outlet, or from some published resource ... you can find almost anything out there that you want to believe! And even though there’s a good chance the information isn’t true, people will be spreading that information nonetheless! That’s why it’s more important than ever that you know what the Bible has to say about Jesus Christ. When you rely on the truth of God’s Word to ground you in your faith, you will be able to trust God in any situation!

Jesus claimed to be God! He really did! And that’s one fact that can be proven in the Bible. Jesus actually claimed that He was the “I am” that God had called himself in the Old Testament.

In Exodus 3:14–15 we read,

*“God said to Moses, ‘I am that I am.’ And he said, ‘You must say this to the Israelites, “I am has sent me to you.”’ God also said to Moses, ‘You must say this to the Israelites, “The LORD— the God of your fathers, the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob—has sent me to you. This is my name forever, and this is my memorial from generation to generation.”’*

And then in John 8:59, Jesus said,

*“I tell you the solemn truth, before Abraham came into existence, I am!”*

Jesus also made other “I am” statements of himself:



***"I am the bread of life.*** The one who comes to me will never go hungry, and the one who believes in me will never be thirsty." —John 6:35 ***"I am the light of the world!*** The one who follows me will never walk in darkness, but will have the light of life." —John 8:12 ***"I am the good shepherd.*** The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep." —John 10:11 ***"I am the door.*** If anyone enters through me, he will be saved, and will come in and go out, and find pasture." —John 10:9 ***"I am the resurrection and the life.*** The one who believes in me will live even if he dies" —John 11:25 ***"I am the way, and the truth, and the life.*** No one comes to the Father except through me." —John 14:6 ***"I am the true vine*** and my Father is the gardener." —John 15:1

Q. How can knowing these "I am" statements about Jesus make a difference in your life?

Q. Which one of the "I am" statements speaks most clearly to you at this point in your life? Why?

The leaders of other religions are dead (Confucius, Buddha, and Mohammad), but Jesus is alive! Jesus continues to be the "I am" because of his resurrection from the dead. Because Jesus is the "I am" and is alive today, He is continually working in each one of our lives!

In John 1:1-5, 9-14 we read:

*"In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was fully God. The Word was with God in the beginning. All things were created by him, and apart from him not one thing was created that has been created. In him was life, and the life was the light of mankind. And the light shines on in the darkness, but the darkness has not mastered it. "The true light, who gives light to everyone, was coming into the world. He was in the world, and the world was created by him, but the world did not recognize him. He came to what was his own, but his own people did not receive him. But to all who have received him—those who believe in his name—he has given the right to become God's children—children not born by human parents or by human desire or a husband's decision, but by God. "Now the Word became flesh and took up residence among us. We saw his glory—the glory of the one and only, full of grace and truth, who came from the Father."*

Q. According to this passage in John, who is Jesus, and what is He doing?

In Colossians 1:15–20, we read,

*“He [Jesus] is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn over all creation, for all things in heaven and on earth were created in him—all things, whether visible or invisible, whether thrones or dominions, whether principalities or powers—all things were created through him and for him. He himself is before all things and all things are held together in him. He is the head of the body, the church, as well as the beginning, the firstborn from the dead, so that he himself may become first in all things. For God was pleased to have all his fullness dwell in the Son and through him to reconcile all things to himself by making peace through the blood of his cross—through him, whether things on earth or things in heaven.”*

Q. From Colossians 1:15–20, I learn that Jesus ...

Hebrews 1:1–3 tells us,

*“After God spoke long ago in various portions and in various ways to our ancestors through the prophets, in these last days he has spoken to us in a son, whom he appointed heir of all things, and through whom he created the world. The Son is the radiance of his glory and the representation of his essence, and he sustains all things by his powerful word, and so when he had accomplished cleansing for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high.”*

Q. From Hebrews 1:1–3, I learn that Jesus ...

*“You should have the same attitude toward one another that Christ Jesus had, who though he existed in the form of God did not regard equality with God as something to be grasped, but emptied himself by taking on the form of a slave, by looking like other men, and by sharing in human nature. He humbled himself, by becoming obedient to the point of death—even death on a cross! As a result God highly exalted him and gave him the name that is above every name, so that the name of Jesus every knee will bow—in heaven and on earth and under the earth—and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord to the glory of God the Father.” —Philippians 2:5–11*

The Message version of the Bible presents these verses in this way:

*“Because of that obedience, God lifted him high and honored him far beyond anyone or anything, ever, so that all created beings in heaven and on earth—even those long ago dead and buried—will bow in worship before this Jesus Christ, and call out in praise that he is the Master of all, to the glorious honor of God the Father.”*

Q. From Philippians 2:5–11, I learn that Jesus ...

*“I am the Alpha and the Omega, the first and the last, the beginning and the end!” —Revelation 22:13*

Q. From Revelation 22:13, I learn that Jesus ...

Sometimes it’s hard for people to accept the fact that Jesus is God because they can’t see Him. “Doubting Thomas,” one of Jesus’ Disciples, was like that. We find his story in John 20:24–29:

*“Now Thomas (called Didymus), one of the twelve, was not with them when Jesus came. The other disciples told him, ‘We have seen the Lord!’ But he replied, ‘Unless I see the wounds from the nails in his hands, and put my finger into the wounds from the nails, and put my hand into his side, I will never believe it!’ “Eight days later the disciples were again together in the house, and Thomas was with them. Although the doors were locked, Jesus came and stood among them and said, ‘Peace be with you!’ “Then he said to Thomas, ‘Put your finger here, and examine my hands. Extend your hand and put it into my side. Do not continue in your unbelief, but believe.’ “Thomas replied to him, ‘My Lord and my God!’ “Jesus said to him, ‘Have you believed because you have seen me? Blessed are the people who have not seen and yet have believed.’”*

Q. What convinced Thomas?

Q. What doubts do you have about Jesus?

Q. In what ways have the scriptures we’ve looked at in this lesson helped you?

## **Application**

Q. How can the truth of who Jesus is influence your life on a day-to-day basis?

## Jesus, the “Messiah”

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Jesus fulfilled over three hundred scriptures that foretold of His coming to be the Messiah!

A “messiah” is an expected deliverer or savior of an entire people. In Jewish tradition, the Messiah is the expected king and deliverer of the Jews. In the Christian tradition, the Messiah is Jesus Christ—our Savior.

Q. What do you currently know about Jesus, the Messiah?

Throughout the Old Testament Scriptures, a spotless, unblemished lamb was required for a sin offering. This offering pointed to the future spotless Lamb of God, the Messiah, who would be God’s perfect sacrifice for our sins. John 1:29 records:

“On the next day John saw Jesus coming toward him and said, ‘Look, the Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world!’”

Here is that “sin” concept again! Yes, our sin really does matter to God! It separates us from Him and only a sacrifice can pay for that sin. It is important to recognize and accept Jesus Christ as the Messiah, because without Him, we do not have a relationship with the God of the universe!

For centuries the prophets of Israel foretold the coming of the Messiah. Specifically, the prophet Isaiah wrote about the coming of Jesus the Messiah 700 years before Jesus was born. Over the span of fifteen hundred years, nearly three hundred specific references were made to his coming. All of these are recorded in Scripture.

The odds against one person fulfilling merely eight of these prophecies would be the same as a blindfolded person picking one special silver dollar from a two-foot-high stack of silver dollars over an area the size of Texas (greater than the entire nation of France.) Yet, Jesus Christ fulfilled over two hundred of them ... exactly! And his sinless life qualified Him to be God’s perfect sacrifice for all of our sins.

Hebrews 9:11-15 explains,

“But now Christ has come as the high priest of the good things to come. He passed through the greater and more perfect tent not made with hands, that is, not of this creation, and he entered once for all into the most holy place not by the blood of goats and calves but by his own blood, and so he himself secured eternal redemption. For if the blood of goats and bulls and the ashes of a young cow sprinkled on those who are defiled consecrated them and provided ritual purity, how much more will the blood of Christ, who through the eternal Spirit offered himself without blemish to God, purify our consciences from dead works to worship the living God. And so he is the mediator of a new covenant, so that those who are called may receive the eternal inheritance he has promised, since he died to set them free from the violations committed under the first covenant.”

The Message translation of the Bible presents these verses in this way:

“If that animal blood and the other rituals of purification were effective in cleaning up certain matters of our religion and behavior, think how much more the blood of Christ cleans up our whole lives, inside and out. Through the Spirit, Christ offered himself as an unblemished sacrifice, freeing us from all those dead-end efforts to make ourselves respectable, so that we can live all out for God.”

Q. As you read these verses from Hebrews, what truths are new to you?

Listed below are just a few Old Testament prophecies about the Messiah that were fulfilled by Jesus and are recorded in the New Testament.

Prophecy: “As for you, Bethlehem Ephrathah, seemingly insignificant among the clans of Judah —from you a king will emerge who will rule over Israel on my behalf, one whose origins are in the distant past.” —Micah 5:2

Fulfillment: “After Jesus was born in Bethlehem in Judea, in the time of King Herod, wise men from the East came to Jerusalem” —Matthew 2:1

For centuries the prophets of Israel foretold the coming of the Messiah.

Q. What key information is given in the above verses?

Prophecy: “For a child has been born to us, a son has been given to us. He shoulders responsibility and is called: Amazing Adviser, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace. His dominion will be vast and he will bring immeasurable prosperity. He will rule on David’s throne and over David’s kingdom, establishing

it and strengthening it by promoting justice and fairness, from this time forward and forevermore. The zeal of the LORD of Heaven's Armies will accomplish this."  
—Isaiah 9:6-7

Fulfillment: "Listen: You will become pregnant and give birth to a son, and you will name him Jesus. He will be great, and will be called the Son of the Most High, and the Lord God will give him the throne of his father David. He will reign over the house of Jacob forever, and his kingdom will never end." —Luke 1:31-33

Q. What important information do we learn about Jesus in the above verses?

Prophecy: "My God, my God, why have you abandoned me? I groan in prayer, but help seems far away." —Psalm 22:1

Fulfillment: "At about three o'clock Jesus shouted with a loud voice, 'Eli, Eli, lema sabachthani?' that is, 'My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?'" —Matthew 27:46

Q. What do you learn about Jesus from the above verses?

Prophecy: "They are dividing up my clothes among themselves; they are rolling dice for my garments." —Psalm 22:18

Fulfillment: "When they had crucified him, they divided his clothes by throwing dice." —Matthew 27:35

Q. Why do you think this detail about Jesus' clothes is included in the Bible?

Prophecy: "For this reason the Lord himself will give you a confirming sign. Look, this young woman is about to conceive and will give birth to a son. You, young woman, will name him Immanuel." —Isaiah 7:14

Fulfillment: "The angel replied, 'The Holy Spirit will come upon you, and the power of the Most High will overshadow you. Therefore the child to be born will be holy; he will be called the Son of God.'" —Luke 1:35

Q. Why do you think the information in the above passages is important?

## **Application**

Q. As you look over all of the information contained in this lesson, what does it mean to you personally that Jesus is the Messiah?

Check out the article, "[Was Jesus the Messiah?](#)" for more information about Jesus, the Messiah.



## God's Names in the Bible—Seven Names to Hold On to!

What is your name? Does it have any special meaning or significance? Even if you don't know something specific about your name, your name was chosen especially for *you*. Our names are precious to us ... they are a part of our identity.

In Bible times names were even more important than they are today. A person's name was considered to reveal his or her character. God's name also reveals His character.

Q. What comes to your mind when you hear the name 'God'?

Q. Do you know any other names for God? What do those names tell you about God?

Unfortunately, when we hear the name *God* or *Lord*, it typically conveys little more to us than the designation of a supreme being. But throughout Scripture, we find that the names of God actually present to us miniature portraits of *who He is*. Throughout the Bible, a person's name identified them and stood for something specific. This is especially true of God. Naming carries special significance.

God's names actually reveal His character and tell us about His very nature. By knowing God's names, we gain strength for times of struggle, comfort for times of disappointment, and wisdom for times of confusion.

Many Christians experience confusion in their lives because they don't really know God—who He really is or how He works in our lives. You can know God more fully by knowing and studying His names which in turn will give you strength for times of struggle, comfort for times of disappointment, and wisdom for times of confusion.

Seven different names for God that were used often in the New Testament are included in this lesson. Study each name and its meaning, read the verses associated with each name, and take time to reflect upon how that specific name of God touches your life. Know that God's names reveal to us His very nature—He is waiting to meet you!

- Emmanuel: God with us

- Adonai: Lord and Master
- Elohim: God, the strong, faithful One
- El Elyon: The Most High God
- El Olam: Everlasting God
- El Roi: The God who sees
- El Shaddai: God Almighty

### **Emmanuel: God with us**

“For this reason the LORD himself will give you a confirming sign. Look, this young woman is about to conceive and will give birth to a son. You, young woman, will name him Immanuel.” —Isaiah 7:14

Q. What comes to your mind as you consider Emmanuel—God with us?

To actually have the God of the Universe “with” us is a mind-staggering concept! Not just a God “out there,” but a God who is always with us!

Q. Because God is Emmanuel/God with us, I can ...

### **Adonai: Lord and Master**

“Then both parties to the controversy must stand before the LORD, that is, before the priests and judges who will be in office in those days.” —Deuteronomy 19:17

When we have a relationship with God, He is our Lord and Master. The word “Lord” indicates a relationship, one in which we are submissive to God’s will over our lives. Sometimes this is a hard concept for people to accept. When God is “Adonai,” He has total possession of all that we are and all that we have.

“Look, as the eyes of servants look to the hand of their master, as the eyes of a female servant look to the hand of her mistress, so our eyes will look to the LORD, our God, until he shows us favor.” —Psalm 123:2

Q. What is hard for you about this verse from Psalm 123?

Q. What is reassuring to you as you think about God as your Lord and Master?

Q. Because God is Adonai/The Lord and Master, I will ...

### **Elohim: God, the strong, faithful One**

“In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth.” —Genesis 1:1

God has been the consistent, stable factor in all of creation since the very beginning of time. He has proven himself the strong, faithful One again and again.

Q. When times are tough, what keeps you from turning to God, the strong, faithful One?

Q. When have you experienced God's strength and/or faithfulness?

Q. Because God is Elohim/God the strong, faithful One, I can ...

### **El Elyon: Most High God**

El Elyon is the name the Bible uses to tell us that God is the Most High God; the sovereign ruler of the entire universe.

"Worthy of praise is the Most High God, who delivered your enemies into your hand." —Genesis 14:20

"The oracle of the one who hears the words of God, and who knows the knowledge of the Most High, who sees a vision from the Almighty." —Numbers 24:16

Q. What does it mean to you that God is the Most High God?

Q. How can depending on El Elyon change your life?

Q. Because God is El Elyon/The Most High God, I ...

### **El Olam: Everlasting God**

"Abraham planted a tamarisk tree in Beer Sheba. There he worshiped the Lord, the eternal God." —Genesis 21:33

Q. What does it mean to you to know that God is everlasting?

Q. Because God is El Olam, Everlasting God, I ...

### **El Roi: The God who sees**

"So Hagar named the Lord who spoke to her, 'You are the God who sees me,' for she said, 'Here I have seen one who sees me!'" —Genesis 16:13

Q. Have you ever considered that God always sees you? What does this mean to you?

Q. Because God is El Roi/The God who sees, I will ...

## **El Shaddai: God Almighty**

“When Abram was 99 years old, the Lord appeared to him and said, ‘I am the Sovereign God. Walk before me and be blameless. Then I will confirm my covenant between me and you, and I will give you a multitude of descendants.’” —Genesis 17:1-2

Q. How can knowing that God is almighty influence the moments of each one of your days?

Q. In what ways has God revealed Himself to you as El Shaddai?

Q. Because God is El Shaddai/God Almighty, I know ...

## **Application**

Q. What are some other things you look to for deliverance when you are experiencing difficulty in your life?

Q. As you consider the different names for God included in this study, which one is most real to you at this point in your life?

Q. Which one seems the most unfamiliar to you?

Q. Which one gives you most the comfort?

Q. Which one is most confusing to you?

Q. How can holding on to these different names of God help you when you are struggling, are disappointed, or need wisdom?

Reference the short JO App article titled “[Names of God](#)”.

A great resource for learning more about God’s names as they are presented in the Bible is *Lord, I Want to Know You: A Devotional Study on the Names of God* by Kay Arthur.

You can also go to this external resource, [bible.org](http://bible.org), and read the article “[Names of God](#)”.

## God's Names in the Bible—Ten “Jehovah” Names You Can Rely On!

This lesson actually builds on the one previous to it. We learned in that lesson that God's very nature is communicated to us through the names used for him in the Old Testament. Knowing who God really is and how He works in our lives gives us the confidence to fully trust Him. When we claim those names in our lives, we can depend on His character to sustain us through all of life.

Ten different names for God as “Jehovah” are included in this lesson.

- Jehovah: LORD, I am who I am
- Jehovah-Jirah: The LORD provides
- Jehovah-Kaddesh: The LORD who makes you holy
- Jehovah-Nissi: The LORD is my banner
- Jehovah-Rohi: The LORD is my Shepherd
- Jehovah-Rophi: The LORD who heals
- Jehovah-Sabaoth: The LORD of hosts
- Jehovah-Shalom: The LORD is peace
- Jehovah-Shamma: The LORD is there
- Jehovah-Tsidkenu: The LORD is our righteousness

Study each name and its meaning, read the verses associated with each name, and take time to reflect upon how that specific name of God touches your life. God's names reveal to us His very nature—He is waiting to meet you!

### **Jehovah: LORD, I am that I Am**

Of all the names of God used in the Old Testament, Jehovah is the name used most frequently. It was also transcribed as Yahweh and is the proper name of the God of Israel. Anytime LORD appears in all capital letters in the Bible, it is translated from the word Jehovah, “I am”.

“This is the account of the heavens and the earth when they were created—when the LORD God made the earth and heavens.” —Genesis 2:4

“God said to Moses, ‘I am that I am.’ And he said, ‘You must say this to the Israelites, “I am has sent me to you.”’ God also said to Moses, ‘You must say this to the Israelites, “The LORD—the God of your fathers, the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob—has sent me to you. This is my name forever, and this is my memorial from generation to generation.”’” —Exodus 3:14-15

“The LORD descended in the cloud and stood with him there and proclaimed the LORD by name. The LORD passed by before him and proclaimed: ‘The LORD, the LORD, the compassionate and gracious God, slow to anger, and abounding in loyal love and faithfulness, keeping loyal love for thousands, forgiving iniquity and transgression and sin. But he by no means leaves the guilty unpunished, responding to the transgression of fathers by dealing with children and children’s children, to the third and fourth generation.’” —Exodus 34:5-7

This is a very strong statement: “I am that I am”!

Q. What does it mean to you personally?

Q. Because God Jehovah is 'I am who I am', I can ...

### **Jehovah-Jireh: The LORD Provides**

In Genesis 22:8-14 we see a picture of God as provider:

“‘God will provide for himself the lamb for the burnt offering, my son,’ Abraham replied. The two of them continued on together. When they came to the place God had told him about, Abraham built the altar there and arranged the wood on it. Next he tied up his son Isaac and placed him on the altar on top of the wood. Then Abraham reached out his hand, took the knife, and prepared to slaughter his son. But the LORD’s angel called to him from heaven, ‘Abraham! Abraham!’ ‘Here I am!’ he answered. ‘Do not harm the boy!’ the angel said. ‘Do not do anything to him, for now I know that you fear God because you did not withhold your son, your only son, from me.’

“Abraham looked up and saw behind him a ram caught in the bushes by its horns. So he went over and got the ram and offered it up as a burnt offering instead of his son. And Abraham called the name of that place ‘The LORD provides.’ It is said to this day, ‘In the mountain of the LORD provision will be made.’”

Q. What do you need God to provide for you today? Take time to ask Him!

Q. Because God Jehovah is 'The Lord provides', I ...

### **Jehovah-Kaddesh: The LORD Who Makes You Holy**

“You must sanctify yourselves and be holy, because I am the LORD your God.” — Leviticus 20:7

Q. What does it mean to you to set yourself apart to be holy?

Q. Because God Jehovah is 'The LORD who makes you holy', I ...

### **Jehovah-Nissi: The LORD is my banner**

“Moses built an altar, and he called it ‘The LORD is my Banner.’” —Exodus 17:15

Q. What does it mean to you to know that God is a banner over you?

Q. Because God Jehovah is 'The Lord is my banner', I will ...

### **Jehovah-Rohi: The LORD is my Shepherd**

“The Lord is my shepherd, I lack nothing.” —Psalm 23:1

Q. Do you know anything about shepherds? If you don't know anything at all, it might be a good idea to Google the word or look up the definition in a dictionary! As you think about what a shepherd is and does, what comes to your mind when you hear that the LORD is your Shepherd?

Q. In what ways are you like a sheep with God as your Shepherd?

Q. Because God Jehovah is 'The Lord is my Shepherd', I will ...

### **Jehovah-Rophe: The LORD who heals**

“Then Moses led Israel to journey away from the Red Sea. They went out into the wilderness of Shur, walked for three days into the They traveled in this wilderness, and found no water. Then they came to Marah, but they were not able to drink the waters of Marah, because they were bitter. (That is why its name was Marah.) So the people murmured against Moses, saying, ‘What can we drink?’ He cried out to the Lord, and the Lord showed him a tree. When Moses threw it into the water, the water became safe to drink. There the Lord made for them a binding ordinance, and there he tested them. He said, ‘If you will diligently obey the Lord your God, and do what is right in his sight, and pay attention to his commandments, and keep all his statutes, then all the diseases that I brought on the Egyptians I will not bring on you, for I, the Lord, am your healer.’” —Exodus 15:22-26

Q. In what area of your life do you need healing?

Q. Because God Jehovah is 'The LORD who heals', I will ...

### **Jehovah-Sabaoth: The LORD of hosts**

“The LORD of hosts” actually represents the God of deliverance. The “hosts” are the angels of heaven. When there seemed to be no other source of deliverance, the children of Israel came to know God as Jehovah-Sabaoth. This term is used a great deal in the prophet books in the Old Testament of Isaiah, Jeremiah, Amos, Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi. It seems that it was when God’s chosen people found themselves failing and powerless, they realized their need for the LORD of hosts.

“This man would go up from his city year after year to worship and to sacrifice to the LORD of Heaven’s Armies at Shiloh. (It was there that the two sons of Eli, Hophni and Phineas, served as the LORD priests.” —I Samuel 1:3

“Moreover, this is what the LORD of Heaven’s Armies has said: ‘Pay close attention to these things also.’” —Haggai 1:7

“The LORD of Heaven’s Armies is on our side!” —Psalm 46:7

Q. What does it mean to you that God is 'The LORD of hosts'?

Q. Because God Jehovah is 'The LORD of hosts', I will ...

### **Jehovah-Shalom: The LORD is peace**

“Gideon built an altar for the Lord there, and named it ‘The LORD is on friendly terms with me.’ To this day it is still there in Ophrah of the Abiezrites.” —Judges 6:24

Q. In what areas of your life do you need to experience God’s peace?

Q. Because God Jehovah is 'The LORD is peace', I can ...

### **Jehovah-Shammah: The LORD is there**

“The circumference of the city will be six miles. The name of the city from that day forward will be: ‘The LORD Is There.’” —Ezekiel 48:35

Q. God is everywhere! How can embracing this concept change your life on a day-to-day basis?



Q. Because God Jehovah is 'The LORD is there', I will ...

### **Jehovah-Tsidkenu: The LORD is our righteousness**

“Under his rule Judah will enjoy safety and Israel will live in security. This is the name he will go by: ‘The LORD has provided us with justice.’ —Jeremiah 23:6

Q. What comes to mind when you think of the word 'righteousness'?

Righteousness actually means to be right with God! It is more than goodness. It is to do what God says is right, to live according to His standards. God extended His righteousness to us when He allowed His only Son, Jesus Christ, to pay the penalty for our sins on the cross. When we accept Christ as our personal Savior, we are made righteous before God. Jesus saves us from our sins. We do not earn it —God *is* our righteousness!

Q. Because God Jehovah is 'The LORD is our righteousness', I will ...

When we know who God really is and how He works in our lives, we will have the confidence to fully trust Him. By learning God’s names, we can depend on His very character to sustain us through all of life!

### **Application**

Q. As you consider each one of the ten names of God included in this study, which one is most real to you at this point in your life?

Q. Which one seems the most unfamiliar to you?

Q. Which one gives you most comfort?

Q. Which one is most confusing?

Here’s a great resource for learning more about God’s names as they are presented in the Bible: *LORD, I Want to Know You: A Devotional Study on the Names of God* by Kay Arthur.

You can also go to bible.org and read the article, [Names of God](#).

## What Does It Mean to “Ask, Seek, and Knock”?

Is there something specific that you need God to do on your behalf? Are you wondering what He is doing in your life? Are you trying to discover a specific direction to take? Is there someone in your life who desperately needs God? Have you tried to talk with God about this, but it seems that you can't seem to get an answer from Him? There is a key verse in Matthew 7 that gives us a great framework for our conversations with God:

*“For everyone who asks receives, and the one who seeks finds, and to the one who knocks, the door will be opened.” —Matthew 7:8*

Verses 9 through 11 go on to say: “Is there anyone among you who, if his son asks for bread, will give him a stone? Or if he asks for a fish, will give him a snake? If you then, although you are evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will your Father in heaven give good gifts to those who ask him!”

In another version of the Bible, The Message, these verses are translated:

*“Don’t bargain with God. Be direct. Ask for what you need. This isn’t a cat-and-mouse, hide-and-seek game we’re in. If your child asks for bread, do you trick him with sawdust? If he asks for fish, do you scare him with a live snake on his plate? As bad as you are, you wouldn’t think of such a thing. You’re at least decent to your own children. So don’t you think the God who conceived you in love will be even better?”*

God will answer our prayers!

It is very common for Christians to *know about* prayer, *study* prayer, *memorize* prayers, *read books about* prayer, and *still not believe that prayer makes any difference*. We prove we don't really believe what God says about prayer when we don't actually pray. God has told us in His Word to ask and seek and knock ... He *will* answer!

Let's take a look at those key action words in Matthew 7:7-8 ... ask, seek, and knock!

## Step 1: “Ask” God

Prayer changes things in the physical and spiritual realm when you ask according to God’s guidelines. But it may take time before a change becomes noticeable. Are you watching for God’s answer? You can demonstrate your faith and anticipation while you are waiting by “seeking” and “knocking.”

But first, you must ask. James 4:2-3 says,

*“You desire and you do not have; you murder and envy and you cannot obtain; you quarrel and fight. You do not have because you do not ask; you ask and do not receive because you ask wrongly, so you can spend it on your passions.”*

Q. Are the things you are wanting within God’s will for you or for your own passions?

Q. Are you taking the time to ask God for what you want? What is it?

John 14:13-14 says:

*“And I will do whatever you ask in my name, so that the Father may be glorified in the Son. If you ask me anything in my name, I will do it.”*

Q. According to these verses in John, what is required for your asking?

John 16:23-24 puts it this way:

*“Whatever you ask the Father in my name he will give you. Until now you have not asked for anything in my name. Ask and you will receive it, so that your joy may be complete.”*

Q. According to this verse in John 16, what will be the outcome of our asking if we ask in the right way?

## Step 2: “Seek” God’s Answer

Seeking God’s answer means that we are looking for possible ways through which God may answer our prayer. With an attitude of expectation and a mindset of anticipation, be sensitive to the Holy Spirit’s promptings. Stay alert, fully open to

God's direction. If you believe God will answer your prayer, you will be looking for His answer. As the Holy Spirit makes you aware of possibilities, be faithful to pursue them until you have checked them out.

Prayer changes things in the physical and spiritual realm when you ask according to God's guidelines. Seeking God's answer means that we are looking for possible ways through which God may answer our prayer.

Part of seeking God's answer is actually looking for Him. Think about that for a minute. It fits in perfectly with the verses related to "asking" according to God's will. In the Old Testament, nearly all of the scriptures using the word "seek" refer to seeking after God. Here are just four verses that represent many!

*"But if you seek the LORD your God from there, you will find him, if, indeed, you seek him with all your heart and soul." —Deuteronomy 4:29 "The people of Judah assembled to ask for the LORD's help; they came from all the cities of Judah to ask for the LORD's help." —2 Chronicles 20:4 "Seek the LORD and the strength he gives! Seek his presence continually!" —Psalm 105:4 "When you seek me in prayer and worship, you will find me available to you. If you seek me with all your heart." —Jeremiah 29:13*

Q. As you are seeking your answer, in what ways are you seeking God as well?

Q. In what ways are you currently seeking God?

### **Step 3: "Knock" on Possible Doors**

When is the last time you knocked on someone's door? You usually knock and then wait for that person to answer, right? So, have you knocked on God's door, and are you waiting for an answer? As the Holy Spirit makes you aware of possibilities, be faithful to pursue them until you have checked them out. Knock on the door of a possibility and then wait to see if it will open wide or stay securely closed. God's answers will present themselves clearly to you!

Q. Consider for a moment and write down the ways you are currently knocking on doors.

Q. Do you sense that God is telling you to wait, or should you be knocking on another door?

## **An Example**

Here is an example of how the “Ask, Seek, and Knock” could play out in your life.

Let us assume you need a job. If you go job hunting without praying and asking God first for His direction and blessing, you will be at the mercy of the world system. In addition, if you ask God for a job but don’t bother to seek out possibilities, then you are not doing your part. Instead, you need to pray until you have the faith to believe God is going to grant your request. Then step out by faith, and seek options, trusting God to guide your steps. When you become aware of a possibility, knock and check it out. As you walk by faith continue to thank God that His answer is on the way. Although you do not know when it will arrive, the answer to your prayer will be right on schedule according to God’s timetable.

We must believe that God will answer. In 1 John 5:14-15 Jesus said, “And this is the confidence that we have before him: that whenever we ask anything according to his will, he hears us. And if we know that he hears us in regard to whatever we ask, then we know that we have the requests that we have asked from him.”

Q. On a scale of 1 to 10, how much confidence do you currently have that God hears you and that He will answer you?

“Ask” God for greater confidence!

## **Application**

Q. Is there something in your life that you specifically want God to show you?

Ask God for something that you know is in line with his will for you.

Seek out God’s answer by staying alert to ways that He is working in your life.

Knock on the door of a possibility and then wait to see if it will open wide or stay securely closed.

Although you do not know when it will arrive, the answer to your prayer will be right on schedule according to God’s timetable.

Take time to “Ask, Seek, and Knock” and remember to thank God when He answers.

## Prayers You Can Use

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Sometimes it seems hard to pray. . . you simply don't have the right words for God.

The Bible contains prayers written by other people that can help you talk to God. Many verses in the Bible, the Lord's Prayer, the Prayer of Jabez, The Benediction, and the Prayer for Peace all provide models of prayers that can be used in our conversations with God. There are times when it may seem hard to pray or you simply don't have the right words for what you want to say to God.

One passage of Scripture to remember during those times is Romans 8:26-27:

*"In the same way, the Spirit helps us in our weakness, for we do not know how we should pray, but the Spirit himself intercedes for us with inexpressible groanings. And he who searches our hearts knows the mind of the Spirit, because the Spirit intercedes on behalf of the saints according to God's will."*

The Holy Spirit speaks for us in harmony with the purpose and plans of God! He provides constant, continuous, unchanging access and fellowship with himself, the Creator of the universe, available to every believer all the time. When you don't have the words, rely on the Holy Spirit to be praying for you! There are also ways that you can use the words of others to help you as you pray.

Here are some thoughts and ideas:

### **Use Scripture!**

You can always pray Scripture! Praying Scripture directly not only will give you the words you need, but it will also encourage and bless you as well! Use the Psalms to praise God. Even if you don't know them well, just open up your Bible to that book. It won't take you long to find a praise or petition passage. You may find this spiritual discipline so helpful that you will start to use it on a regular basis!

You can also use other passages of Scripture in this way. Choose a passage of scripture and insert your own name (or a pronoun) or the name of a family member or friend into the passage in the appropriate places. You can simply do this as you read or write it into your personal notebook or journal.

*“For this reason we also, from the day we heard about you, have not ceased praying for you and asking God to fill you with the knowledge of his will in all spiritual wisdom and understanding, so that you may live worthily of the Lord and please him in all respects – bearing fruit in every good deed, growing in the knowledge of God, being strengthened with all power according to his glorious might for the display of all patience and steadfastness, joyfully giving thanks to the Father who has qualified you to share in the saints’ inheritance in the light. He delivered us from the power of darkness and transferred us to the kingdom of the Son he loves.” —Colossians 1:9-13*

Here is an adaptation of this passage using a friend named Mary:

*“For this reason, since the day I heard about Mary, I have not stopped praying for her. I continually ask You, God, to fill Mary with the knowledge of Your will through all the wisdom and understanding that the Spirit gives, so the she may live a life worthy of You and please You in every way: bearing fruit in every good work growing the knowledge of You, being strengthened with all power according to Your glorious might so that she may have great endurance and patience, giving joyful thanks to You who has qualified her to share in the inheritance of Your holy people in the kingdom of light. For You, God, have rescued both of us from the dominion of darkness and brought us all into the kingdom of Your Son!”*

Here is a prayer using the keywords and phrases from the same Colossians passage:

*“Lord, fill my friend Mary with the knowledge of Your will.  
Give her wisdom and understanding that comes from the Holy Spirit.  
Lord, help her live a life worthy of You.  
Give her a desire to please You in every way.  
May her life bear fruit in all that she does.  
Give her the strength and power that only comes from You.  
May she experience the incredible endurance and patience that only comes from You.  
Help to give joyful thanks to for all things in her life.  
Remind her daily that she is part of the kingdom of light.*

Praying the Scriptures directly not only will give you the words you need, but it will also encourage and bless you as well! Here are some other verses that you can use in the same way:

*“And I pray this, that your love may abound even more and more in knowledge and every kind of insight, so that you may be able to discern what is best and may be pure and blameless until the day of Christ, filled with the fruit of righteousness that comes through Jesus Christ—to the glory and praise of God.” —Philippians 1:9-11 “Now may the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace as you believe in him, so that you may abound in hope by the power of the Holy Spirit.” —Romans 15:13 “I do not cease to give thanks for you when I remember you in my prayers. I pray that the God of our Lord Jesus Christ, the glorious Father, will give you spiritual wisdom and revelation in your growing knowledge of him—since the eyes of your heart have been enlightened—so that you can know what is the hope of his calling, what is the wealth of his glorious inheritance in the saints.” —Ephesians 1:16-18*

Q. Have you ever used the words of the Bible in your prayers? How might this benefit you as you talk to God?

### **The Lord’s Prayer**

The Lord’s Prayer is one of the best-loved and most spoken prayers on the planet. It is used in church services, schools, in small groups, and in many individual private times with God. The traditional Lord’s Prayer is based on the King James versions of the Bible of the 1600s. All the versions base the text on Matthew 6:9-11:

“Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be thy name. Thy kingdom come, Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven. Give us this day our daily bread. And forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors. And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil: For thine is the kingdom, and the power, and the glory, forever. Amen.”

Q. Where have you heard The Lord’s Prayer?

Q. When has The Lord's Prayer been most meaningful to you?

### **The Prayer of Jabez**

1 Chronicles 4:10 is a remarkable example of a prayer that God answered!



“Jabez called out to the God of Israel, ‘If only you would greatly bless me and expand my territory! May your hand be with me! Keep me from harm so I might not endure pain!’ God answered his prayer.”

Q. What were the five requests of Jabez?

Pastor Bruce Wilkenson wrote a book on this passage that sold millions of copies! It is a prayer you can pray for yourself, asking God to enlarge your “territory”—whatever they may be!

Q. Is there anything about this Prayer of Jabez that seems frightening to you?

Q. Why do you think Bruce Wilkenson’s book was so appealing to so many people?

Q. As you think about God answering your prayer for blessing, how do you feel? Do you think He will really answer you? Why or why not?

## **The Benediction**

In Numbers 6 the Lord instructed Moses to have Aaron and his sons bless the children of Israel with this special prayer. This blessing is also known as “The Benediction.” This prayer is often said at the close of a church service to pronounce a blessing upon the congregation, or in a wedding ceremony to bless the bride and groom. You can use it to bless anyone in your life!

“The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face shine upon you and be gracious to you; the LORD turn his face toward you and give you peace.”

Q. Have you heard this benediction before? Where?

Q. What words in this benediction encourage you?

## **Prayer for Peace**

(by St. Francis of Assisi [1181-1226])

There are many prayers that have been written and passed down. The Prayer for Peace was first used primarily in catholic traditions but has become widely known. It is a great example of a prayer that you can use word for word as you talk to God.

*Lord, make me an instrument of Thy peace;  
where there is hatred, let me sow love;  
where there is injury, pardon;  
where there is doubt, faith;  
where there is despair, hope;  
where there is darkness, light;  
and where there is sadness, joy. O Divine Master,  
grant that I may not so much seek to be consoled as to console;  
to be understood, as to understand;  
to be loved, as to love;  
for it is in giving that we receive,  
it is in pardoning that we are pardoned,  
and it is in dying that we are born to eternal life. Amen.*

## **Application**

You will be blessed in special ways by using scripture and the words of prayers written and shared by others to communicate with God. Use your own words and enhance your conversation with God with the words of others!

Choose one of the prayers/scripture passages included in this lesson and pray it for the next week.

## “One Another” Body Life

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One thing that is true about the body of Christ is that we need one another!

Jesus said, “I give you a new commandment—to love one another. Just as I have loved you, you also are to love one another. Everyone will know by this that you are my disciples—if you have love for one another.”—John 13:34-35

Loving one another involves accepting, instructing, serving, bearing with, submitting to, and encouraging each other. We need each other to help us grow in our relationship with God. We need each other for encouragement. But ... we have a hard time getting along, let alone needing each other! God knows all about the difficulty we have at times with other people! We are tempted to gossip, judge, get angry, and accuse one another. We get annoyed. We get irritated. We get hurt. And yet, our heavenly Father truly desires for us to love one another ... and to model His love to the world. Here is what Jesus told His disciples in one of His last conversations with them: “I give you a new commandment—to love one another. Just as I have loved you, you also are to love one another. Everyone will know by this that you are my disciples—if you have love for one another.” —John 13:34-35

Love is the key to good relationships in the family of God ... but how do we get there? God gives us the answer in Paul’s letter to Timothy: “For God did not give us a Spirit of fear but of power and love and self-control.” —2 Timothy 1:7

Q. Look closely at this verse. Where does love come from?

Paul told the Corinthians what Christ’s love looks like when we are controlled by the Holy Spirit: “Love is patient, love is kind, it is not envious. Love does not brag, it is not puffed up. It is not rude, it is not self-serving, it is not easily angered or resentful. It is not glad about injustice, but rejoices in the truth. It bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things.” —1 Corinthians 13:4-7

Q. Which aspect of love described in this passage is already a part of your life?

Q. As you look at these verses, which characteristic of love are you lacking?

The Corinthian church in the New Testament was full of “baby” Christians. They had accepted Christ’s love for them, but they treated one another selfishly, which resulted in quarreling and jealousy (see 1 Corinthians 3:1-4). They needed to

learn how to love one another! Love is the key to good relationships in the family of God.

“One another” is mentioned more than thirty times in the Bible! God intends that we love each other, and the many facets of love are expressed in these “one another” commands. Loving “one another” involves several key actions: devotion, accepting, instructing, serving, bearing with, submitting to, and encouraging. When we are able to do these things, then we truly will be able to show the world that as Christians we love one another. This love is not an emotional here today gone tomorrow kind of love. It is a tough, strong, knowledgeable, and lasting commitment kind of love.

### **Devoted to One Another**

“Be devoted to one another with mutual love, showing eagerness in honoring one another.” —Romans 12:10

When we are devoted, we are loyal, faithful, and dedicated. As God’s family we show concern for one another and are loyal to each other. Because we are the family of God, we need to love each other as brothers and sisters in Christ.

Q. What kinds of actions do you think show that you are devoted to others?

### **Accept one Another**

“Receive one another, then, just as Christ also received you, to God’s glory.” —Romans 15:7

Romans 14:13 says, “Therefore we must not pass judgment on one another, but rather determine never to place an obstacle or a trap before a brother or sister.”

To accept one another is to receive each other willingly or to give admittance to or approval of someone. Because of the sacrifice Jesus made for each one of us, we need to accept one another as the unique individuals that God has created.

Q. What reasons do you have for not accepting others?

### **Instruct One Another**

“But I myself am fully convinced about you, my brothers and sisters, that you yourselves are full of goodness, filled with all knowledge, and able to instruct one another.” —Romans 15:14

Oh, how we don't like to have someone telling us what to do! Instruction implies teaching and learning ... and having someone tells us what to do!

Q. How are you at taking instruction? Are you gracious when you give it?

Q. Why is this mandate to instruct one another difficult within the body of Christ?

Q. How can you cultivate an open heart to the instruction from others?

## **Serve One Another**

Galatians 5:13 says, "Serve one another humbly in love" (NIV). As a member of God's family, with all its rights and privileges, every Christian is to be a servant to all the other members of the family. The needs of all those in the family are then met! Proud people use others; humble people are able to serve others.

Q. Is there a way you can serve someone this week?

Q. What happens to you when you serve someone?

## **Bearing with One Another**

"Bearing with one another and forgiving one another, if someone happens to have a complaint against anyone else. Just as the Lord has forgiven you, so you also forgive others." —Colossians 3:13

What does it mean to when Paul says, "bearing with one another"? If we look at this same phrase in a couple of different Bible translations, we'll get a very clear answer! The NLT says, "Make allowance for each other's faults" and the CEV puts it this way, "Put up with each other."

"To bear" means to patiently endure the idiosyncrasies and weaknesses of others! It means we have a forgiving spirit. Patience and a forgiving spirit are nearly synonymous concepts. These are not automatic; they involve a deliberate act of the will. When you are impatient, angry, and unforgiving, you are choosing to be that way! It is only through the Holy Spirit's supernatural power that we are able to bear with each other! It is only by the Holy Spirit's power that you will be able to take on all of these "one another" admonitions! You can't generate this kind of behavior on your own.

Q. What are some of the quirks and habits of others that irritate you?

Q. What are some of your idiosyncrasies that clearly test the patience of others?

Q. What one thing can you do today to take a step toward doing a better job of bearing with others?

### **Submit to One Another**

“Submitting to one another out of reverence for Christ.” —Ephesians 5:21

Submission is a very important yet often ignored Biblical teaching. The Bible is very clear that all Christians are to submit to one other. All Christians are to submit to their leaders, and servants are to submit to masters. Children are to submit to parents, and Christians are to submit to government and authority, and husbands and wives are to submit to each other.

This is amazing because in the world there is no such thing as mutual submission! It is uniquely Christian. Christ brought a whole new approach to functional relationships between people. Submission has to do with servanthood, humility, respect, reverence, honor, and willingness to be teachable. All of this is rooted in our individual submission and obedience to Christ.

Q. In what ways are you learning to submit to God?

Q. Who are you currently submitting to?

Q. What about this concept of submission is difficult for you?

Q. What is keeping you from obeying God in this area?

### **Encourage One Another**

1 Thessalonians 5:11 tells us, “Therefore encourage one another and build up each other, just as you are in fact doing.”

One of the ways we can encourage one another is by sharing scripture. We can also find many ways to build each other up. Ecclesiastes 4:9-10 says, “Two people are better than one, because they can reap more benefit from their labor. For if they fall, one will help his companion up, but pity the person who falls down and has no one to help him up.”

Q. Who in your life needs to be encouraged?

Q. How can you encourage that person?

Q. What can you do to make encouragement more of an everyday action in your life?

It is only by the Holy Spirit's power that you will be able to take on all of these "one another" admonitions! You can't generate this kind of behavior on your own. God's love and the actions that come out of it are only the result of the Holy Spirit working in and through you.

### **Application**

Q. Which one of the "one another" directives is easiest for you?

Q. Which one of the directives is most difficult?

Ask God to show you how you can be a more Spirit-filled member of His family.

## Live for Eternal Significance

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“Tell them to do good, to be rich in good deeds, to be generous givers, sharing with others. In this way they will save up a treasure for themselves as a firm foundation for the future and so lay hold of what is truly life.” —1 Timothy 6:18-19

True faith involves knowledge and conviction of God’s saving grace and then acting on that knowledge. Doing good, being generous, and being willing to share are the fruits of true faith. They are an outgrowth of the seed of faith, just as an ear of corn is the outgrowth of a kernel of corn planted in the soil. Conviction moves us to do the good works that God has planned ahead for us to do as we walk on the path of faith. As God transforms us by the renewing of our minds, we will find ourselves transformed from being “getters” to becoming givers. As we become givers, we will be progressively more concerned with fulfilling kingdom objectives. Giving results in our laying up treasure in heaven.

When we fully understand the reality of this principle, we truly begin to accomplish great things for God’s kingdom! Businessman Phil Wiegand calls this kingdom approach to life “KingdomNomics.” KingdomNomics involves defining life from God’s point of view, as communicated to us through the Bible. This perspective helps us to determine how we invest our time, talent, and treasure in those things that will last forever.

The promise of eternal reward is a motivating factor as we consider the impact of what we do in this world. The decisions we make here on earth will echo into eternity.

### **Become More**

In what ways are you able to use your time, talent, and treasure to echo into eternity? Is this a new concept for you? Think about some ways you can deposit to your bank account in heaven.

### **Further Reflections**

“Because we are not looking at what can be seen but at what cannot be seen. For what can be seen is temporary, but what cannot be seen is eternal.” —2 Corinthians 4:18



“Therefore, if you have been raised with Christ, keep seeking the things above, where Christ is, seated at the right hand of God.” —Colossians 3:1

[This article is from [KingdomNomics.com](http://KingdomNomics.com) by Phil Wiegand]